HT MUMBAI, NEW DELHI, BENGALURU, KOLKATA, CHENNAI, AHMEDABAD, HYDERABAD, PUNE* VOL. 9 NO. 84

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mint

Think Ahead. Think Growth.

mint primer

Now, a new covid strain. Should that worry us?

BY JESSICA JANI

The covid-19 virus continues to mutate. A new strain, BA.3.2, has now surfaced in many countries. Early reports show high spike-protein mutations that could help it enter human cells. Global experts urge for caution but no panic. Should you be concerned? *Mint* breaks it down.

AFP

1 What is this new covid variant about?

The latest variant is a part of the Omicron strain that swept across the globe late 2021. BA.3.2 was first detected in 2024 in South Africa but was dormant until now, causing it to be dubbed 'cicada', an insect that stays underground for long before popping up. It has unusually more spike protein mutations than LP.8.1, the basis for the 2025-26 vaccines. Spike mutations influence how transmissible a virus is, and how well it can evade immunity from prior infections or vaccines. The US Centers for Disease Control said BA.3.2 is a "highly divergent" variant. However, the sub-variant is still being assessed.

2 Where has this covid strain been detected?

As per the CDC, the sub-variant was reported in 23 countries as of 11 February. More cases were reported last week, and it has since been found in 29 US states and Puerto Rico, parts of Europe, and in travellers entering the US from Japan, Kenya, the Netherlands, and the UK. Symptoms are similar to those of recent Omicron sub-variants, reports say, with patients having fever, sore throat, fatigue, headache, a runny nose and cough. In the US, the first case was detected on 27 June 2025 in CDC's traveller-based genomic surveillance in a traveller from The Netherlands. Detections rose from September, the CDC said.

REUTERS

3 What do global agencies have to say on the virus?

The World Health Organization's vaccine composition group has flagged it for discussion at its May meeting. BA.3.2 is a "variant under monitoring" but not yet a "variant of concern" or even a "variant of interest", it says. Public health groups have called for serious attention but no panic. Experts say vaccines give strong protection, even as the virus evolves.

4 What were the earlier variant mutations like?

Since the virus first emerged in 2019, it has seen several mutations. Its evolving variants—Alpha, Delta, and most significantly, Omicron—shaped the pandemic's course. The virus mutates as it replicates, and most changes are either neutral or detrimental to it. Occasionally, a mutation gives the virus a higher transmissibility that can lead to new waves of infection. For instance, JN.1, a descendant of Omicron BA.2.86, drove infection waves in 2023- 24, although it did not show evidence of causing more severe disease symptoms.

5 So, should you be worried over BA.3.2?

Experts say there's no reason for immediate concern. New variants are expected, and most do not lead to significant changes in public health risk. This variant is being monitored to check if it spreads faster, causes severe illness, or significantly reduces vaccine effectiveness. At this point, current vaccines appear to be working as intended for the variant. It has not yet been widely reported or detected in India. But, as with the previous variants, authorities worldwide have stepped up monitoring and surveillance.

QUICK EDIT

Ease GST on phones

Smartphone makers in India have raised prices by as much as 40%, according to a *Mint* report, as the war in West Asia and a chip scarcity push up costs. The increases appear to be industry-wide, with brands such as Vivo, Oppo and Samsung, among others, raising their price tags. Ordinarily, this should not attract the attention of policy-makers. But these handsets are fast turning indispensable at every socio-economic level, needed as they are for internet access, UPI payments, Aadhaar identity verification and a whole lot more. The dream of AI diffusion to uplift those at the bottom of India's income pyramid also depends on smartphone affordability. As of now, the country subsidizes their production through an incentive scheme for manufacturers. But smartphone purchases bear a GST burden of 18%. Given how quickly they are becoming essential items, India should consider offering buyers tax relief; a GST rate of 5% could make them more affordable and help revive flagging demand in this once-booming market. This is not just another consumption category. These devices are tickets to better lives and livelihoods. They mustn't get priced out of people's reach.

QUOTE OF THE DAY

Food security is of paramount importance. In the present global situation, dependence on other countries for food is unacceptable. We must become self-reliant.

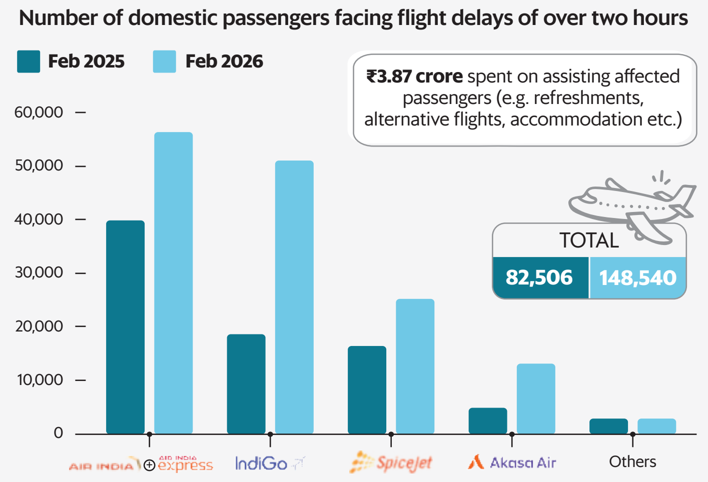
SHIVRAJ SINGH CHOUHAN
AGRICULTURE MINISTER

INSIDE

mint | DATA BITES

LONG FLIGHT DELAYS HIT MORE PASSENGERS IN FEB 2026

Nearly 150,000 domestic passengers were hit by flight delays exceeding two hours in February, up 80% year-on-year, with IndiGo seeing the sharpest rise in percentage terms.



Data: Rupanjal Chauhan; Graphic: Prateek Kumar

Source: Directorate General of Civil Aviation

COLUMNS

mint

PLAIN FACTS

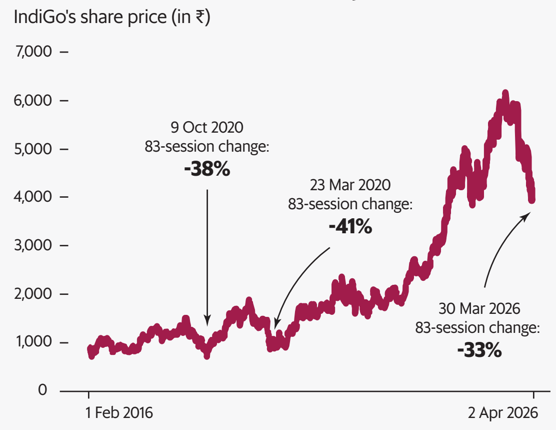
CAN INDIGO FLY OUT OF THIS PERFECT STORM?

BY HOWINDIALIVES.COM

The past four months have been a stretch of severe turbulence for IndiGo, with India's largest airline hitting one air pocket after another. In early December, it was caught off guard by its approach to new domestic regulations that curtailed and staggered pilots' flying hours, forcing widespread flight cancellations. Then came the US attack on Iran, setting off a chain reaction across oil prices, West Asia aviation, and the rupee's exchange rate against the dollar—all variables central to IndiGo's business. As it heads into the peak summer season, the airline has significant course correction ahead if it is to return to the steady glide path it has long been known for.

The IndiGo stock has lost 33% since late November, a scale seen only twice before

IndiGo's share price (in ₹)



The legal entity that runs IndiGo is InterGlobe Aviation Ltd.

Source: BSE mint

WINNING INVESTORS

NOWHERE IS the strain more visible than in the share price of InterGlobe Aviation Ltd, IndiGo's parent company. Over the past 83 trading sessions, from 27 November 2025, the stock has declined about 33%. The selloff began in early December, when IndiGo ran short of pilots under the new regulations and was forced to cancel a large number of flights, and subsequently cut its domestic schedule by roughly 10%.

Since listing in November 2015, IndiGo has seen comparable sell-offs only twice. The first was during the covid pandemic in 2020, when the global aviation industry ground to a halt. The second came in late 2018, when the airline was headed for its first annual loss after eight consecutive years of net profit, an outlier in Indian aviation.

In both instances, the recovery was sharp: over the subsequent six months, the stock rose 45% in 2020 and 95% in 2019.

PRESERVING PROFITABILITY

AS BUSINESS problems go, the covid pandemic was relatively straightforward—the sector was shut, but reopening was a matter of time. The 2018-19 episode, by contrast, was about managing expansion without sacrificing profitability. This time it is more complex on three counts.

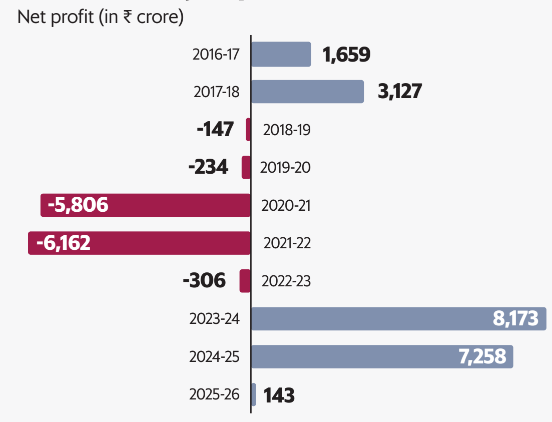
First, IndiGo is a far larger operation now; its revenues are almost 3x those of 2018-19. Yet profitability is under strain, and the airline is likely to post a loss in 2025-26.

Second, it faces multiple challenges at once. It has to ramp-up pilot hiring, reclaim lost domestic market share, and manage higher costs—all while continuing to take delivery of new aircraft, as it has committed to.

Third, several key variables remain outside its control: geopolitics, crude prices, and currency movements. The airline is firmly in damage-control mode. Pieter Elbers, who was CEO during the December disruption, has exited. Last week, IndiGo named Willie Walsh as his successor. He previously led British Airways.

After two immensely profitable years, IndiGo is likely to post a loss in 2025-26

Net profit (in ₹ crore)

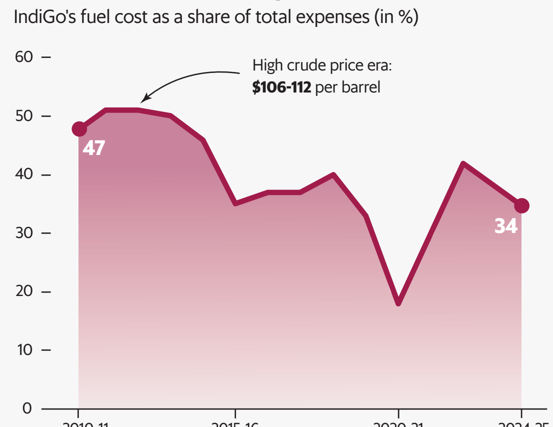


Data for 2025-26 for Apr-Dec 2025.

Source: IndiGo financial statements mint

Fuel made up half of IndiGo's costs during FY12-FY14 when crude prices were above $100

IndiGo's fuel cost as a share of total expenses (in %)



Source: IndiGo financial statements mint

CRUDE DYNAMICS

THE BIGGEST external shock comes from oil prices, which have surged after the US and Israel attacked Iran. According to the government-run Petroleum Planning & Analysis Cell, the average price of India's crude basket jumped from around $69 per barrel in February to $121 per barrel in April. Data from the International Air Transport Association for the week ended 27 March show jet fuel prices doubling compared with a month earlier.

For airlines, fuel is the single largest cost. In 2023-24 and 2024-25, when crude oil prices were steady and IndiGo posted strong profits, fuel accounted for 34-38% of its total expenses. Prices started soaring in March. The Indian government has also not passed on the full effect of prices for domestic usage, containing the impact on IndiGo's 2025-26 numbers. But if prices don't drop, IndiGo, like all airlines, will struggle.

In the three financial years from 2011-12 to 2013-14, when average crude prices ranged from $106-112 per barrel, fuel expenses accounted for about 50% of IndiGo's expenses.

DOLLAR DIPS

INDIGO POSTED a net profit margin of 8.6% in 2024–25. With fuel accounting for 34% of total expenses that year, any increase in prices is bound to weigh on margins—the extent of the rise will determine the impact.

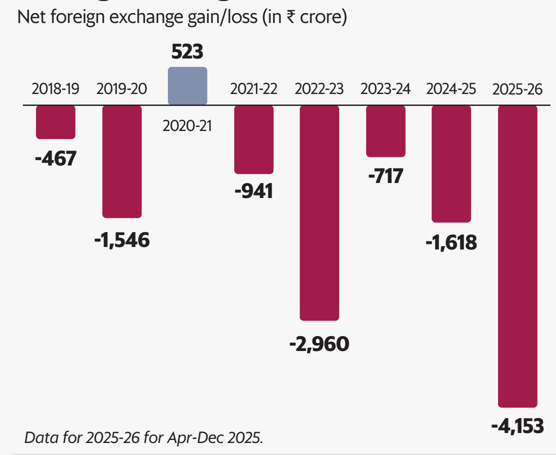
Another pressure point is the rupee's movement against the dollar. Even as IndiGo expands globally, its financial base remains largely rupee-denominated.

For example, in 2024-25, it received payments amounting to ₹14,426 crore in foreign currencies—principally from tickets sold to travellers coming from foreign destinations to India. But it also made payments of ₹29,872 crore—nearly twice as much—in foreign currencies. In a scenario where the rupee is depreciating, it effectively has to pay that much more.

IndiGo does enter into financial contracts to align payments to the exchange rate, but it can also suffer losses on such contracts. For the nine months till December, this was a significant drag, and a persistent slide in the rupee could deepen the impact.

A sliding rupee means IndiGo might be looking at its largest forex loss in 2025-26

Net foreign exchange gain/loss (in ₹ crore)

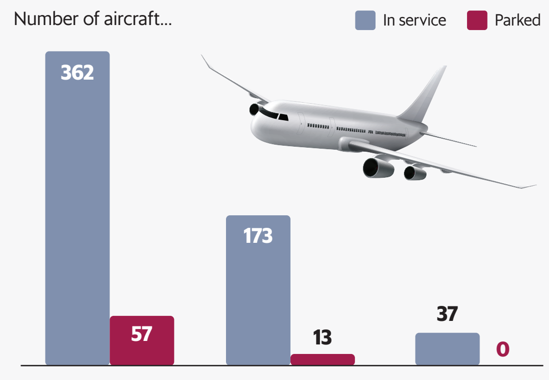


Data for 2025-26 for Apr-Dec 2025.

Source: IndiGo financial statements mint

About 14% of IndiGo's fleet is currently inactive, more than Air India and Akasa

Number of aircraft...



Data as of 5 April 2026.

Source: Planespotters.net mint

PRATEEK KUMAR/MINT

FLEET EFFICIENCY

CONFRONTED WITH challenges, IndiGo has been combative. At its January analyst meet, before the US-Iran war exacerbated matters , it was sparing with details on pilot hiring and potential flight cutbacks. The summer domestic schedule, released last month by the aviation regulator, showed 10% fewer flights than in summer 2025, underscoring IndiGo's constraints on expansion.

IndiGo has been hiring pilots, but getting them airborne takes time. It has turned to 'damp leases' with foreign airlines, leasing plane and pilots, but not cabin crew. It has more planes grounded than other leading airlines, due to engine-supplier issues, and, possibly, pilot availability. The airline also remains committed to taking delivery of new aircraft. IndiGo has the cash, about ₹52,000 crore, it has said, to "navigate short-term challenges while investing confidently in long-term growth". Managing all this will be a fine balancing act.

www.howindialives.com is a database and search engine for public data

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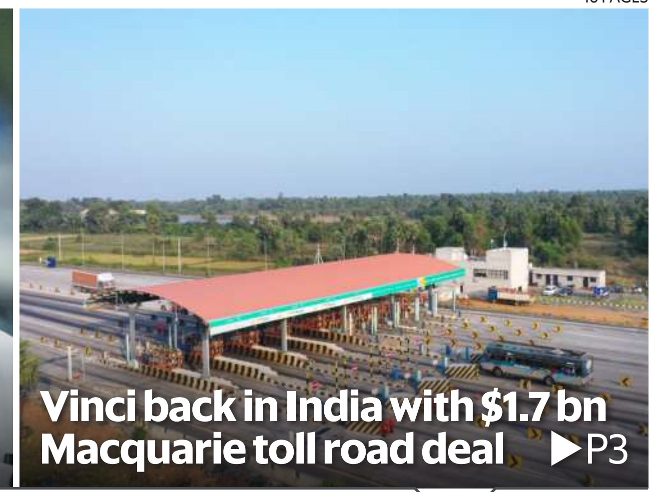
Assam poll: Welfare and infra hog the limelight ▶P10



Vinci back in India with $1.7 bn Macquarie toll road deal ▶P3

SENSEX 74,616.56 ↑ 509.71 | NIFTY 23,123.65 ↑ 155.4 | DOLLAR ₹93.06 ↑ ₹0.16 | EURO ₹107.51 ↓ ₹0.01 | OIL $107.36 ↑ $1.04 | POUND ₹123.35 ↓ ₹0.07

Data centre surge to spark change in electricity plans

CEA to write to states, discoms on resource plans as several states ready data centres

Rituraj Baruah
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NEW DELHI

India's apex power sector planning body has gone back to the drawing board to map electricity demand amid concerns that a concentration of data centres coming up in a few states could skew consumption and adversely affect national grid stability.

The Central Electricity Authority (CEA) will also ask states and power distribution companies to incorporate the power demand projections of data centres in their resource adequacy plans, said two people aware of the developments. The data centre hubs are expected to lead to a surge in electricity demand, significantly changing the demand profile of the host states and possibly impacting grid stability.

Adding the projected electricity consumption of data centres in the resource adequacy plans of states is aimed at ensuring there is sufficient power generation, storage and transmission capacity to meet consumer demand.

The government expects to attract $200 billion of investments in data centres and artificial intelligence (AI) infrastructure by 2030, with their capacity projected to surge from about 1.2 gigawatts (GW) in 2025 to 10GW and their electricity consumption estimated to reach 40-45 terawatt hours (TWh) by the end of the decade, up from 10-15 TWh consumed in 2024.

One terawatt hour is equivalent to using 1 trillion watts of electricity continuously for one hour. A standard LED bulb uses about 10 watts.

Large data centres are expected to come up in Andhra Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra, Telangana, Karnataka and Tamil Nadu. Companies that have committed to invest in India's AI space include Microsoft, Amazon, Alphabet, the Adani Group, Reliance Industries, the AM Group and Larsen and Toubro.

REUTERS

POWER PLAYBOOK

DATA DANCE

CEA to ask states and cos, data centres power projections

DATA centre hubs to see changed power demand profile

GOVT eyes $200 bn bets on data centres and AI infra by 2030

"The CEA is working on demand projections for data centres and will add the requirement for estimation of data centre demand in resource adequacy plans," one of the two people said.

A resource adequacy plan estimates the quantum and type of energy resources required to meet power demand at the least possible cost. The plan assesses annual power generation capacity, including from conventional and renewable sources, storage capacities, reserve margins and costs. According to the guidelines for resource adequacy planning, the exercise must have a horizon of 10 years on a rolling basis.

Spokespersons of the power ministry and the CEA did not respond to queries emailed by *Mint* till press time.

The parliamentary standing committee on energy, which submitted its report to the Lok Sabha last month, noted that India's current data centre load of about 1.2GW is projected to increase to 13.6GW by 2032 and 16.4GW by 2040.

The power ministry informed the parliamentary panel that an increase in electricity demand on account of rapid growth of AI and other large-scale data centres and

TURN TO PAGE 6

Sebi grants more time for IPOs as volatility spikes

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The capital markets regulator has extended the approvals granted to companies seeking to go public, as volatility triggered by the West Asia war has prompted many of them to reconsider the timing of their offerings.

Observation letters expiring between 1 April and 30 September 2026 will now remain valid until 30 September 2026, the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) said in a circular issued on Tuesday.

An observation letter indicates that the regulator has reviewed the proposal, suggested the required changes to ensure compliance, and has allowed the company to launch the issue.

Sebi's one-time extension of the deadline is subject to the lead manager's undertaking to comply with regulatory requirements when submitting updated offer documents.

Volatile markets and slowing capital flows due to the US-Iran war have forced several companies to defer or recalibrate their initial public offering (IPO) plans. *Mint* reported on 25 March that global uncertainty had put about ₹18,000 crore of planned fundraising at risk.

Sebi rules require companies to launch IPOs within a year of receiving final approvals. REUTERS

The regulator's extended deadline comes as a relief to 13 mainboard companies that are nearing their 12-month deadlines to launch their issues by June.

These include the Munjal family's ₹3,600-crore offer for Hero Fincorp Ltd, Morgan Stanley-backed Continuum Green Energy Ltd's ₹3,650-crore IPO, and Norwest Venture Partners-backed Veritas Finance Ltd's proposed ₹2,800-crore IPO, according to Prime Database.

Sebi's move "enables issuers to better assess market conditions and strategically time their IPO launches amid heightened volatility and subdued sentiment", said Mahavir

TURN TO PAGE 4

DON'T MISS

Savills picks majority stake in Hotelivate to expand in Apac

The Indian unit of Savills Plc, a UK real estate adviser, has acquired a majority interest in Hotelivate to expand its hospitality advisory services across the Asia-Pacific (Apac) region, the London-based company said in a statement on Tuesday. >P3

Air India begins search for a new CEO after Wilson quits

Air India has kicked off the search for a new CEO after Campbell Wilson's decision to step down, announcing it formed a committee to identify his successor. *Mint* reported Monday that Wilson stepped down amid mounting losses and operational headwinds. >P5

Trump warns Iran again, says a 'whole civilization will die'

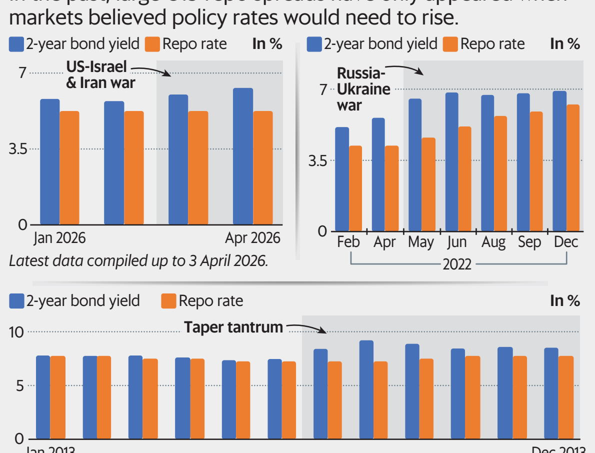
Airstrikes hit two bridges and a train station in Iran on Tuesday as US president Donald Trump warned that a "whole civilization will die tonight" if Tehran does not meet his latest deadline to agree to a deal that includes reopening the crucial Strait of Hormuz. >P8

New company registrations up 31% as AI branding rises

India's formal economy is expanding rapidly, led by technology and trade businesses, with AI emerging as a branding and business driver. MCA data shows IT companies and wholesale and retail trade firms topped new company registrations in FY26. >P7

Street signals

In the past, large OIS-repo spreads have only appeared when markets believed policy rates would need to rise.



Latest data compiled up to 3 April 2026.

For yields average for month was considered.
Source: Bloomberg

mint

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

Street sees future rate hikes while RBI readies pause

Abhinaba Saha & Subhana Shaikh
MUMBAI

Markets are signalling a sharp divergence from the Reserve Bank of India's expected policy pause on 8 April, with traders in the Overnight Index Swap (OIS) market pricing in an aggressive rate-hike cycle over the coming months.

That divergence is feeding into the real economy. Surging crude oil prices and the war in West Asia have pushed up borrowing costs across the economy as lenders and investors factor in higher future interest rates.

The OIS market, where traders position for future interest rates, reflects expectations of the RBI's policy path. A rise in the one-year OIS signals expectations of higher rates over the next year.

In practice, banks and bond markets use these expectations to price loans and debt, meaning higher OIS rates translate into higher borrowing costs, even without an actual rate hike.

Those expectations have strengthened. The one-year OIS is now around 6.18%, well above the repo rate of 5.25%. The spread has hovered around 90-115 basis points (bps) for a month—higher than the usual 50 bps—implying anticipations of at least three rate hikes over the coming year, with each hike typically sized at 25 bps.

"The OIS curve is showing expectations of two to three rate hikes, largely factoring in higher crude prices and rupee depreciation," said V.R.C. Reddy, treasury head at Karur Vysya Bank.

The rupee has fallen nearly 5% since the war began on 28 February and 11% in FY26, hitting a record low of 95.125 per dollar on 30 March. It currently trades at 92.92.

Suyash Choudhary, chief investment officer for fixed income at Bandhan AMC, said markets have swung quickly from expecting lower rates for longer to pricing in multiple hikes, partly reflecting positioning and risk management

TURN TO PAGE 6

Tata Trusts CEO defends action after Srinivasan, Singh cry foul

Varun Sood & Satish John
BENGALURU/MUMBAI

Tata Trusts chief executive officer (CEO) Siddharth Sharma on Tuesday defended his position on the controversy surrounding the Bai Hirabai Jamsetji Tata trust, writing to all 12 members of Tata Trusts, after facing accusations that he had concealed a legal opinion on trusteeship.

TVS chair emeritus Venu Srinivasan and former defence secretary Vijay Singh have accused Sharma of asking them to resign from the trust, an affiliate of the Tata philanthropic entities. Sharma's alleged action came after Mehli Mistry, who was ousted from Tata Trusts last year, challenged their eligibility to be trustees, stating they are neither Zoroastrians nor do they live in Mumbai—conditions Mistry says are necessary to be a trustee. Srinivasan stepped down, while Singh didn't. On Monday, both of them accused Sharma of bias, stating that while Sharma asked them to quit, he did not share with them a 26-year-old legal opinion rebutting the eligibility condition.

Tata Trusts chief executive Siddharth Sharma.

Sharma, who took over as CEO of Tata Trusts in April 2023, defended his action. In a letter on Tuesday, he said he and Tata Trusts chair Noel Tata believed that the legal opinion—which effectively supports the continuance of Srinivasan and Singh on the Bai Hirabai trust—did not substitute for a court order; and, to avoid a potential dispute, they decided to ask Srinivasan and Singh if they wanted to voluntarily step down.

Following this, Sharma said, he shared this view with Singh and Srinivasan on 2 April. Notably, this was a day before Mistry sought a probe by the Maharashtra Charity Commissioner, highlighting the restrictive clauses. *Mint* has seen Sharma's letter to all 11 trustees of Tata Trusts where he sought to clarify his position.

"I was also informed that Mr. Vijay Singh and Mr. Venu Srinivasan were the only two Trustees on the said Trust who did not meet these criteria," Sharma wrote in a letter dated 7 April to Tata Trusts chair Noel Tata and 11 other Trustees. *Mint* has seen a copy of the letter.

"I, thereafter, discussed this with the Chairman, Tata Trusts on April 02, 2026, and both of us felt that irrespective of the

TURN TO PAGE 6

Tatas' battery bet Agratas raises $730 mn from banks

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As the Tata Group ramps up its new energy bets, its battery arm Agratas Energy Storage Solutions Pvt. Ltd raised over $730 million from a clutch of banks in 2025, taking the total funding from lenders and parent Tata Sons' equity infusion to nearly $900 million. The funding push highlights the capital intensity and execution phase ahead of commercial operations.

Tatas' lithium ion cell arm secured the loans between January and December 2025 from banks including Axis Bank, DBS Bank, Hong Kong and Shanghai Banking Corp and Standard Chartered Bank, with an average interest rate of 5.25% and a payback period of nearly three years, *Mint*'s review of the company's filings with the corporate affairs ministry revealed.

Agratas is the latest Tata firm to close in on $1 billion funding for its project, with the group's three other new ventures Air India, Tata Digital and Tata Electronics having already crossed $1 billion infusion from the parent firm.

Loans were secured between Jan and Dec 2025. BLOOMBERG

Mint had reported on 7 November that investments into Air India, Tata Digital and Tata Electronics had crossed a cumulative $11 billion.

Under chairman Natarajan Chandrasekaran, the conglomerate has used dividend income from flagship Tata Consultancy Services Ltd to finance new businesses, including aviation (Air India), e-commerce (Tata Digital), iPhone assembly for Apple, a semiconductor business (Tata Electronics), and battery manufacturing (Agratas).

However, unlike Air India, Tata Digital and Tata Electronics, which have drawn large infusions from Tata Sons, Agratas is relying more on bank funding, pointing to a more asset-backed, lower-equity approach.

Agratas' funding is largely being sourced through banks, with the company pledging all its movable assets to secure some of the loans. To lower its borrowing costs, the firm has taken the Gift City route for its large dollar-denominated loans.

This approach also reflects the strain of funding other new

TURN TO PAGE 4

AI funding boom pulls Big Four deeper into startup scrutiny

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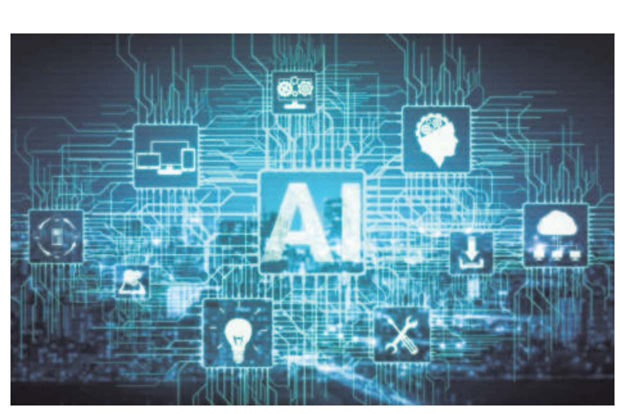
When Raunak Bhinge first approached institutional investors seeking funding for Infinite Uptime, the pitch was straightforward: much of India's factory equipment was still analogue, and digitising it could help manufacturers improve output. Over time, the venture pivoted from being seen as a software startup to proving it was an artificial intelligence (AI)-backed business built on proprietary industrial data and models refined over years of deployments.

"Investor due diligence has become deeper over the years as we raised funding," said Bhinge, whose venture has raised over $60 million since inception. "There is still a bit of analysis paralysis even now."

That is widening the circle of people pulled in to conduct diligence, from outside specialists to the Big Four advisory firms such as PwC and Deloitte. While they were always part of deal scrutiny, it was mostly for financial diligence, tech and cybersecurity reviews. AI has changed that playbook. Investors also want to know how the data is sourced, how models were trained, how reliable the outputs are, and whether customers are seeing real value.

Increased diligence coincides with growing investor interest in AI startups, as the technology threatens to disrupt traditional models and the software-as-a-service (Saas) model. Indian AI ventures raised $832 million in 2025, with another $633 million flowing in during the first quarter of 2026 alone, according to Tracxn data.



Diligence coincides with investor interest. ISTOCKPHOTO

Blackstone in February led a more than $1 billion investment in Neysa, while Emergent raised $70 million a month earlier. Sarvam AI is also reportedly in talks for a $200-250 million round from investors including Nvidia Corp, Bessemer Venture Partners and HCL Technologies Ltd.

Elevation Capital, which has invested in nearly 30 AI companies over the past four years, now "routinely" brings in third parties and, wherever needed, works with Big Four firms on deal-specific reviews.

"AI has shifted venture diligence away from just asking typical SaaS-era focus go-to-market efficiency questions to more towards a deeper focus on product and engineering capability," said Krishna Mehra, an AI partner at Elevation Capital.

For Bharat Innovation Fund (BIF), which has backed deep-tech and AI startups since 2018, the main challenge is not just that AI startups require a new technical lens, but their numbers have surged.

BIF has screened more than 6,000 AI startups, narrowed that to over 500, and held deeper discussions with roughly 300-400 of them, said Somshubhro Choudhury, co-founder and partner at the fund. He said diligence has become harder because investors are struggling to tell genuinely differentiated products from thin wrappers built on existing AI models.

Choudhury said founders are now asked to explain the full stack, how workflows are split into tasks, which models are being called and how the

TURN TO PAGE 6

India to launch 20 maritime reforms to cut logistics costs

Reform push aimed at improving regulatory oversight, enhancing ease of doing business

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The ministry of ports, shipping and waterways is preparing to roll out about 20 sectoral reforms in the first 90 days of FY27, including the creation of a maritime sector regulator, revamped shipbuilding incentives and measures to increase India's shipping tonnage, as part of a plan to strengthen the country's maritime ecosystem and cut logistics costs.

The reform push, being finalized, is aimed at improving regulatory oversight, boosting domestic shipbuilding, increasing the share of Indian-flagged vessels in global trade and enhancing the ease of doing business across ports, shipping and inland waterways, two people aware of the matter said.

"Reform measures like a dedicated maritime regulator, stronger support for shipbuilding and container manufacturing, and a push toward inland waterways and coastal shipping are especially impactful. They not only build domestic capacity but also make logistics more cost-effective and sustainable," said Pushpank Kaushik, CEO and head of business development at Jassper Shipping, a global shipping and logistics company in Hyderabad.

Currently, less than 5% of India's export-import cargo is carried by Indian-owned ships and an even smaller share of these vessels are built domestically. This results in a significant foreign exchange outgo of almost $75 billion each year to foreign shipowners for freight services.

5%
Export-import cargo carried by Indian-owned ships

A key proposal under consideration is the setting up of a strengthened maritime regulator by expanding the role of the Directorate General of Shipping, which would be given wider powers over safety regulation, maritime training, ship registration and oversight of shipping operations. The move is aimed at creating a modern regulator in line with global maritime nations. The DG Shipping will be rechristened as the Directorate General of Maritime Administration.

The ministry is working on revamped shipbuilding guidelines and a new framework to promote shipbuilding clusters in India, with the aim of increasing domestic capacity and reducing dependence on foreign yards. India has set a long-term target of becoming one of the top shipbuilding nations by 2047. The Shipbuilding Financial Assistance Policy update would aim at encouraging public sector units to form joint ventures for owning and operating Indian-built vessels.

$75 bn
Annual forex payments to foreign shipowners

Officials said the government is looking to operationalize the proposed Maritime Development Fund, a ₹25,000 financing facility aimed at providing long-term, low-cost funding for shipbuilding and maritime infrastructure. The fund is expected to play a key role in supporting domestic shipyards and encouraging fleet expansion by Indian shipping companies.

Queries mailed to the shipping ministry remained unanswered till press time.

The reform package will include policy measures to increase the number of Indian-flagged ships, including changes in tax, financing and regulatory norms, to make it more attractive for shipowners to register vessels in India rather than in foreign jurisdictions.

"Shipping is global, capital-intensive and tightly regulated, so without consistent reforms, inefficiencies and higher costs can quickly creep in. What these changes do is create a more stable and predictable environment where businesses can operate with greater clarity and confidence," said Kaushik.

The reform push is part of the government's maritime strategy under the Sagarmala programme and the Maritime Amrit Kaal Vision 2047, which aim to modernize ports. The coastal cargo promotion scheme proposed in Budget 2026-27 will be launched with the aim of doubling the share of coastal shipping and inland waterways from 6% to 12% by 2047.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com


The reform push is part of the government's maritime strategy under the Sagarmala programme and the Maritime Amrit Kaal Vision 2047. BLOOMBERG


The government is considering opinions on IT rules. ISTOCKPHOTO

'Govt not intending to treat creators as publishers'

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NEW DELHI

The government does not intend to treat influencers and independent content creators on social media platforms as publishers, and is openly considering opinions to tweak, clarify various clauses and even repeal a draft amendment to India's social media intermediary rules, a top bureaucrat said at a press roundtable in the ministry of electronics and IT (Meity)'s office.

Through Tuesday, Meity secretary S Krishnan met stakeholders of India's internet and social media industry, public policy and civil society advocates, and the media at Electronics Niketan, Meity's home turf. The consensus at the end of the day, Krishnan said, is to extend the amendment's public consultation timeline and take into account all views the ministry received on Tuesday.

Multiple parties have voiced their concerns about how the amendment will work, he said. "Some parties have raised a view that there is no need for this amendment and it should be entirely done away with, while others have raised concerns around specific clauses of the amendment to be clarified." Some stakeholders have asked for the public consultation phase to be extended by two weeks or more; a decision will be taken about this, he added.

Published on 30 March, the draft second amendment to the Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021—popularly referred to as IT Rules—proposed that any clarification, advisory or notice issued by the government will need to be complied with.

Further, the amendment proposed bringing general users who independently create and post content on social media platforms under the same lens of scrutiny as news publishing houses, in terms of the ministry of information and broadcasting's ability to block such users publishing 'news and current affairs' content.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Skymet sees below normal monsoon rainfall in 2026

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NEW DELHI


There is a 40% chance of rains being 'below normal' this year.

Private weather forecasting agency Skymet on Tuesday projected a below normal South-West monsoon for 2026, estimating rainfall at 94% (with a 5% margin of error) of the long-period average (LPA) of 868.6 mm for the June-September season.

The private forecaster's January outlook had already flagged a subpar monsoon, with the state-run India Meteorological Department (IMD) set to issue its first official 2026 forecast later this month.

"After a year and a half of La Nina conditions, the Pacific Ocean has turned favourable for ENSO-neutral. Equatorial Pacific ocean-atmosphere coupling is now stronger than before. El Niño is expected during the early phase of the southwest monsoon and will continue to grow stronger until the fall of the year. El Niño return may presage a weaker monsoon," said Jatin Singh, managing director, Skymet.

The second half of the season may be more erratic, he added.

Skymet expects the core monsoon rainfed zone of central and western India to witness inadequate rainfall. Punjab, Haryana and Rajasthan are likely to receive less than normal rainfall, especially during August-September. The eastern and northeastern parts will be placed better than the rest of the country.

There is a 30% probability of 'drought' and a 40% chance of rains being 'below normal' this year, the weather agency said.

Mrutyunjay Mohapatra, director general of meteorology, IMD, declined to comment. India received 108% rainfall of the LPA in 2025 against Skymet's prediction of a normal monsoon at around 103% (with a 5% margin of error) of the LPA and the IMD's initial projection of 105% of the LPA.

The South-West monsoon accounts for nearly 70% of India's annual rainfall, playing a key role in food security, sustaining livelihoods, and supporting overall economic growth. With only about 55% of the net sown area irrigated, agriculture, which employs 46% of the population and accounts for about 16% of gross domestic product, remains heavily dependent on monsoon rains.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

GeM opens door for overseas sellers to bid for govt orders

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NEW DELHI

Government e-Marketplace (GeM) has introduced a global tender enquiry feature, enabling overseas suppliers to participate in government bids, as India seeks to leverage free trade agreements (FTAs) such as the one with the UK to boost cross-border commerce, its chief executive officer (CEO) Mihir Kumar said.

The public procurement platform now supports multi-currency bidding, and is tightening oversight of listings and seller behaviour using data analytics, even as transactions in FY26 fell due to a decline in procurement by the ministry of coal amid lower demand for mine development and operations services.

"The global tender enquiry functionality has been created to cater to buyer requirements and also in the context of FTAs such as with the UK, where UK suppliers can access the domestic market and Indian sellers can explore opportunities in the UK market," Kumar told Mint in an interview. "We studied the rules and regulations governing global tender inquiry and developed this functionality so that overseas sellers can interact with the portal, register, and participate in bidding."


Mihir Kumar, CEO of Government e-Marketplace.

The Government e-Marketplace (GeM) enhances transparency in public procurement by digitising the entire process, standardising bidding procedures, enabling real-time price discovery through competitive tools like e-bidding and reverse auctions, and creating complete digital audit trails that significantly reduce human discretion and opportunities for corruption. Participation in government procurement often features in bilateral trade negotiations because it opens access to large public-sector markets.

The gross merchandise value (GMV) on the GeM portal fell 7.4% to ₹5.03 trillion in FY26, from ₹5.43 trillion in FY25.

"There is a degrowth of 7.4% in FY26 with respect to FY 24-25 due to the absence of unique/ sporadic procurement. However, the cumulative GMV of ₹18.4 lakh crore (since its inception in 2016) reflects the sustained confidence of buyers, sellers and institutions in a transparent and technology-driven ecosystem improving public procurement. GeM continues to enable efficient and inclusive procurement at scale," Kumar said.

Gross merchandise value refers to the total value of all goods and services procured through the platform over a given period.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Reefer shortage may hit mango exports

Vijay C Roy & Manas Pimpalkhare
NEW DELHI

A shortage of refrigerated containers (reefers) caused by the West Asia war is worrying Indian growers of mangoes ahead of the peak export season, according to five people aware of the development.

With the war in its second month, key maritime routes, including the Strait of Hormuz and the Red Sea, have been disrupted, leading to container shortages and higher freight costs. Many containers are stuck in transit due to congestion or are being re-routed, leading to longer shipment cycles.

This poses a unique problem for India, which produces 20.68 million tonnes, or 44%, of the world's mangoes annually, the most by any country. India has been trying to increase mango exports vis-a-vis China, which ships out more mangoes, including Indian varieties such as Dasheri, Chausa, Alphonso and Langra.

The UAE is top destination for Indian mangoes. The Gulf countries including Saudi Arabia, Kuwait and Qatar account for 40-45% of India's total mango exports. Trade with these nations has been hit by Iran's blockade of the Strait of Hormuz.

Many containers are stuck in transit due to congestion or are being re-routed, leading to longer shipment cycles

Refrigerated containers are critical for transporting perishable commodities such as mangoes, which need to be stored at temperatures of 11-18°C to maintain quality. However, delays and difficulties in repositioning containers have made it harder for Indian exporters to secure adequate capacity.


Delays and difficulties in repositioning containers have made it harder for Indian exporters to secure adequate capacity. HT

Queries sent to agriculture and commerce ministries remained unanswered.

Refrigerated container charges went up by about $1,000 in March. Additionally, refrigerated container charges now include a $4,000 levy—about four times the usual freight cost to West Asia—making exports economically unviable.

Exporters said delays in getting reefers could lead to spoilage and financial losses, especially for premium varieties such as Alphonso, Kesar and Banganapalli, which are in high demand. A prolonged disruption could affect export volumes and earnings, while also impacting farmers who depend on overseas markets for better price realization.

"Any decline in purchasing power, trade disruptions, or diversion of shipping routes in the Gulf directly impacts Indian exporters at their most vulnerable point. We currently have 260 tonnes of mango orders in hand for Gulf countries, but there is uncertainty over how the war," said Nadeem Siddiqui, a mango exporter in Amroha.

India's fresh mango exports reached 29,938.40 tonnes in FY25, valued at $56.5 million, the Agricultural and Processed Food Products Export Development Authority said on its website, citing data from the Directorate General of Commercial Intelligence and Statistics. The major mango-growing states in India are Uttar Pradesh, Andhra Pradesh, Bihar, Karnataka, Telangana and West Bengal.

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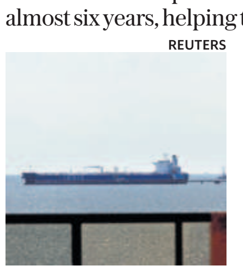
For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

MINT SHORTS

India to buy Venezuelan crude again to ease supply crunch

Indian is set to import the most oil from Venezuela in almost six years, helping the world's third-largest crude importer replace Middle East grades disrupted by the West Asia war. More than 12 million barrels are headed to India's west coast this month from the South American producer, the most since February 2020, according to data from Kpler. BLOOMBERG

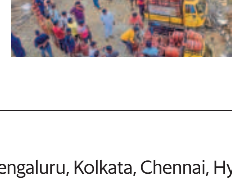

REUTERS

Foreign secy heads to US to review trade, defence ties

New Delhi: Foreign secretary Vikram Misri will begin a three-day visit to Washington DC on Wednesday to review bilateral trade and defence ties, and discuss the escalating crisis in West Asia. The ministry of external affairs said Misri's 8-10 April trip will provide an opportunity to review the full spectrum of India-US bilateral relations and advance ongoing cooperation across key areas. The visit comes as both sides work to stabilise the ties. PTI

Sugar, edible oil demand drops as gas crisis hits restaurants

Mumbai: Consumption of sugar and edible oils in India, the world's largest market, is declining as a shortage of commercial gas cylinders has forced restaurants to scale back during the summer holiday season. Lower consumption could curb India's imports of edible oils, including palm oil from Indonesia and Malaysia, and soyoil and sunflower oil from Argentina, Brazil, Russia and Ukraine. India is battling its worst gas crisis in decades. REUTERS

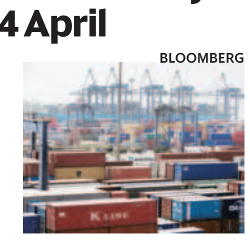

PTI

Reliance, Vedanta join rare earth scheme talks with govt


BLOOMBERG

New Delhi: Reliance Industries, Sona Comstar, Vedanta, Larsen & Toubro and Japan's Proterial were among firms that joined discussions with the government on Tuesday over the $780-million rare earth magnet manufacturing scheme, according to an executive who was part of the consultations. The scheme received the Union Cabinet's assent in November. AYAAN KARTIK & MANAS PIMPALKHARE

India, New Zealand FTA likely to be signed on 24 April


BLOOMBERG

New Delhi: India and New Zealand are expected to sign a Free Trade Agreement (FTA) on 24 April here, which will provide tariff-free access to domestic exporters for their goods in the island nation's market and bring in $20 billion investment over the next 15 years, an official said. PTI

Gas trading volume drops 8% on IGX in Mar amid supply crunch

New Delhi: Trading volume on the Indian Gas Exchange (IGX) fell 8% year-on-year in March to 4.8 metric million British thermal units (mmBtu) because of a decline in supplies amid the ongoing war in West Asia. Trading volume was down 11% month-on-month. GIXI, the benchmark price index of IGX, was ₹998 per mmBtu for March, up 18% year-on-year, IGX said in a statement. RITURAJ BARUAH

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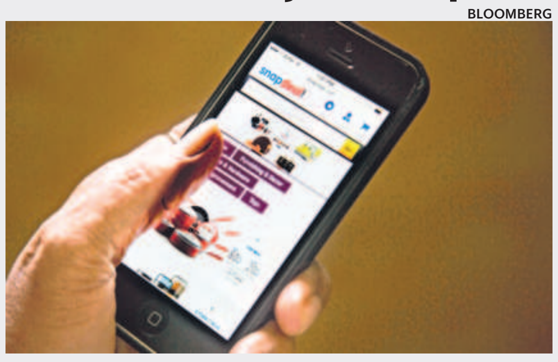
MINT SHORTS

Ultraviolette enters Hungary, central Europe

New Delhi: Electric motorcycle maker Ultraviolette Automotive on Tuesday announced its foray into Hungary and Central Europe in partnership with electric motorcycle brand Elektrorider. The company has appointed Elektrorider as the official importer and distributor of its products for Hungary, Croatia, Slovakia, Romania, Slovenia, and the Czech Republic, Ultraviolette said in a statement. With this partnership, Ultraviolette further strengthens and expands its foothold across 19 European countries, it added. **PTI**

India's e-commerce market to hit $250 billion by 2030: report

BLOOMBERG



New Delhi: India's e-commerce market could nearly triple to $250 billion by 2030, from $90 billion at present, driven by a surge in Gen Z shoppers, the rapid expansion of quick commerce, and artificial intelligence, says a joint report by Google and Deloitte titled *The USD 250 Billion Commerce Frontier*, released on Tuesday. The report says the Indian digital economy will see the entry of 150 million new shoppers by the end of the decade. A massive 220-million-strong cohort of Gen Z consumers is expected to command 45% of total online spending, it adds. **PTI**

WorkOnGrid raises ₹22.5 crore in funding round led by Transition VC

New Delhi: AI-native operations intelligence platform WorkOnGrid has raised ₹22.5 crore in a funding round led by Transition VC, with participation from Indian Angel Network (IAN). The fresh capital will be used to expand WorkOnGrid's global go-to-market activities, enhance its AI and machine learning capabilities, and develop international infrastructure to support wider deployment, according to a company statement. **PTI**

Ola Electric announces readiness of indigenous 46100 LFP cell

New Delhi: Ola Electric on Tuesday announced readiness of its lithium iron phosphate (LFP) cell, developed in-house. Developed as part of Ola's vertically integrated battery innovation efforts, the new '46100' format LFP cell represents a step-change in scale, cost efficiency, and applicability across both mobility and energy storage solutions, the company said. **PTI**

AI roles surge at IT firms as automation shapes growth

At least five top IT services firms introduced or expanded AI-focused roles over the past year

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BENGALURU

As artificial intelligence (AI) reshapes global tech spending, India's IT services majors are responding with a leadership reset. New chief AI roles, dedicated business units, and AI-linked revenue disclosures point to a structural shift in how the sector is gearing up for growth in the automation era.

This shift is already visible in the pace of leadership changes. At least five of the country's top 10 IT services firms—including Tata Consultancy Services Ltd, Infosys Ltd, Wipro Ltd, LTM Ltd (formerly LTIMindtree), and Persistent Systems Ltd—introduced or expanded AI-focused roles over the past year, more than in the previous two years combined.

"As AI becomes more widespread, there will be an increasing need to make and sell AI-specific proposals to clients," said Pramod Gubbi, founder of Marcellus Investment Managers. "This is why we can expect more IT outsourcers across the board to double down on such leadership roles."

On 1 April, fourth-largest Wipro became the latest company to announce a new AI business unit called AI-Native Business & Platforms, to be led by Nagendra Bandaru, who was president of technology services business line. The new unit will include Wipro's proprietary AI offerings and AI-related business arms.

Earlier, in October, Amit Kapur took over as TCS's chief AI and services transformation officer. Kapur, who was the company's head of UK and Ireland, now heads the AI and services transformation unit, which is the third AI unit of the company, and reports directly to chief operating officer Aarthi Subramanian.

The focus was not just on heading AI-specific business units, but also on selling those technologies. In May last year, second-largest Infosys announced Vivek Sinha—an associate vice-president—as the global head of sales for AI and Automation.

Mid-sized IT firms, too, took steps in this direction. Sixth-largest LTM announced Manoj Kothiyal as the chief business head for AI in November last year. Five months ago, the company launched BlueVerse, a dedicated AI business unit that would include its AI products and platforms.

In August, Persistent Systems announced Sameer Dixit as the global practice head for data and analytics, AI & integration. However, the company does not have one fixed AI offering and sells its AI solutions through its Persistent.AI service offering.

In January 2024, third-largest HCLTech announced Ajay Singh, senior vice-president at WNS, as the global director and head of AI. Fifth-largest Tech Mahindra announced Nikhil Malhotra—its global head of innovation—as the company's AI head around 2024.

The focus was also on selling AI technologies. ISTOCKPHOTO

HEADED FOR AI

ON 1 April Wipro announced a new AI business unit called AI-Native Business & Platforms

WIPRO'S new unit is led by Nagendra Bandaru, who was president of its tech services business

IN October, Amit Kapur took over as chief AI and services transformation officer at TCS

IN May, Infosys announced Vivek Sinha as the global head of sales for AI and Automation

Namratha Dharshan, chief business leader of ISG, a a Connecticut-based research and advisory firm, said this was done to drive two mandates.

"Firstly, building and testing AI solutions internally before scaling to clients, including internal consolidation of solutions, building CoEs (centres of excellence), and investing in continuous expansion of capabilities," said Dharshan.

"The other mandate is to cut organizational friction and accelerate innovation and go to market and, most importantly, ensure AI delivers measurable RoI (return on investment) at a time when enterprises are under increasing value pressure," she added.

However, even as companies formalize AI leadership, questions have been raised about how substantive these roles are.

"Nearly half of the AI leaders surveyed report that their organization has simply reclassified existing positions to include AI responsibilities," read a 24 February report from Chicago-based executive search firm Heidrick & Struggles.

"This approach has created confusion about what constitutes true AI leadership and has inflated compensation expectations across the board, because these roles have a remit wider than AI alone," the report added.

Heidrick & Struggles bases its comment on data it compiled from a survey conducted in summer 2025, featuring responses from 318 executives.

To be sure, the shift mirrors a broader hiring wave beyond IT services. A *Mint* report dated 18 February, which cited data from executive search firm Longhouse, noted that there have been at least 50 AI-focused leadership hirings—most notably chief AI officers—across sectors such as fintech, banking, manufacturing, logistics, media and enterprise technology over the past 12 months.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Pershing Square eyes merger with UMG

Reuters
feedback@livemint.com

Bill Ackman's Pershing Square proposed a deal on Tuesday to merge Universal Music Group with its investment fund under a plan to revive the world's biggest music label's value with a listing in the US.

Pershing Square's cash-and-shares offer values Universal Music at around €30.40 per share—a 78% premium to last close price at €17.10—making the deal worth €55.75 billion, *Reuters* calculated.

Universal Music Group—the company behind international superstars including Taylor Swift, Billie Eilish and Drake—declined a *Reuters* request for comment.

The Amsterdam-listed entertainment company's shares were up 12% on Tuesday, while top shareholder Bollore Group climbed 7%.

"The offer is non-binding and might well fail but we think at a minimum it has the merit of raising valid questions and making the case for dramatic changes," said ING analysts, adding that they expected investors to consider the proposal. Pershing's move comes after UMG last month delayed a plan for a U.S. listing, walking back from an agreement with Pershing, which had exercised its right to request a US offering and had argued a New York listing would boost UMG's share price and liquidity. Like other big music labels Sony and Warner Music, UMG is scrambling to stay competitive. Its shares have lost almost a third of their value since its listing in 2021 and trade at a long-term multiple of 21.8 times earnings, compared with Spotify's 40 times, LSEG data said.

KreditBee raises $280 mn, enters the unicorn club

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MUMBAI

Madhusudan Ekambaram, founder and chief executive officer, Kreditbee.

Advent-backed digital lender KreditBee has raised about $280 million in a Series E funding round, valuing the company about $1.5 billion and marking its entry into the unicorn club.

The round was led by Motilal Oswal Alternates, Hornbill Capital, and MUFG-backed Dragon Funds. WhiteOak Capital and A.P. Moller Holding, besides existing investors including Premji Invest and Advent International also participated in the round.

The funding round makes KreditBee the third unicorn of 2026 and the first in the new financial year. The other two recently-crowned unicorns were fintech firm Juspay and AI cloud startup Neysa. KreditBee last raised a round in 2023 at $700 million in valuation.

Of the total funding, $220 million is primary capital and $60 million is secondary, allowing early investors like Alpine Capital, Mirae Asset Naver Asia Growth Fund and some employees to partially exit. "The majority of the capital will go into the company," founder and chief executive Madhusudan Ekambaram said.

> The latest fund-raise comes at a time when large deals in the fintech lending space have been scarce

The latest fund-raise comes when large deals in the fintech lending space have been scarce. "Given the current global macro environment, raising such a large round is a strong validation of the company's performance and investor confidence," he said.

Mint had first reported in September that the company had hired bankers to raise over $100 million. Moneyview, one of Kreditbee's closest competitors, had raised a $75 million cheque in 2024, while another, Fibe, raised $35 million last year. For Kreditbee, the current round comes at a significantly higher size, underscoring renewed investor interest in the segment.

The company plans to deploy the fresh capital to expand its lending book. "The capital will largely be used to fund the NBFC (non-banking financial company) business and expand AUM (assets under management)," Ekambaram said.

KreditBee has seen strong growth in its AUM, closing FY25 with ₹10,200 crore and is expected to end FY26 at ₹14,700 crore. This growth has been driven largely by its core unsecured lending business. "Over 90% of disbursements still come from this segment (personal loans)," Ekambaram said.

On the tech front, the firm is increasing the use of artificial intelligence in areas like operational efficiency, developer productivity, and improving customer journeys, he said.

For an extended version of the story, go to livemint.com

Vinci set to re-enter India with $1.7 bn Macquarie toll roads deal

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MUMBAI

In one of the largest toll road divestments in India, Australian asset manager Macquarie Asset Management is selling its Indian platform, Safeway Concessions, to French engineering and infrastructure firm Vinci SA for an implied enterprise value of approximately $1.7 billion (₹15,000 crore).

Safeway Concessions acquired the rights to operate nine highways spanning nearly 700 kilometres across Andhra Pradesh and Gujarat in 2018 under the National Highways Authority of India's toll-operate-transfer (TOT) model for about ₹9,680 crore (around $1.49 billion at the time), marking the country's first major privatization of existing road assets.

Macquarie put Safeway on the block in 2025, with the race for the assets originally narrowing down to three contenders: Vinci; IPO-bound EAAA India Alternatives Ltd's Sekura Roads; and KKR's Vertis Infrastructure Trust.

Mint reported on 9 February that Vinci was nearing a $2 billion deal for the assets, paving the way for its return to India after 11 years. It had exited the country in 2015 amid policy shifts in the road assets industry.

The company had sought to form a joint venture with BlackRock-backed infrastructure fund Global Infrastructure Partners (GIP) for an India entry, but talks fell through, the news report said.

Vinci is now likely to set up an India unit to house the road assets and avoid putting them into an infrastructure investment trust due to complex regulatory procedures, the report added.

"India has the world's second-largest road network, with a rapidly growing middle class driving higher demand for road usage," Verena Lim, co-head of Asia-Pacific Macquarie Asset Management, said in a statement on Tuesday. Lim noted the sale reinforces the viability of the TOT model for international investors such as Vinci.

The sale of Safeway Concessions to Vinci will mark the French company's return to India after more than a decade.

Macquarie had approximately $477 billion in assets under management globally as of 30 September 2025.

The sale is subject to regulatory approvals and customary closing conditions, with a financial close expected by end-2026, the statement said. The final valuation may be adjusted based on transaction costs and foreign exchange rates at the time of closing.

Vinci's interest in India's road assets is not an outlier.

Media reports suggest Macquarie is also seeking a stake in the Canadian institutional investor CDPQ-backed Maple Infrastructure Trust. KKR has been consolidating its road portfolio under Vertis, as it aims to build a platform large enough to rival Singapore-based Cube Highways.

Cube, meanwhile, acquired two annuity road assets in Jammu & Kashmir in 2025.

In 2024, KKR-backed Highways Infrastructure Trust also signed definitive agreements to acquire a dozen road projects from PNC Infratech Ltd for ₹9,005 crore.

The interest in roads is driven by factors such as the availability of a large number of assets that allow large institutional investors, including pension and sovereign wealth funds, to flock in. Macquarie's assets are also sweetened by the fact that they have a 30-year concession period.

Vinci's India bet also comes at a time when India's road monetization has a steady outlook.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Savills picks majority stake in Hotelivate to expand in Apac

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MUMBAI

The Indian unit of Savills Plc, a UK real estate adviser, has acquired a majority interest in Hotelivate to expand its hospitality advisory services across the Asia-Pacific (Apac) region, the London-based company said in a statement on Tuesday.

The investment combines Hotelivate's hospitality expertise with Savills' real estate platform to create the Hotelivate-Savills brand.

"This acquisition accelerates Savills' plan to build out hospitality expertise across the Apac region and globally," Martin Fidden, chief executive officer of Savills Asia Pacific (ex-Greater China), told *Mint*.

Savills did not disclose the amount invested in Hotelivate.

Savills provides services in leasing, capital markets, valuations, and project management.

The move fuses Hotelivate's hospitality expertise with Savills' real estate platform.

Its portfolio includes commercial, industrial and residential property and data centres.

The company employs more than 42,000 people across 700 offices, including in Bengaluru, Mumbai, the National Capital Region and Chennai.

While Savills already has hospitality teams in place, Hotelivate has the dominant market share in India, Fidden explained. This domestic market share is estimated at about 55%, Manav Thadani, founder-chairman of Hotelivate, told *Mint*.

"Beyond that, 20-25% of our revenue comes from outside India," he said. "With the Savills deal, we expect that share to grow to maybe 90% of our revenue soon."

Hotelivate was started by the erstwhile team of HVS India in 2017 after the global consultancy parent wrapped up its India operations.

Hotelivate offers hospitality consulting services through offices in Delhi, Mumbai, Bangkok, Dubai and Singapore.

For an extended version of the story, go to livemint.com

Index	Close	Percent change	Previous close	Open	High	Low
BSE Sensex	74,616.58	0.69	74,106.85	73,734.36	74,686.32	73,282.41
Nifty 50	23,123.65	0.68	22,968.25	22,838.70	23,153.85	22,719.30
Nifty 500	21,296.45	0.48	21,194.05	21,085.30	21,313.10	20,959.35
Nifty Next 50	63,151.05	0.46	62,858.95	62,607.45	63,217.25	62,021.15
Nifty 100	23,730.25	0.64	23,579.45	23,453.20	23,757.35	23,326.00
BSE 150 MidCap	14,760.35	0.03	14,756.04	14,715.10	14,780.47	14,538.74
BSE 250 SmallCap	5,917.50	0.16	5,908.13	5,898.08	5,936.20	5,855.10

Adani Ports gets volume cushion

Manish Joshi
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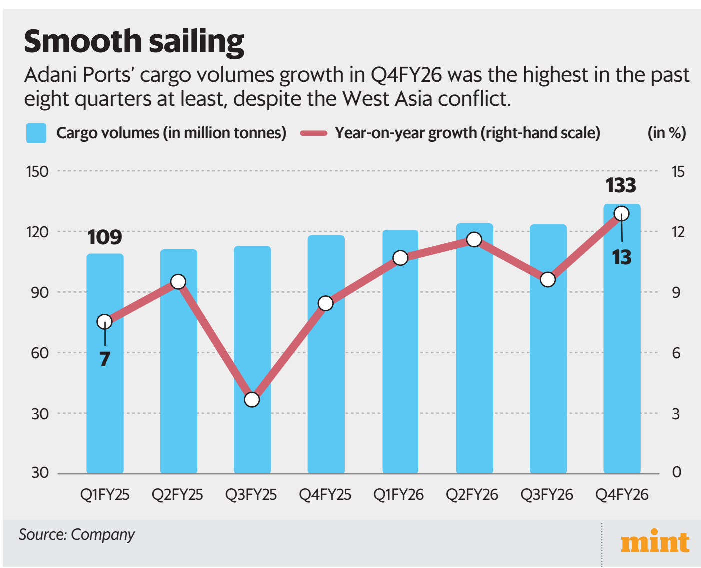
Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone Ltd stock has fallen by about 9% to ₹1,381 since the West Asia conflict began on 28 February. The fall would have been steeper if not for the company's business updates highlighting that it had clocked 11% year-on-year growth in cargo volumes to 46 million tonnes (MT) in March. Riding on the strong showing in March, FY26 volume growth came in at 11% to 501 MT, slightly lower than management's guidance of 505-515 MT.

Analysts from JM Financial Institutional Securities and Nomura Financial Advisory and Securities (India) believe Adani Ports overcame the estimated loss of container volumes linked to Mundra Port in March with gains from transshipment volumes, as many international ports shied away from Middle-East-bound cargo owing to congestion worries. The analysts noted that about 15% of Mundra Port's container traffic is linked to the Middle East.



PRATEEK KUMAR/MINT

Amid the conflict, the company's international ports business has stayed resilient. Volumes at the Haifa port in Israel increased month-on-month from 0.59 MT to 0.77 MT. Haifa's March volumes grew even after adjusting for fewer days in February. While the port contributes about 2% of Adani Ports' volumes, the trend highlights the war has had no impact on volumes so far. Similarly, the Colombo terminal handled the highest ever monthly volume at 134,960 twenty-foot equivalent units. Logistics rail volume and wagon volumes, primarily based in India, grew month-on-month by 6% and 18%, respectively, in March.

Adani Ports has navigated war-related volume growth concerns in March. While a prolonged conflict in the Middle East could prove a headwind to container-linked volumes, there is a tailwind from the restarting of Tata Power's Mundra power plant, which relies on imported coal at Mundra Port.

As of now, JM Financial estimates the war's impact on port traffic is likely to last for the current quarter, Q1FY27. It has therefore reduced its FY27 Ebitda estimate by 7% while leaving the FY28 estimate largely unchanged. It has cut the target price of Adani Ports stock from ₹1,800 to ₹1,725, citing the 10-year G-sec yield rising from 6.7% to 7%. But two points are worth noting here. One, rising bond yields make equities less attractive in general, though not specific to Adani Ports stock. Two, even after cutting the target price, there is still about 25% upside from the current price.

Other brokerages such as Motilal Oswal and Nomura echo this positive outlook. They have set price targets of ₹1,820 and ₹1,850, respectively, valuing the stock at an EV/Ebitda multiple of 15, based on FY28 estimates.

For long-term investors looking beyond FY28, the ongoing expansion of Mundra port and its timely completion will be critical. The current capacity of 264 MT at Mundra will eventually be expanded to 514 MT with ₹45,000 crore of capital expenditure. This will expand the port's multi-purpose cargo handling capabilities, including LNG in cryogenic ships. Its completion will help achieve management's goal of almost doubling FY26 total volumes to 1,000 MT by 2030/FY31. That would mean achieving a compound annual growth rate of 15% on a larger base, higher than 13% CAGR achieved in volumes over FY17-FY26. Investors will keenly watch management's delivery on this target.

HOLDING FIRM

AGAINST the backdrop of the war, Adani's international ports business has stayed resilient

FOR long-term investors, expansion of Mundra port and its timely completion will be critical

AWL Agri down 37% post Adani exit. Q4 signals worst is over

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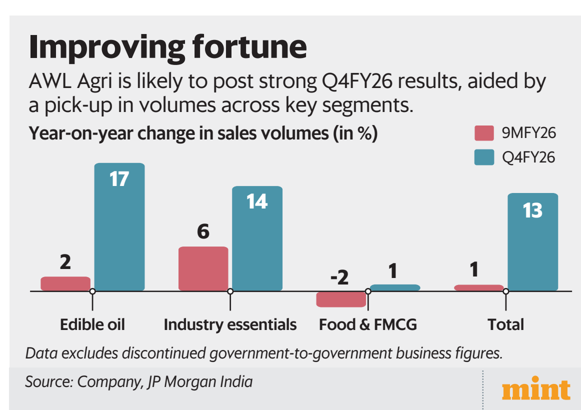
Shares of AWL Agri Business (formerly Adani Wilmar) are down 37% since 21 November after Adani group's exit. The stock hit a 52-week low of ₹171.19 on 16 March, amid muted financials for the nine months ended December (9MFY26).

But the worst may be over. Its March quarter (Q4FY26) business update reveals sales volumes grew by 13% year-on-year. This compares with just 1% volume growth in 9MFY26, pulling down FY26 growth to 5%. Nuvama Institutional Equities estimates AWL's Q4 Ebitda growth at 20% year-on-year, vis-à-vis a similar drop in 9MFY26.

Edible oil, which contributed 80% of AWL's FY26 revenue, led Q4 show, clocking 17% volume growth aided by lower imports from neighbouring countries. It saw a modest 2% rise in 9MFY26. Value growth in Q4 was at 21%, helped by ₹4-5 price hike per litre taken by the edible oil industry in March.

AWL benefits from access to the global linkages of its Singapore-based parent, Wilmar International. Also, ports-based processing units reduce logistics cost, helping them maintain about 20% share in the domestic market in a low-margin business. Edible oil Ebit margin fell 219 basis points year-on-year in 9MFY26 to 1.7% due to higher raw material costs.



PRATEEK KUMAR/MINT

Industry essentials, used as an ingredient in producing soaps, detergents, etc., volumes grew by 14%, versus 6% growth in 9MFY26. The segment contributed 12% of FY26 revenue. Some of these products are made from by-products of the edible oil segment, providing AWL a cost advantage. Food & FMCG stayed subdued, clocking just 1% growth, slightly better than the 2% drop in 9MFY26, due to weak institutional exports. The segment is scaling up its retail network, after AWL exited the government-to-government business in Q4FY25.

The number of outlets rose 14% in FY26, largely in rural areas, helping the branded rice business grow 30% year-on-year in Q4FY26. Alternate channels, e-commerce, quick commerce and modern trade, saw continued traction, rising 43% in the quarter.

AWL's valuations are appealing, with the stock trading at about 19 times FY27 estimated earnings, as per *Bloomberg*. But investors must track the volatility in prices of raw materials, which form nearly 90% of sales. Besides, investments to scale the food & FMCG business may keep the segment's margins under pressure in the near term.

Mark to Market writers do not hold positions in the companies discussed here unless otherwise informed

Markets rally for 4th day; Sensex up by over 500 points

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Stock market benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty ended higher on Tuesday, as a drop in crude oil prices and a rally in global markets calmed investors' sentiment.

Also, buying in IT stocks aided recovery in the markets after early losses. The 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 509.73 points, or 0.69%, to settle at 74,616.58. During the day, it hit a high of 74,686.32 and a low of 73,282.41, gyrating 1,403.91 points.

The 50-share NSE Nifty climbed 155.40 points, or 0.68 per cent, to end at 23,123.65.

From the 30-Sensex firms, Tata Consultancy Services, HCL Tech, Infosys, Bharti Airtel, Sun Pharma, and Hindustan Unilever were among the major gainers.

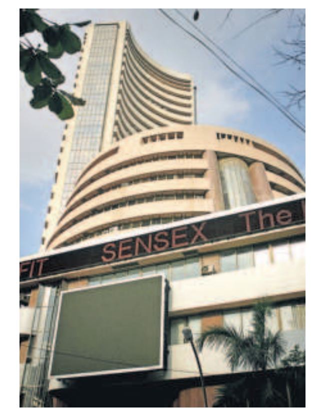
InterGlobe Aviation, Adani Ports, Mahindra & Mahindra and Titan were among the laggards. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, dropped 0.71% to $109 per barrel.

"Indian markets staged a sharp intra-day recovery, with Nifty reversing early losses to reclaim higher levels, driven largely by short-covering and selective sectoral strength rather than broad-based buying conviction," Hariprasad K, research analyst and founder, Livelong Wealth, said.

From 30-Sensex firms, TCS, HCL Tech, Infosys, Bharti Airtel, Sun Pharma and HUL were among the major gainers

A key driver of today's rally was strong outperformance in the IT sector, which acted as a defensive anchor, he said.

"The domestic market extended its recovery trend, although the session opened on a weak note amid elevated crude prices and caution ahead of Trump's deadline for Iran.


Drop in crude oil prices and a rally in global markets calmed investors' sentiment. BLOOMBERG

Gains remained largely confined to IT, FMCG, and metal, while broader market breadth stayed weak, reflecting persistent caution," Vinod Nair, head of research, Geojit Investments Ltd, said.

Sectorally, BSE-Focused IT jumped 2.46%, IT (2.37%), realty (1.70%), metal (1.55%), commodities (0.83%), hospitals (0.83%) and FMCG (0.71%). PSU banks, consumer durables, services, BSE MidSmall Private Banks Quality Tilt and consumer discretionary were the laggards.

A total of 2,671 stocks advanced while 1,555 declined and 155 remained unchanged on the BSE.

In Asian markets, South Korea's benchmark Kospi, Japan's Nikkei 225 index and Shanghai's SSE Composite index ended higher. Markets were closed in Hong Kong for a holiday.

Foreign Institutional Investors offloaded equities worth ₹8,167.17 crore on Monday, according to exchange data. Domestic Institutional Investors, however, bought stocks worth ₹8,088.70 crore.

IPO, public float norms eased amid conflict

FROM PAGE 1

Lunawat, founder of Pantomath Financial Services and chairman of the Association of Investment Bankers of India.

The market regulator also eased pressure on already listed companies, giving them more time to comply with the minimum public shareholding (MPS) norms.

Citing prevailing market conditions, Sebi said it has decided to grant a one-time relaxation from penalties levied on companies whose due dates for compliance with the MPS requirement fall between 1 April 2026 and 30 September 2026, according to a separate circular issued on Tuesday.

Mint reported earlier that the pace of IPOs could moderate in 2026 unless market sentiment stabilizes, as merchant bankers flagged rising uncertainty amid the escalation of the US-Israel-Iran conflict. Companies including XED Executive Development and PhonePe have deferred or cancelled their listing plans, citing geopolitical tensions.

Still, the Indian benchmark indices have posted gains for four consecutive days after several weeks of consistent outflows. The Sensex erased an over 800-point loss and closed 0.69% higher at 74,616 at closing on April 7. The Nifty 50 index also ended the session 0.68% higher.

Agratas raises $730 million from banks

FROM PAGE 1

bets that are yet to turn profitable. Air India, Tata Electronics and Tata Digital had posted cumulative losses of ₹15,539 crore in the year ended March 2025, according to Tata Sons' annual report.

Tata Semiconductor—a unit of Tata Electronics—and Agratas are yet to start operations, as their manufacturing facilities are still work in progress and nearing completion.

"In giga factories, the last mile before launch is often the most cash intensive and execution sensitive. So, securing funding at this point is crucial because it reduces the risk of delays, gives confidence to suppliers and customers, and helps the company manage the transition from construction to commercial ramp-up," said Harshvardhan Sharma, group head of automotive technology and innovation at Nomura Research Institute Consulting & Solutions India.


Agratas is building a 20GWh plant in Gujarat. ISTOCKPHOTO

Another point to note about Agratas here is the group's willingness to bring an external investor into the company. The AESC Group, headquartered in Yokohama, Japan, bought a 12% stake in Agratas for ₹66 crore in March 2025. Chinese energy technology company Envision owns the AESC Group.

In 2024, Agratas had announced it would build a 40 gigawatt hour (GWh) electric battery manufacturing plant in Somerset, UK. The firm is also building a 20GWh plant in Sanand, Gujarat, which is expected to begin production in fiscal year 2027 (FY27). The plants will produce cells for electric vehicles (EVs) as well as battery energy storage solutions.

Agratas' funding is largely through banks, with it pledging all its movable assets to secure some of the loans

"The project to set up giga factories in India and the UK is on track and will commence operations from FY27 in a phased manner," a Tata Motors spokesperson had told *Mint* in June. This is expected to cater to the internal requirement for EV cells from Jaguar Land Rover and Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles as well as external demand.

On 2 April, Agratas said the steel frame of its Sanand factory was complete and that it is moving closer to production. The focus now is on building the systems, processes and capabilities, the company said.

Billions flow out of BlackRock's India ETF as Iran war escalates

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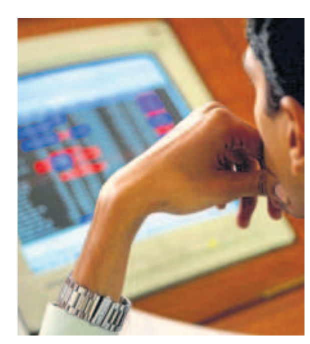
Investors are accelerating their flight from the largest US-listed exchange-traded fund tracking Indian equities, as concerns mount over the impact of the global energy crisis on the Asian economy.

The $6.4 billion iShares MSCI India ETF recorded over $220 million in withdrawals on Monday alone, its largest single day outflow since April 2025. That extends what has been a streak of five consecutive weeks of withdrawals that now total over $2 billion, according to data compiled by *Bloomberg*.

The conflict in West Asia has driven a selloff in Indian assets


The NSE Nifty 50 Index fell over 11% in March alone. AP

over the past month as concern grows over the country's reliance on fuel shipped through the Strait of Hormuz. India imports roughly 90% of its crude oil and nearly 50% of its liquefied petroleum gas, with about half of that crude and over three-quarters of the LPG transiting the Strait of Hormuz, which Iran has effectively shut.

The NSE Nifty 50 Index fell over 11% in March alone, pushing the index near levels last seen during the market turmoil after the US tariff rollout a year ago. The rupee, meanwhile, weakened over 4% against the dollar in that same period.

UBS Global Wealth Management recently downgraded Indian stocks to neutral, citing the market's sensitivity to elevated oil prices. On top of that, investors' jitters about India's high valuations, the risk of AI disruption and currency weakness also weighed on sentiment.

Rupee could fall to 100/dollar if oil stays above $110 a barrel, says Mishra

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India's currency outlook is increasingly tied to the trajectory of crude oil price, Axis Bank's chief economist Neelkanth Mishra said, cautioning that the rupee could weaken to 100 per dollar if oil stays above $110 per barrel.

In a worst-case scenario, the rupee's depreciation could be significant. However, the central bank's recent intervention in currency markets is expected to delay rate-based support for the currency by 1-2 months, Mishra said at a Kotak Private event in Mumbai on Tuesday.

His comments come at a time when the local unit has fallen by 4.5% against the dollar since the war in West Asia began on 28 February, and 11% in FY26, hitting an all-time low of 95.1250 per dollar on 30 March. It later pared some losses following measures by the Reserve Bank of India to limit banks' currency positions, curb derivative market trades and tighten offshore rupee market bets to reduce speculative pressures and limit spillovers to the onshore market.


Axis Bank's chief economist Neelkanth Mishra said in a worst-case scenario, the rupee's depreciation could be significant. MINT

"Given that they (RBI) managed to get back $40 billion because of those recent interventions, it potentially delays rate-related defence of the INR by at least two months," he said, suggesting that immediate rate hikes may not be necessary.

The Reserve Bank of India is set to announce its first policy decision of the current financial year on Wednesday. A *Mint* poll of 10 economists and market participants expects the monetary policy committee to keep the repo rate steady at 5.25% as it shifts its focus to rising inflation and a possible slowdown in growth due to the ongoing West Asia conflict.

The Reserve Bank of India is set to announce its first policy decision of the current financial year on Wednesday

According to Mishra, the government's broader response to the ongoing global disruption has also been assessed positively, particularly if the shock proves temporary. However, some degree of currency adjustment is inevitable if oil sustains above $100 per barrel.

"...don't let the currency weaken a lot, because the currency will need to weaken... if oil prices are going to be $100, then the INR may need to go to 98, 99," he said, cautioning against premature moves if prices ease.

The rupee closed at 93.10 to a dollar on Tuesday.

The current macro shock, he said, is not permanent but involves adjustments. "There is a one-time adjustment on growth, there is a one-time adjustment on inflation, there is a one-time adjustment on currency."

"[But] compared to any other time in our history, I think we are the best prepared that we can imagine," he said.

The currency outlook hinges on oil: if prices stay elevated, a gradual, RBI-managed depreciation towards 98–100 appears likely.

Air India begins search for a new CEO after Wilson quits

Experts say appointing a strong successor quickly is key to the airline's turnaround plans

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Campbell Wilson had informed Tata Sons chairman Natarajan Chandrasekaran as early as 2024 that he was planning to move on in 2026, and will stay on until a successor at Air India is appointed. REUTERS

Air India has kicked off the search for a new chief executive after Campbell Wilson's decision to step down, announcing on Tuesday that it has constituted a committee to identify his successor.

Mint reported on Monday that Wilson stepped down from the helm of India's second-largest airline, cutting short his five-year tenure by a year amid mounting losses and operational headwinds. Wilson's tenure was to end in July 2027.

The press statement said Wilson had conveyed his intention to move on in 2026 to Air India chairman N. Chandrasekaran in 2024 and that, since then, he has been working to ensure the airline and its leadership are on a stable footing for the transition.

"He (Wilson) will remain in the role until his successor is announced and in place," the statement added.

The Tata group hired Wilson from Singapore Airlines' low-cost unit Scoot in May 2022, less than four months after the conglomerate acquired the state-run Air India for ₹18,000 crore.

Wilson's exit comes shortly after leadership changes at India's largest airline, IndiGo, where CEO Pieter Elbers stepped down in March. William Walsh has been named his successor, expected to join by August, about three weeks after Elbers' departure. IndiGo also appointed former Air India Express chief Aloke Singh, who also quit in March, as chief strategy officer.

Air India Express, the low-cost carrier and subsidiary of Air India, is yet to appoint a CEO, and the airline has appointed Captain Hamish Maxwell as manager and key managerial personnel for a one-year tenure.

In an email to over 24,000 employees on Tuesday, Wilson said the airline's transformation since privatization included "the merger of four airlines (Air India, Vistara, Air India Express and AirAsia India)", a shift to private-sector practices, "complete modernization of systems", and the addition of over 100 aircraft, along with new infrastructure such as "South Asia's largest training academy".

He added that "with these foundational blocks now settling, the time is right…to hand over the reins", calling it "a true honour" to be part of Air India's journey.

To be sure, Wilson tried to revive the airline by replacing outdated IT infrastructure and implementing processes and systems to modernize the carrier.

However, 2025 exacerbated the challenges of running an airline. First, on 12 June 2025, an Air India flight from Ahmedabad to London crashed shortly after taking off, killing all but one of the 230 passengers and 12 crew members on board, triggering intense scrutiny, inspections, and the temporary grounding of several aircraft.

The crash was followed by Operation Sindoor, launched in the aftermath of the Pahalgam terrorist attack, which led to the closure of Pakistan's airspace, disrupting international routes for Indian carriers. Towards the end of February, the US and Israel jointly attacked Iran, marking the start of a war that sent fuel prices soaring and led to further airspace closures across West Asia, forcing carriers such as Air India to fly longer distances.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

LEADERSHIP CHANGE

WILSON joined Air India in May 2022, months after Tata Group acquired the airline for ₹18,000 cr	**HE** oversaw merger of the four airlines—Air India, Vistara, Air India Express and AirAsia India	**THE** airline posted ₹10,859 crore loss in FY25, and is likely to exceed ₹20,000 cr by March 2026	**WHILE** standalone revenue rose 13% to ₹61,080 cr in FY25, Air India's borrowing has declined

'Privatize or reposition Pawan Hans as NE-focused carrier'

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The government holds a 51% stake in Pawan Hans, with ONGC owning the rest; earlier privatization attempts have failed. MINT

A parliamentary committee has asked the civil aviation ministry to consider selling state-owned chopper service firm Pawan Hans Ltd or reposition it as a north-east (NE)-focused helicopter operator.

"The committee recommends that the ministry articulate a clear, strategic direction for Pawan Hans, whether restructuring, re-attempting disinvestment, or repositioning it as a strategic helicopter operator for North Eastern region and island connectivity," the 31-member panel said in a report tabled in Parliament on 25 March.

The civil aviation ministry holds a 51% stake in Pawan Hans, while Oil and Natural Gas Corp. owns the rest. Efforts to privatize the helicopter operator in 2016, 2017, 2019 and 2020 did not materialise, and the process was called off in 2023 after a winning consortium was disqualified due to pending legal cases.

It reported revenue of ₹369.63 crore and a loss of ₹16.15 crore in FY25. Its fleet comprises 46 helicopters. The panel, headed by JD(U) MP Sanjay Kumar Jha and comprising members from Rajya Sabha and Lok Sabha, also flagged staff shortages at the directorate general of civil aviation (DGCA) and the bureau of civil aviation safety (BCAS).

DGCA is India's civil aviation regulator responsible for safety oversight, and BCAS is responsible for security oversight and protocols for airports and airlines. DGCA vacancies stood at 48.3%, with 787 posts vacant out of 1,630 sanctioned strength. At BCAS, 181 of 598 posts are vacant. This means that one in every two posts at the DGCA is vacant, and one out of every three posts at the BCAS is vacant.

These vacancies represent a "structural challenge to the regulatory capacity and safety oversight", the panel said. It has been recommended that vacancies be filled on an "urgent basis" through steps such as fast-tracking UPSC-recommended candidates and exploring lateral hiring.

Pawan Hans posted ₹369.63 cr in revenue and a ₹16.15 cr loss in FY25; it operates a fleet of 46 helicopters

Experts said staffing shortage, particularly in technical roles, is still unresolved.

"There are a couple of problems at the DGCA that remain unaddressed. Firstly, technical vacancies in key departments such as air safety and airworthiness continue to remain. These are two critical departments. Secondly, the chief at the regulatory body is almost always a bureaucrat, rather than a technical person," said Rajendra Prasad, former director (Airworthiness), DGCA, and an aviation safety expert.

"At least, the Parliamentary committee is finally acknowledging that filling up of vacancies is critical and needs to be addressed as a priority," Prasad added.

The civil aviation ministry did not respond to queries till publishing time.

This panel also said the aviation ministry should expedite the process for selling the three arms of Air India Assets Holding Ltd (AIAHL), the special purpose vehicle set up to house the residual assets of Air India after its privatisation.

AIAHL includes maintenance, repair, and overhaul firm AI Engineering Services Ltd (AIESL), ground-handling entity AI Airport Services Ltd (AIASL), state-run airline Alliance Air Aviation Ltd.

"Meanwhile, AIASL's profit has declined precipitously from ₹40.42 crore to ₹2.94 crore, raising questions about the trajectory of the asset's value," it said.

Alliance Air reported loss of ₹682.94 crore in FY25, while AIASL's profit fell to ₹2.94 crore from ₹40.42 crore in FY24. AIESL is yet to publish FY25 numbers. It posted profit of ₹254.98 crore in FY24.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

'Global turmoil to boost India tourism'

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William E. Heinecke, founder and chairperson of Minor International, which runs hotel brands like Avani and Anantara.

India could gain from the disruptions in West Asia, as global travellers rethink traditional routes and turn to Asia for leisure and experiences. Minor International is looking to capitalise on that shift, betting on city hotels and experiential resorts.

"Travel is shifting, with Asia, including India, likely to benefit as some European and West Asia-bound tourists who may divert their travels from elsewhere," said William E. Heinecke, founder and chairperson of Minor International, which runs hotel brands like Avani and Anantara.

It's the right time to focus on India, he told *Mint*. "There's tremendous potential for both domestic and international travel here," said Heinecke, who is in India to attend the Hotelivate hospitality conference in Mumbai this week.

The Thailand-based hotel company is signing an Anantara at the World Trade Centre in Kolkata this month. It will have 170 rooms and will be ready in 2032. The firm will also sign another property in Coorg in April. Last year, the company launched its first Anantara hotel in Jaipur.

Unlike some global peers chasing scale, Minor is taking a measured approach. "We're not chasing scale. Our focus is on delivering experiences and results to our owners," he added. "In India, all the hotels we have announced so far are management contracts. That allows us to maintain quality and ensure each property meets our brand standards."

It plans to expand in India with a mix of city properties and experiential resorts, targeting 50 hotels over the next decade

With a goal of 50 hotels in India over the next decade, the company aims to balance city and leisure properties, emphasising quality experiences rather than rapid scale. "We're positioned like the big players, but without their baggage," William said. The focus is on creating unique stays, leveraging brand diversity, and catering to the evolving expectations of both domestic and international travellers, he said.

Globally, Minor has nearly 600 hotels in operation and over 650 signed, with an average occupancy of around 70%. Its largest brand is NH, primarily in Europe, followed by Anantara and Avani. In 2025, the firm's core profit grew 32% year-on-year to THB 6.84 billion ($217 million), driven by rate-led growth, improved financial efficiency, and lower financing costs. Its core revenue reached THB 133.2 billion ($4.05 billion), down 1% from the previous year.

Minor Hotels reported a global occupancy of around 70% in 2025, which he said is a comfortable level. While some city markets run at high occupancy, many of its experiential and resort properties, such as in northern Thailand and islands like Samui and Phuket, operate at lower occupancies but command higher room rates, allowing the company to maintain strong profitability across its diverse portfolio.

In India, Minor plans to target tier-one cities and experiential destinations. "Domestic travel is growing at a phenomenal rate. Indian travellers are exploring parts of India they never visited before, drawn by new quality properties," Heinecke said.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Lodha Developers misses FY26 pre-sales guidance due to war

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The Mumbai-based firm's sales bookings rose to ₹20,530 cr.

Despite 16% year-on-year rise in pre-sales, Lodha Developers fell short of meeting its FY26 pre-sales guidance of ₹21,000 crore due to the impact of the Iran war.

The Mumbai-based firm's sales bookings rose to ₹20,530 crore from ₹17,630 crore in the previous year, it said in a regulatory filing on Tuesday.

March saw a select deferral of sales due to the Iran war, resulting in pre-sales being ₹470 crore below guidance, the company said in its January-March quarter update.

Lodha Developers reported a 23% year-on-year increase in pre-sales to ₹5,890 crore in Q4FY26, which is a seasonally strong quarter for real estate companies. Customer collections for Q4FY26 were ₹5,230 crore, up 18% year-on-year, as construction activity ramped up. For FY26, the company's collections were ₹15,160 crore, up 5% year-on-year.

The company said it added one project in Mumbai Metropolitan Region (MMR) with gross development value (GDV) of ₹1,300 crore in the fourth quarter.

In FY26, Lodha Developers added 12 projects across key markets, including MMR, Pune, Bengaluru and National Capital Region (NCR), with a combined GDV of around ₹60,000 crore. Its net debt reduced by ₹ 800 crore to ₹5370 crore during the quarter on the back of strong collections, the company said.

Lodha Developers is among India's top four best-selling real estate developers along with Godrej Properties Ltd, DLF Ltd and Prestige Estates Projects Ltd.

While the overall residential sector is showing some signs of plateauing, the top four developers continue to report decent sales.

As per their sales guidance, they collectively aimed to cross ₹1 trillion in residential sales in FY26, marking the strongest year yet for branded players. However, the Iran war may cause a softening in sales for developers in the month of March.

Crisil Ratings in March said the residential real estate industry appears to have entered a phase of calibrated growth after a strong post-pandemic surge that saw it clock a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 26% in FY22-FY25.

Nevertheless, steady operating performance underpinned by healthy collections has translated into controlled debt levels, supporting the credit profiles of developers, the rating agency noted.

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HC rejects SpiceJet plea in ₹144.5 cr Maran row

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NEW DELHI

Budget carrier SpiceJet and its chairman and managing director Ajay Singh have filed a review petition before the Delhi high court (HC), seeking relief from an earlier direction requiring the airline to deposit ₹144.5 crore within four weeks in its long-running arbitration dispute with Kalanithi Maran and KAL Airways Pvt. Ltd.

Justice Subramonium Prasad adjourned the hearing to 13 April after both parties sought time. The court orally observed that filing a review plea does not absolve SpiceJet of its obligation to comply with an order to deposit the amount by 14 April. "You have to comply with the order. The fact that you have filed this application is not a passport to not comply with the order."

The review follows the HC's 18 March order rejecting SpiceJet's plea seeking modification of its January direction. The airline had proposed furnishing an unencumbered immovable property worth around ₹148 crore as security instead of making a cash deposit. However, the HC insisted on a cash deposit.

The plea assumes significance as SpiceJet is facing a liquidity crunch due to flight disruptions linked to the West Asia war. Around 22,000 flyers and 7,000 employees have been affected due to the war, senior counsel Amit Sibal said.

According to submissions made before the court, about 40% of the airline's flights operate on Gulf routes, many of which have been affected, leading to cancellations and financial stress.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Celebrity AI avatars promise fame at scale, but present new legal risks

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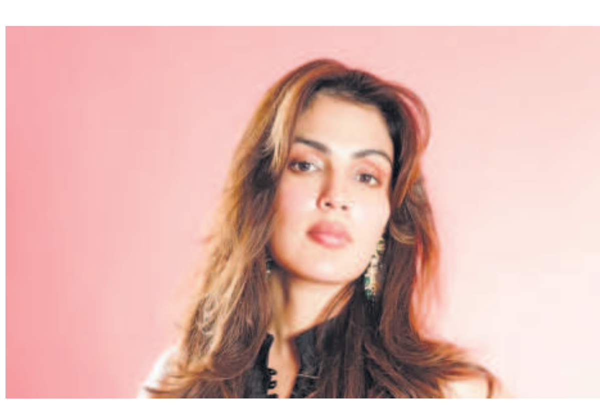

AI avatars allow celebrities like Rhea Chakraborty to scale fan engagement, endorsements and personalised content.

Celebrities may no longer be limited by time, geography or even physical presence.

With actor Rhea Chakraborty launching AI-powered avatar named Mishty in collaboration with Collective Artists Network and its AI studio Galleri5, the business of fame is entering a new phase—built on infinite scalability. Experts say AI avatars allow public figures to extend their commercial life cycle far beyond traditional constraints, unlocking always-on engagement and personalized brand deals.

As digital doubles become mainstream, legal and reputational risks are moving just as quickly. From unauthorized cloning of likeness and voice to disputes over digital identity ownership, the battle over control is only beginning, said experts. "The real opportunity is scale. A celebrity can be only in one place at a time. AI avatar removes the constraint, opening doors to always-on fan engagement, brand partnership, and personalised content at a volume no one can match. We are seeing a shift where AI avatars are moving from a futuristic concept to a practical tool," said Rajnish Rawat, co-founder and CEO at digital marketing agency Social Pill.

Globally, stars like Lil Miquela have shown that a digital persona can land massive fashion deals with, say, a Prada or Chanel, without stepping onto a physical set, Rawat said. In India, we are at early adopter stage. Actors like Chakraborty with Mishty avatar are testing the waters, and even legends like Sourav Ganguly launched digital twins for virtual coaching and fan access.

"The business opportunity is essentially about infinite scalability. A physical celebrity can be in one place at a time, but AI avatar can do thousand hyper-personalized endorsements in a hundred different regional languages," he added.

To be sure, the possibilities with AI avatars are genuinely exciting, said experts. Think personalized video messages at scale, AI-powered fan clubs, branded virtual appearances, language-localized content for local markets, and AI tutoring or mentorship products built around a persona.

INFINITE STARDOM

DIGITAL personas can enable hyper-personalised brand deals and content in regional languages

FOR brands, AI avatars could speed up production, cut campaign costs and boost outreach

For India, the regional language opportunity is massive. A single avatar speaking in 10 languages is a thing no human celebrity can replicate. "We are actively leveraging advanced generative AI platforms and real-time engines to develop AI-driven worlds and characters such as Mohini, along with immersive VR experiences that meet international quality benchmarks. These integrations allow us to optimise production timelines, enhance visual fidelity, and create scalable intellectual property. We are also exploring strategic partnerships with leading AI and immersive technology platforms to further strengthen our capabilities," said Khvafar Vakharia, executive business head and creative executive producer at Equinox Virtual.

Ushmi Desai, visual communication designer, BC Web Wise said for brands, this fundamentally alters economics of celebrity marketing.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Street sees future rate hikes while RBI readies pause

FROM PAGE 1

that can push rates beyond fundamentals.

Shailendra Jhingan, treasury head at ICICI Bank, said this raises the tail risk of higher policy rates later in the year, though "this remains a probabilistic outcome rather than the base case."

In the past, such large OIS-repo spreads have only appeared when markets believed policy rates would need to move up meaningfully. *Mint's* analysis shows that since 2010, whenever markets ran this far ahead of RBI, a policy shift followed.

During the so-called Taper Tantrum in 2013, the spread exploded to 245 bps as the rupee nearly collapsed against the dollar. RBI was forced to hike rates to stabilize the currency. In 2022, following the Russia-Ukraine war, the spread hit a 130-bps high as concerns of stickier inflation spiked. Again, RBI was forced to raise rates by 50 bps just a month after an off-cycle 40 bps rate hike.

This time, the Iran war has pushed oil prices up over 60% to around $111 per barrel, raising concerns over inflation and India's trade deficit. That has fed into expectations of a worsening macro outlook and higher rates, said Pradeep Gupta, executive director and head of India investments at Lighthouse Canton.

Some market participants also point to aggressive offshore hedge-fund positioning in the non-deliverable OIS market, which is distorting domestic rates.


Rise in one-year OIS signals higher rates expectation. REUTERS

"Large offshore players have been aggressively pushing the one-year swap from around 5.5% levels to over 6.3% in a short span," a senior treasury official said, requesting anonymity.

The bond market is signalling the same shift. When investors expect rates to rise, they tend to sell existing bonds that offer lower returns. As bond prices fall, their yields move up. The two-year government bond yield has risen to around 6.5%, widening its spread over the repo to well above 100 bps.

In the past, such large OIS-repo spreads came when markets believed policy rates need to move up

In effect, market rates have already tightened. Since many loans are benchmarked to these yields, companies' borrowing costs have risen even without a policy move.

A 6 April *Mint* poll of 10 economists and market participants showed unanimous expectations of a rate pause.

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For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Applied Materials to up the game in Indian deep-techs

'Policy support, early-stage investments beginning to translate into stronger startup pipeline'

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Applied Materials, Inc. is sharpening its focus on India's deal pipeline, with its venture arm, Applied Ventures Llc, intensifying efforts to scout and evaluate deep-tech startups in the country as it shows early signs of maturity, its senior executives told *Mint*.

The US-based semiconductor equipment major is "spending more energy" tracking opportunities in India than before, as policy support and early-stage investments start translating into a stronger startup pipeline, said Om Nalamasu, chief technology officer of Applied Materials.

"With initiatives like ISM 1.0 (India Semiconductor Mission 1.0), ANRF (Anusandhan National Research Foundation), and RDI (research, development, and innovation) funds, we expect a significant increase in both the number and quality of ideas emerging from India," he said.

Nalamasu added that the firm is also engaging with government-backed initiatives such as fund-of-funds structures that aim to boost local innovation.

Applied Ventures has joined the India Deep Tech Alliance (IDTA) as a corporate strategic partner, signalling a deeper engagement with the country's semiconductor and deep-tech ecosystem. Globally, it has invested over $500 million across more than 100 firms, deploying about $100 million annually across 19 countries. It has seen more than 10 listing exits and multiple mergers and acquisitions.

In India, however, its exposure remains limited so far. One of its early investments, Tessolve, the Bengaluru-based semiconductor engineering firm, was acquired by Hero Electronix. More recently, in 2024, it made a growth equity investment in Gurugram-based electronics product design, software and manufacturing company VVDN Technologies.

The US-based chip equipment major has joined the India Deep Tech Alliance.

DEEP DIVE

FIRM engaging with government-backed initiatives aimed at boosting domestic innovation

GLOBALLY, Applied Ventures invested over $500 million across more than 100 companies

APPLIED ventures has deployed around $100 million annually across 19 countries

IT has seen more than 10 listing exits and multiple mergers and acquisitions

This India focus is part of a broader evolution in Applied Materials' presence, which has historically been centred around engineering and design.

Avi Avula, president at Applied Materials India, said the company is now moving up the value chain. "Over time, we've expanded into product development and research and development. We are moving beyond engineering and design to actually building products. As the ecosystem evolves, especially with fabs coming up, we expect to support them through sales interfaces and technical capabilities"

Despite this shift, India's contribution to the company's global revenue remains negligible on lack of semiconductor manufacturing in the country.

"We sell to fabs like TSMC or Samsung, and since India does not yet have production, revenue from the country is minimal. That will change as fabs such as Tata's come up. But for now, India's role is primarily as a delivery and engineering centre," Avula said.

India's growing demand for chips is seen as a key driver of this transition. "India is expected to become the third-largest economy and chip demand is projected to exceed $100 billion by 2030. Currently, all of this demand is met through imports," he added.

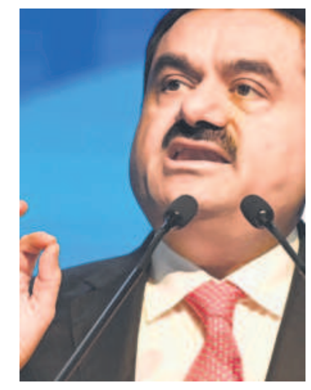
The company, which entered India in 2002, is also preparing to deepen its R&D and product development footprint in the country, backed by earlier announced investments. In 2023, Applied Materials committed $400 million over four years to build a new engineering centre in the country.

"We are waiting for ISM 2.0 to scale further, which will allow us to expand beyond design into building products and creating IP in India. Over time, this should lead to global product sales originating from India," Avula said.

Applied Materials expects its investments to catalyze wider ecosystem growth. "For every dollar we invest, we expect our suppliers to invest five times that amount. This could lead to about $2 billion of ecosystem investment," he said.

The firm believes India can play a key role in solving global tech challenges as its ecosystem matures. "India needs deep-tech for its own growth, but deep-tech also needs India," Avula said. "There is a large pool of talent that can be deployed to solve global challenges... If even a fraction of India's talent focuses on deep tech, it can significantly accelerate global innovation."

For an extended version of the story, go to livemint.com.


Gautam Adani and his nephew Sagar Adani said the case falls outside US jurisdiction. AFP

Adani seeks dismissal of SEC fraud case in US court

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Billionaire Gautam Adani and his nephew Sagar have asked a US court to dismiss a securities fraud lawsuit brought by the US Securities and Exchange Commission, arguing the case falls outside US jurisdiction and fails to establish any wrongdoing.

In a pre-motion letter ahead of a planned 30 April dismissal plea, the Adanis, through their lawyers, said the SEC's claims over a 2021 bond sale by Adani Green Energy Ltd are legally flawed on multiple grounds.

The SEC had sued the Adanis in November 2024, alleging they misled investors by failing to disclose an alleged bribery scheme tied to Indian state officials, framing the case under US securities laws.

Adanis said the $750 million bond sale was conducted outside the US under Rule 144A and Regulation S exemptions, with securities sold to non-US underwriters and only later resold in part to qualified institutional buyers. Lawyers said the complaint does not allege that Gautam Adani approved the issuance, attended key meetings, or directed any activity at US investors.

The filing also contends the SEC's case is impermissibly extraterritorial, noting the securities were not listed in the US, the issuer is Indian, and the alleged misconduct occurred entirely in India.

Citing US Supreme Court precedent, the defendants said the SEC failed to show any "domestic transaction", a requirement for applying US securities laws. They added that the SEC does not allege investor losses, and that the bonds were fully repaid with interest in 2024, while disputing the underlying bribery allegations as unsupported by credible evidence.

The filing argues that statements cited by the SEC—relating to ESG commitments, anti-corruption practices, and corporate reputation—amount to non-actionable "puffery", or general corporate optimism that investors cannot reasonably rely on. It further said the SEC failed to link either defendant to specific misleading statements or demonstrate intent to defraud.

The defendants are seeking dismissal of the case in full and said they are prepared to appear for a pre-motion conference if required.

Intel joins Musk's Terafab AI chip project

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Intel said on Tuesday it will partner with Elon Musk's Terafab artificial intelligence (AI) chip complex project alongside SpaceX and Tesla to produce processors powering the tech billionaire's robotics and data centre ambitions.

The announcement comes months after Musk laid out plans for Tesla to build a massive AI chip fab to power the electric vehicle (EV) maker's autonomous ambitions and suggested the company could work with Intel.

"Our ability to design, fabricate, and package ultra-high-performance chips at scale will help accelerate Terafab's aim to produce 1 terawatt per year of compute to power future advances in AI and robotics," Intel said in a post on social media platform X. For Intel, the partnership is set to boost investor confidence as its turnaround efforts gather steam.

Big Four pulled in for AI startup scrutiny

FROM PAGE 1

system has been trained. "We ask them to take us through the entire (code) stack."

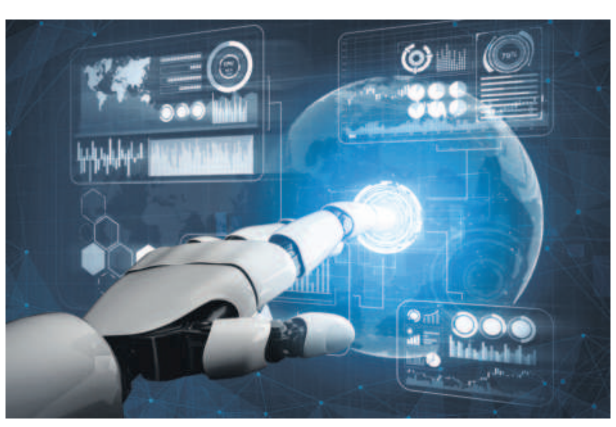
The fund brings in chief technology officers (CTOs) from portfolio companies and other experts from its network to pressure-test those claims before investing.

For advisory firms, the diligence lens is broader still. AI diligence now stretches beyond product claims to include the data layer, contracts, business viability and whether the company has the internal talent to deploy AI at scale, said Siddharth Vishwanath, advisory markets leader at PwC India.

That means checking who owns the data, whether it was acquired legitimately, whether consent and privacy safeguards are in place, how reliable and fair the outputs are, and who is liable if the AI fails.

"This kind of work is more common in private equity than in early-stage venture capital, because PE firms usually enter once a company has customers, revenue and enough operating history to test," said Vishwanath.

Strong AI products coexisting with weak governance show up "very often", especially when a PE investor is evaluating a company for the first time after earlier rounds of capital, said Vishwanath. He said roughly 70-80% of PwC's reports in such AI-linked PE deals carry recommendations across governance, privacy, cybersecurity, compliance and team capability.


AI diligence now stretches beyond just product claims. ISTOCKPHOTO

Indian AI ventures raised $832 mn in 2025, with another $633 mn flowing in during the first quarter of 2026 alone

Rohit Madan, who leads Deloitte's forensic due diligence practice, has scrutinized more than 30 startups over the past 18-24 months, giving the firm a bird's-eye view of how AI startup claims hold up.

Madan said, a startup that pitched itself as an agentic AI company still had 850 operations employees doing tagging work behind the scenes. "You're not an agentic company with such large employees working full-time for running the model," he said, describing the gap between the AI narrative and the actual operating model.

Jayant Saran, partner at Deloitte who leads forensic technology, has seen financial services emerge as a relatively easier AI category because the sector combines deep domain expertise with long experience in handling large data sets.

Healthcare and similar sectors, by contrast, are harder to underwrite because models often need to be adapted across countries, populations and systems, raising questions around data quality, scalability and real-world applicability. That makes the diligence burden heavier even when the product thesis appears strong.

Another concern is deployment economics. Abhishek Srivastava, general partner at Kae Capital, put it bluntly: "An AI product is expensive to run." Investors increasingly have to ask whether those economics still make sense once a product moves beyond the demo stage and whether founders are actually building lower-cost layers of their own over time, he said.

For Infinite Uptime, this increased diligence shaped its journey from an early pitch on digitising factory equipment to creating a real AI moat. And according to Raunak Bhinge, "It's a lot of learning from both sides–VCs as well as founders."

Data centres may spark plan change

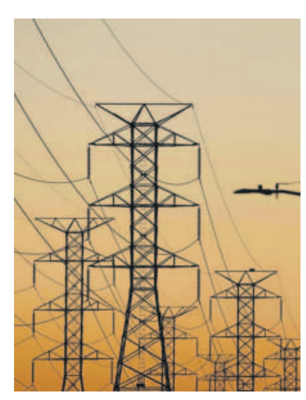
FROM PAGE 1

other emerging loads is being ascertained under the 21st Electric Power Survey Exercise. The increase in demand will be considered in the National Electricity Plan for the period from FY28 to FY37, which is expected to be released by March 2027, the ministry said.

According to Debasish Mishra, chief growth officer at Deloitte South Asia, data centres or clusters are likely to consume about 2GW of power each around the clock, which will be added to the base load. They have the potential to change the demand profile of the area and the state, which can impact the national grid, Mishra said.

For Maharashtra, Andhra Pradesh and Karnataka, 2-3GW will make a huge difference, for which planning will be required.

Instances of grid instability due to sudden surges in demand may lead to a grid collapse, he said.


Power demand rise will be considered for FY28 to FY37. AFP

However, Alok Kumar, former power secretary and current director general of the All India Discoms Association, noted that data centre hubs may not have a major impact on the country's peak demand load.

"Data centre plans and projections have been very ambitious across the globe," Kumar said. "They have not materialized as expected even in major economies. Maybe 5 to 8GW of cumulative data centre capacity will be installed by 2030."

Kumar said there could be other causes of concern in emerging areas such as space cooling including households.

Tata Trusts CEO defends action after Singh, Srinivasan cry foul

FROM PAGE 1

legal opinion and past precedent, it was open to anyone to question the appointments of non-Zoroastrians made to the Trust, in view of the specific clauses contained in the Trust Deed. It was our considered opinion that a legal opinion per se does not substitute for a judicial pronouncement. In that light, and in good faith, the Chairman requested me to speak to both Mr. Vijay Singh and Mr. Venu Srinivasan, apprise them of the situation and ask them if they would like to voluntarily step down from the said Trust."

However, following Sharma's 2 April communication, Srinivasan resigned, while Singh asked for more time. Both said in a media interview on Tuesday that the CEO had implicit bias in concealing material information, underscoring the tensions at the philanthropic entities that own Tata Sons.

Tata Trusts' efforts to simplify the structure of the 14 philanthropic entities led the secretarial team to review the trust deeds of many of the individual trusts. However, Mistry cited these clauses to allege non-compliance with the trust's deed and to question Singh and Srinivasan's continued service at Bai Hirabai Jamsetji Tata Navsari Charitable Institution (BHJTNCI).

Sir Dorabji Tata Trusts (SDTT) and Sir Ratan Tata Trusts (SRTT) hold 27.98% and 23.56%, respectively, of Tata Sons, the holding company of the Tata Group. Along with this 51.54% stake, six other Trusts own 14.36%, making the philanthropic entities the owners with 65.9% of Tata Sons. SDTT runs nine smaller Trusts while SRTT runs five trusts, including BHJTNCI.

"On receipt of the relevant documents from my team on April 4, 2026, almost within the hour, I sent out a detailed e-mail to the Trustees of BHJTNCI, enclosing both the Trust Deed and the legal opinion obtained in the year 2000 (a copy of the same was also forwarded to Mr. Venu Srinivasan for his information)," said Sharma.

Sir Dorabji Tata Trusts (SDTT) and Sir Ratan Tata Trusts (SRTT) hold 27.98% and 23.56%, respectively, of Tata Sons. BLOOMBERG

Sharma, in his letter addressed to 12 Tata Trustees, including the three children of Noel Tata, said that a few media reports alleging that material information was withheld due to implicit bias in the CEO's actions were "distressing".

In an interview with the *Economic Times*, Singh said the CEO's action indicated "seriously flawed governance and an implicit bias against the two trustees."

TRUST TROUBLE

VENU Srinivasan and Vijay Singh have accused Sharma of asking them to resign from the trust

SRTT runs five trusts, including Bai Hirabai Jamsetji Tata Navsari Charitable Institution

"I believe you acted in good faith," Srinivasan wrote to Sharma later on Tuesday evening. "However, the matter would have been resolved by seeking at least a video conference with Noel, Vijay and myself."

"Thank you for saying that you believe I acted in good faith, which I always have," Sharma replied an hour later, adding that he was extremely "surprised" and "hurt". "I am completely at a loss to understand as to how I could have acted on those allegations on the 2nd April, when they were not even made! "The chairman's desire and mine, was solely to protect the Trusts from controversy," wrote Sharma.

"There are two things here. First, a former judge's opinion has no relevance until a competent court has pronounced a judgment. Until then, a particular trust will continue to operate in accordance with the trust deed or constitution. So, in this case, Tata Trusts chair Noel and CEO Siddharth are right that a former judge's legal view is of no binding value," said senior Supreme Court lawyer H.P. Ranina.

"Second, the CEO of Tata Trusts did the right thing by asking two leaders and laying the things before them. Now, if one of them resigned, citing personal reasons, and not because of the restrictive clauses in the trust deed, then how can the CEO or the management of Tata Trust be faulted?" said Ranina.

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New company registrations up 31% as AI branding rises

Over 247,500 companies were registered in FY26 compared to 189,400 in the previous year

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India's formal economy is expanding rapidly, primarily led by technology and trade businesses, with artificial intelligence increasingly emerging as a powerful branding and business driver.

Data from the Union ministry of corporate affairs (MCA) shows IT companies and wholesale and retail trade firms topped new company registrations in each of the 12 months ending March 2026.

The trend underlines not just rising entrepreneurial activity, but also a deeper structural shift towards digitization and formalization.

In financial year 2025-26, more than 247,500 companies were registered—up 31% from more than 189,400 companies in the previous year. By the end of March 2026, India had over 2 million active companies on record.

Every 11-13 firms out of 100 newly registered ones each month were in the IT sector, the data shows. There has also been a visible surge in companies explicitly branding themselves as AI-focused. At the beginning of FY26, 84 companies in every 10,000 new registrations mentioned 'AI' in their names. By March 2026, that number had risen to 120 per 10,000 registrations.

AI branding is no longer confined to core IT services. Businesses describing themselves as AI-based are now spread across health, education and consultancy sectors, indicating growing cross-sectoral adoption, the data indicated. Wholesale and retail trade continue to form the backbone of new incorporations across the economy.

The number of companies incorporated with wholesale trade as the main activity ranged between 1,400 and 2,600 per month in FY26. Retail trade businesses incorporated during the year ranged from about 900 to 1,400 per month.

On an average, fewer than a dozen government companies—central and state combined—were formed each month during the year.

Despite the surge in registrations, most newly incorporated firms remain relatively small. Companies registered in January—the latest month for which detailed incorporation data is available—had average paid-up capital of about ₹6 lakh and authorized capital of roughly twice that amount. However, the actual investment could be significantly higher since debt typically constitutes a substantial portion of total investments.

Business registrations are often viewed as a proxy for formalization, investment intent and entrepreneurial momentum in the economy. "The consistent rise in new company incorporations, particularly in technology, trade, and AI-enabled activities signals more than just numerical growth," said Amit Maheshwari, managing partner, AKM Global, a tax and consulting firm.

"It reflects a maturing entrepreneurial mindset across India, closely tied to the country's accelerating digital adoption. Artificial intelligence is no longer confined to niche start-ups; it is increasingly being enshrined into everyday business models, whether in healthcare, delivery, professional consulting, or operational services," said Maheshwari.

"This transition points toward a more formalized and technology-driven economy, where startups and small and medium enterprises are playing a meaningful role in job creation, efficiency gains, and sustained economic expansion," he added.

Data from the statistics ministry showed that businesses, including government enterprises, are estimated to have made ₹103.3 trillion in fixed asset investments—such as plant, machinery and factories—in the financial year ended March 2026, marking an annual increase of 7.1% over the previous year.

However, incorporation growth exists alongside a still-large informal economy. While India has over two million active companies, the number of unincorporated enterprises remains far larger across the country and continues to dominate the business landscape.

According to a government survey, such establishments increased from 73.4 million during October 2023–September 2024 to 79.2 million in the January–December 2025 survey period, reflecting growth of about 7.97%.

Employment in this segment grew 6.18%, with more than 7.452 million new jobs added during the period. The informal sector employed about 128.1 million people across the country in January–December 2025.

India had over 2 million active companies on record at the end of March. MINT

AI BUSINESS BOOM

IT firms accounted for 11-13% of monthly registrations, with AI branding increasing among new firms

FIRMS mentioning 'AI' in their names increased from 84 to 120 per 10,000 registrations in FY26

AI-LED business in India are spreading across healthcare, education and consultancy

WHOLESALE and retail trade, however, remained the backbone of new incorporations

Hotel chains chase demand, but favour asset-light deals

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The next phase of India's hospitality boom is underway. Indian and global hotel chains signed pacts to manage at least 550 new hotels across the country last calendar year. The push spans pilgrimage towns, hill stations, industrial hubs and airport corridors, as the demand for branded rooms continues to outstrip supply. Hospitality firms are locking in inventory through asset-light deals, without the pressure of owning the properties.

This year too, the number is expected to look strong, early indicators suggest. Data collected by *Mint* from hotel chains and consultancies shows at least three firms—including Radisson and Marriott—have signed over a dozen hotels in 2026, riding the tourism boom and demand for branded experiences.

Last week, Hyatt signed two new hotels with the Brigade group in Chennai and Bengaluru, while IHG Hotels signed one in Nehru Place, Delhi. ITC Hotels signed up a Storii branded hotel in Mukundgarh Fort, Rajasthan.

"In 2026 so far, we've already added nine new hotels signed across markets. Our development strategy remains focused on a balanced mix of tier-1, -2, and -3 markets," said Nikhil Sharma, MD and COO, South Asia, for the Radisson Hotel Group.

That is the appeal of the asset-light model that now dominates much of the branded hotel business. In such arrangements, a developer or property owner builds the property, while the brand, such as Sarovar, Lemon Tree, Hyatt or IHG, comes in to run the hotel. The hotel operator typically earns management fees linked to revenue, and in some cases, profits, while also benefiting from room distribution, loyalty plans and brand visibility. For owners, tying up with a known hotel firm can boost occupancy, pricing and customer access.

Per industry estimates, India has only about 220,000 branded hotel rooms, and this is seen rising to 350,400 by 2030. Demand for branded hotel rooms is seen growing at a CAGR of 8-10% during FY25-28 as against the 5-6% rise likely in premium hotel rooms, as per ratings firm Icra.

India's hotel signing activity has risen at a smart pace. From 223 in 2019, it doubled to about 550 in 2025

Many businesses in the sector told *Mint* that over the last decade or so, they have moved to asset-light management contracts rather than owning the properties since it is easier to scale this way. This reflects a simple math: room demand is expected to stay ahead of supply for years, encouraging hotel brands to secure management contracts in markets where travel demand is deepening beyond the top metros.

Kiran Andicot, senior VP for South Asia at Marriott International, said 2025 was a landmark year, with 99 signings. "These were across gateway cities and emerging destinations, across luxury, premium, and select-service segments," he told *Mint*. In the first three months of 2026, the company signed up with 13 hotels.

Hotel signing activity has risen at a smart pace. From 223 contract signings in 2019, the number has doubled to about 550 in 2025. There were 484 signings in 2024. In room count too, the scale-up has been big, from 20,870 keys in 2019 to over 64,000 in 2025.

Sarovar plans 20-odd launches in 2026, while listed player Lemon Tree signed up with 56 hotels in FY26.

EIH Ltd, parent of Oberoi Hotels, said it has added managed properties in Kabini, Hampi and Coorg during the third quarter, while Indian Hotels Co Ltd, parent of Taj, has said a key driver of its next growth phase is a sharper asset management focus. In FY26, ITC Hotels signed for 33 hotels to have 220 hotels by 2030.

A clear theme emerging is that faith, leisure and infrastructure are converging to drive branded stay demand.

For an extended version of the story, go to livemint.com.

The push spans pilgrimage towns, hill stations, industrial hubs and airport corridors. MINT

Trump warns Iran again, says a 'whole civilization will die'

US president says his warning is final, tells Iran to agree to his deal and also reopen the Strait of Hormuz

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Airstrikes hit two bridges and a train station in Iran on Tuesday, and Iranian officials urged young people to form human chains to protect power plants, as US president Donald Trump warned that a "whole civilization will die tonight" if Tehran does not meet his latest deadline for the Islamic Republic to agree to a deal that includes reopen the crucial Strait of Hormuz.

Trump has extended previous deadlines but suggested the one set for 8pm in Washington was final, and the rhetoric on both sides reached a fever pitch, leaving Iranians on edge. Trump threatened to destroy all of Iran's power plants and bridges if Tehran does not allow traffic to fully resume in the strait, through which a fifth of the world's oil transits in peacetime. Iran's president said 14 million people, including himself, have volunteered to fight.

It was not clear if the latest airstrikes were linked to Trump's threat to attack bridges. At least two of the targets were connected to Iran's rail network, which Israel earlier signalled it might attack. Israel has increasingly carried out strikes that it says are aimed at delivering a blow to Iran's economy.

Iran, meanwhile, fired on Israel and Saudi Arabia, prompting the temporary closure of a major bridge. While Iran cannot match the sophistication of US and Israeli weaponry or their dominance in the air, its chokehold on the strait is causing major damage to the world economy and raising the pressure on Trump both at home and abroad to find a way out of the standoff.

Officials involved in diplomatic efforts said talks were ongoing—but Iran has rejected the latest American proposal, and it was unclear if a deal would come in time to head off Trump's threatened attacks. World leaders and experts warned that strikes as destructive as Trump threatened could constitute a war crime.

"A whole civilization will die tonight, never to be brought back again," if a deal isn't reached, Trump said in a post Tuesday morning, while keeping open the possibility of an off-ramp, saying that "maybe something revolutionarily wonderful can happen".


Trump has extended previous deadlines but suggested the one set for 8pm in Washington was final. AFP

Earlier, Iranian official Alireza Rahimi issued a video message calling on "all young people, athletes, artists, students and university students and their professors" to form human chains around power plants.

Iranians have formed human chains in the past around nuclear sites at times of heightened tensions with the West. This time though, it was unclear who would heed the call, and one major power plant in Tehran apparently had been closed off for security purposes at the time the demonstration was to start.

President Masoud Pezeshkian posted on X that 14 million Iranians had answered state media and text message campaigns urging people to volunteer to fight—and said he would join them—while a general from the paramilitary Revolutionary Guard urged parents to send their children to man checkpoints.

Officials involved in diplomatic efforts said talks were ongoing — but Iran has rejected the latest US proposal

The Guard, meanwhile, warned that Iran would "deprive the US and its allies of the region's oil and gas for years" and expand its attacks across the Gulf region if Trump carries out his threat.

In Tehran, the mood was bleak. A young teacher said that many opponents of Iran's Islamic system had hoped Trump's attacks would quickly topple it.

Now, as the war drags on, she fears US and Israeli attacks will spread chaos. "If we don't have the internet, and if we don't have electricity, water, and gas, we're really going back to the Stone Age, as Trump said," she said told The Associated Press, speaking anonymously for her safety.

French foreign minister Jean-Noël Barrot joined a growing chorus of international voices and calling for restraint, saying attacks targeting civilian and energy infrastructure "are barred by the rules of war, international law".

"They would without doubt trigger a new phase of escalation, of reprisals, that would drag the region and the world economy into a vicious circle," the minister said on France Info television.

UN secretary-general António Guterres also warned the US that attacks on civilian infrastructure are banned under international law, according to his spokesperson.

Such cases are notoriously difficult to prosecute, and Trump told reporters he's "not at all" concerned about committing war crimes.

A series of intense airstrikes pounded Tehran, including in residential neighbourhoods. Such strikes in the past have targeted Iranian government and security officials.

Israel's military said it attacked an Iranian petrochemical site in Shiraz, the second day in a row it hit such a facility.

Israel also issued a Farsi-language warning telling Iranians to avoid trains throughout the day, likely telegraphing intended strikes on the rail network.

Iranian officials later said that a railway bridge, a train station and a highway bridge had been hit in airstrikes. Neither the US nor Israel immediately claimed the attacks.

Another strike hit the Khorramabad International Airport in western Iran, and an attack on an unidentified target in Alborz province, northwest of Tehran, killed 18 people, according to state media. A total of 15 people were killed in other strikes, Iranian media reported.

Early Tuesday, Tehran launched seven ballistic missiles at Saudi Arabia, which authorities said rained debris near energy facilities as they were intercepted.

The attacks prompted Saudi Arabia to temporarily close the King Fahd Causeway, the only road connection between Bahrain, home to the US Navy's 5th Fleet, and the Arabian Peninsula.

Iran also fired on Israel, with reports of incoming missiles in Tel Aviv and Eilat.

More than 1,900 people have been killed in Iran since the war began, but the government has not updated the toll for days. In Gulf Arab states and the occupied West Bank, more than two dozen people have died, while 23 have been reported dead in Israel, and 13 US service members have been killed.

Iran choked off shipping through the strait after Israel and the US attacked on 28 February, starting the war. That stranglehold and Iran's attacks on the energy infrastructure of its Gulf Arab neighbours have sent oil prices rocketing, raising the price of petrol, food and other basics far beyond West Asia.

In spot trading Tuesday, Brent crude, the international standard, was above $108 per barrel, up around 50% since the start of the war.

On Monday, Tehran rejected a 45-day ceasefire proposal and said it wants a permanent end to the war. But as Trump's deadline neared Tuesday, an official said indirect communications between the US and Iran remained under way.


Prime minister Keir Starmer-led UK government has reaffirmed that it will allow only defensive missions from its airbases. AFP

UK signals it won't let US use bases for Iran energy strikes

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The UK government signalled it won't let the US use British military bases for strikes on Iranian energy or civilian infrastructure after President Donald Trump threatened an escalation of operations against Tehran.

Asked Tuesday about Trump's threat to bomb the Islamic republic's bridges and power plants if Iran doesn't agree to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, prime minister Keir Starmer's spokesman Tom Wells pointed to Britain's position since the early days of the war that the US could only use its bases at RAF Fairford in Gloucestershire, England and Diego Garcia in the Indian Ocean for what the UK government has called "defensive" missions.

"Our principles have been clear from day one," Wells said. "Our position on this hasn't changed." He declined to say whether the UK would consider the destruction of civilian infrastructure by the US as a war crime.

Wells' remarks highlight the diplomatic tightrope Starmer's Labour administration is walking as it seeks to allow its bases to be used in defence of British interests and allies while maintaining a position—reiterated Tuesday by the premier's spokesman—that "this is not our war".

The government has published a summary of legal advice arguing that granting American basing requests for defensive operations is in line with Britain's commitments to international law. However, it can be a war crime to target civilian infrastructure because doing so can punish non-combatants. Trump has threatened to bomb Iran "back to the Stone Ages, where they belong" if it doesn't agree a deal with the US, including "blowing up and completely obliterating all of their electric generating plants".

"The agreement in place is for the US to use UK bases for the collective self-defence of the region, including US defensive operations to degrade missile sites and capabilities used to attack ships in the Strait of Hormuz," Wells said.

Starmer has insisted he will not bow to pressure from Trump to expand the UK's role in the conflict

Starmer's initial refusal to approve US basing requests at the start of the war has provoked repeated criticism from the president, whose most recent remarks this week appeared to compare the British prime minister to Neville Chamberlain, the premier at the onset of World War II whose name became synonymous with appeasement of Adolf Hitler. Starmer, however, has insisted he will not bow to pressure from Trump to expand the UK's role in the current conflict.

How China helped Iran cushion the blow of sanctions and fund its war machine

Rory Jones, Brian Spegele & Austin Ramzy

In the first Trump administration, the U.S. launched a "maximum pressure" campaign to cut Iranian oil from the global market and eliminate Tehran's biggest source of revenue. Today, Iran sells billions of dollars worth of oil every month.

For that, it can thank one country: China.

Tehran's Asian partner has dramatically increased the amount of Iranian oil it buys as sanctions have gotten tighter. It now takes nearly every drop Iran produces, compared with around 30% a decade ago.

To make those purchases possible, Chinese buyers have worked closely with Iran to expand what U.S. officials and researchers say has become one of the world's largest sanctions-evasion networks.

Payments are routed through smaller Chinese banks that have limited global operations and less to lose if they are sanctioned by the U.S., making it hard to stop them. Front companies established by Iran in Hong Kong and elsewhere help manage the proceeds.

Private Chinese refineries, known as "teapots," have become the primary buyers of Iranian crude, after China's state-owned energy giants, wary of upsetting Washington, left the market. Fake invoices and mislabeled crude have further disguised the trade.

All these moves—laid out in U.S. sanctions documents, public indictments and described by Western officials and researchers—have allowed Iran to earn tens of billions of dollars in revenue every year from China, and then launder it so it can be used around the world.

China is Iran's "chief partner in sanctions evasion," said Max Meizlish at the Foundation for Defense of Democracies, a Washington-based think tank. "Iran just wouldn't be able to fight this war without the years of support that it has received from China."

In a written response, China's Foreign Ministry said it firmly opposes "illegal and unreasonable unilateral sanctions," and it has previously said it would do what it sees as necessary to protect its energy security. Behind the scenes, Beijing has been wary of being seen to openly violate sanctions, which could provoke Washington's wrath and damage its relations with other Gulf states.

Still, unlike other nations, China has continued to find Iranian crude irresistible. It needs the energy, and it can get Iran's oil at a sharp discount after U.S. sanctions scared off other buyers. Buying a lot of it also frustrates U.S. objectives in the Middle East.

The U.S. has tried to rein in the trade, indicting some individuals and expanding the sanctions. But it has been limited in how far it can go in targeting China by the risk of sending global oil prices higher and destabilizing U.S.-China ties.

The sanctions-busting system has continued to function since the Iran war began, even as Tehran has effectively closed the Strait of Hormuz to Western shipping. Iran has mined the strait and threatened attacks on ships carrying oil from U.S. allies, while tankers laden with its own products still sail toward Chinese ports.


Chinese buyers have worked closely with Iran to expand 'one of the world's largest sanctions-evasion networks'. AFP

Officially, China's customs authorities haven't reported any crude imports from Iran from 2023 onward, which researchers say is intended to reduce political tensions with Washington.

But Kpler, a commodity research firm that tracks tanker movements, estimates China bought roughly 1.4 million barrels of oil a day from Iran in 2025.

That was more than 80% of Iran's oil sales last year and more than double the roughly 650,000 barrels a day it bought in 2017, before President Trump's maximum pressure campaign began.

Maximum pressure

Many years ago, when sanctions against Tehran were less strict, Chinese state-owned oil companies openly purchased Iranian crude, as did many other buyers around the world.

The Obama administration tightened the rules, making it much tougher to do business with Iran. It then eased sanctions after reaching a nuclear accord with Tehran in 2015. Numerous countries, including India, Italy and Greece, stepped up their purchases of Iranian oil.

Everything changed when Trump first came into office. He threw out the Obama nuclear accord and launched his maximum-pressure campaign with the toughest sanctions yet, threatening to punish anyone who bought or financed the purchase of Iranian oil.

Iranian sales plummeted from nearly 2.8 million barrels a day in May 2018 to roughly 200,000 in August 2019, according to Kpler, as buyers dropped out of the market.

But Iran was quick to respond—with China's help.

Forced to rethink how it sold its oil, Tehran accelerated the build-out of a clandestine trading network, according to U.S. officials and researchers. It set up oil-sales firms with obscure names such as Sahara Thunder and Sepehr Energy and created fictitious invoices stating Iranian oil was from other nations such as Oman or Malaysia, the officials and researchers said.

The U.S. sanctions certainly made life harder for Tehran, increasing the cost of selling its oil, and reducing Iranian revenues. But Tehran consistently found a way to sell oil and access the proceeds, eventually dealing almost entirely with China.

By the end of 2022, Iran's exports had picked up to more than a million barrels a day, with China making up the biggest chunk, according to Kpler.

One key to making the trade possible was the expansion of a shadow fleet of tankers to move sanctioned oil between Iran and China, U.S. officials and researchers say.

Tanker operators based across the Middle East, China and elsewhere practiced creative subterfuge, changing the names of vessels, turning off equipment signaling their positions, and transferring Iranian crude from one ship to another while en route to China to disguise its origin.

One China-based tanker network, established in 2019, now comprises at least 56 vessels that have funneled more than 400 million barrels of sanctioned oil, according to C4ADS, a Washington-based nonprofit that specializes in national-security threats.

Filling the 'teapots'

Inside China, however, the oil needed buyers.

Iran's traditional customers, including state-owned giants Sinopec and China National Petroleum Corp., or CNPC, have extensive global operations, which meant they couldn't afford to lose access to U.S. financial markets for violating sanctions buying Iranian oil.

But China also has a network of smaller refineries—the so-called teapots—which operate independently of the state-owned energy giants. These companies are less exposed to sanctions because they are thought to pay for oil from Iran using yuan instead of dollars.

Beijing gradually increased the amount of oil the teapots could import. Previously, the teapots were limited in how much they could bring in by quotas set by the state.

China's crude-import quota for nonstate trade—a measure of how much the teapot sector can import—grew from 140 million metric tons in 2018 to 257 million metric tons this year, according to official Chinese data.

Money flows

Chinese buyers still had to figure out how to pay for the oil, because U.S. sanctions strictly limited banks from doing business with Iran.

They turned to smaller Chinese institutions that, like the teapots, had less to lose than China's biggest banks if they were targeted by the U.S.

One such bank, U.S. officials say, is the Bank of Kunlun, which got its start in a desert city near China's border with Kazakhstan, before being taken over by the Chinese oil major CNPC in 2009.

In 2012, the U.S. sanctioned Kunlun for allegedly providing hundreds of millions of dollars of financial services to Iranian banks, including moving money for them and paying their letters of credit, effectively cutting off Kunlun's access to the U.S. financial system. That only solidified Kunlun as a go-to choice for facilitating trade with Iran in China's currency.

Payments are routed through smaller Chinese banks that have less to lose if they are sanctioned by the U.S.

The bank grew rapidly, financial disclosures show. A "significant portion" of Iran's oil revenue was deposited at the institution as of 2022, according to the U.S. Treasury.

Bank of Kunlun didn't respond to a request for comment through CNPC.

Complex deals

Indictments filed in U.S. federal court provide a deeper picture of how American investigators think the China-Iran trade works.

In one case, in 2024, U.S. prosecutors alleged that buyers of Iranian crude at times engaged directly with Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, negotiating and carrying out multimillion-dollar oil deals through a front for the Iranians called China Oil & Petroleum Co.

In an episode described in the indictment, a ship identified as the *Oman Pride* picked up Iranian crude on Sirri Island in the Persian Gulf. Another boat outside the Gulf, meanwhile, transmitted fake signals pretending to be the *Oman Pride*. Later, the Iranian oil was unloaded from the real *Oman Pride* and transferred to another vessel before being delivered to China.

Front companies in Hong Kong and elsewhere have been used to convert Chinese yuan into dollars, euros or other foreign currencies Iran needs, *The Wall Street Journal* has reported. One Iranian exchange house, part of a large financial institution called Bank Tejarat, oversaw 66 front companies in Hong Kong and China, according to research by Udi Levy, the former head of the economic warfare unit of Israel's Mossad intelligence agency.

In some cases, Chinese buyers didn't even need to send money for payment.

Instead, they arranged to trade services through a barter system in which state-backed Chinese companies in Iran build infrastructure there as compensation for oil. Up to the equivalent $8.4 billion in oil payments flowed through this funding conduit in 2024, the *Journal* previously reported.

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NEWS IN NUMBERS

$30 bn
ANTHROPIC'S ANNUALIZED revenue run-rate currently, up from $9 billion at end-2025, driven by global demand for its Claude AI models

₹2.5 tn
THE CREDIT guarantee scheme the government is considering to support micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs) hit by the West Asia war

₹100 cr
THE SEED funding amount raised by OffBeat Studios, founded by boAt co-founder Aman Gupta, in a round led by Bessemer Venture Partners

₹60,655 cr
THE AMOUNT FPIs pulled out of India's financial services sector in March, accounting for over 50% of total equity outflows of ₹1.17 trillion, per NSDL data

₹20,530 cr
VALUE OF Lodha Developers' bookings in FY26, up 16% from ₹17,630 crore in FY25, but short of ₹21,000 crore guidance owing to the impact of war in West Asia

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MINT

Trai nudges telcos on fair pricing, wider choice

If implemented, proposal could benefit feature phone & low-income users, elderly subscribers

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The Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (Trai) is tightening rules on mobile tariffs after finding that telecom operators have fallen short of its earlier mandate on voice-and-SMS-only plans, limiting choice and blunting price benefits for users.

In draft regulations released on Tuesday, the regulator proposed that telecom companies offer voice-and-SMS-only plans across all recharge durations, not just a handful of long-term packs, and ensure these are priced lower than bundled plans that include data.

The move follows Trai's review of its December 2024 rules, which had required operators to offer at least one such plan. It found that companies largely complied in form, offering only a couple of long-duration options such as 80/84 days or annual packs, leaving users with limited flexibility.

"After the introduction of these exclusive voice and SMS STVs (special tariff vouchers), several concerns and representations from consumers and their associations have been received by the Authority, expressing need for shorter-duration voice and SMS only packs," Trai said in the draft regulations.

If implemented in its current form, the proposal could benefit low-income users, elderly subscribers and those using feature phones, who typically prefer shorter-duration, lower-cost recharges without data.

Trai said the changes are aimed at preventing consumers from being pushed into bundled plans. "At the same time, it provides consumers with greater choice of Voice and SMS-only packs, placing them at par with data-inclusive packs," it said, adding that lack of parity goes against the objective of ensuring fair, equal and non-discriminatory choices for all consumers, regardless of their service requirements.

It has sought comments from stakeholders by 28 April.

Voice-and-SMS-only plans were first mandated by Trai in December 2024, through the 12th amendment to its consumer protection rules. Operators were asked to offer at least one special tariff voucher exclusively for voice and SMS with validity period not exceeding 365 days.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Govt may seek revised bids for IDBI Bank

Centre may seek revised financial bids for IDBI Bank as original bids were below reserve price. MINT

The government may ask for revised financial bids from two potential buyers of IDBI Bank as their original bid amounts were lower than the reserve price fixed for the strategic sale of the lender, persons aware of the matter said. "The IDBI Bank strategic sale is in the technical evaluation stage," a senior official told *PTI*.

After over three years of pursuance, the strategic sale of IDBI Bank had reached the final stage of financial bid, and the government wants to avoid further delay that restarting the process again would entail.

The government and the Life Insurance Corp. of India were together looking to sell 60.72% in IDBI Bank and had floated an Expression of Interest (EoI) in October 2022. Financial bids came on 6 February.

After that, the government set the reserve price for the strategic sale. The financial bids for the IDBI Bank strategic sale, however, came in lower than the reserve price set by the inter-ministerial group on disinvestment headed by secretaries in the finance ministry.

Following that, the strategic sale of IDBI Bank hit a roadblock. PTI

Reassessment of Vi AGR dues by June

The telecom department expects that adjusted gross revenue (AGR) reassessment for Vodafone Idea—which received government relief for its dues and liabilities—will be completed by June, persons in the know said. The reassessment was earlier targeted for completion by 31 March.

The persons said the review of Spectrum Usage Charge (SUC) is on, following the internal licence fee reassessment by Controller of Communication Accounts. Accordingly, the timeline has been extended to June, the persons said.

The Union cabinet has given relief to Vodafone Idea Ltd (Vi) based on the Supreme Court order and "frozen" its Adjusted Gross Revenue dues at ₹87,695 crore for a period ranging from FY 2006-07 to FY 2018-19.

The "frozen" dues are subject to reassessment. PTI

Kalyan's India operations posted revenue gains of over 65% in the March quarter compared with a year ago.

Kalyan Jewellers Q4 revenue surges 64%

Kalyan Jewellers India Ltd reported 64% jump in consolidated revenue for the fourth quarter of fiscal year 2025-26, buoyed by robust wedding and discretionary jewellery purchases even as gold prices remained volatile.

The jewellery retailer had a revenue of ₹6,222.35 crore in the same quarter a year earlier, a company statement said. For full fiscal year FY26, consolidated revenue rose approximately 42% from the prior year, when the company recorded annual revenue of ₹25,189.66 crore.

India operations, which drove the bulk of growth, posted revenue gains of over 65% in the March quarter compared with a year ago, with same-store sales growth exceeding 45%. The domestic business grew approximately 43% for the full year. International operations, which contributed about 11% to consolidated quarterly revenue, grew approximately 45% in the quarter.

Within West Asia, revenue rose about 39%, though geopolitical tensions in the region dampened customer footfall during the first three weeks of March. A strong Ramadan sales surge in the final 10 days of the month offset the shortfall, the company said. PTI

Rupee closes at 93 to a dollar

The rupee closed stronger on Tuesday, supported by the unwinding of residual arbitrage positions, while traders braced for a US deadline to reach a deal with Iran and the Reserve Bank of India's monetary policy decision.

The rupee closed up 0.1% at 93.0075 against the US dollar, its strongest closing level since mid-March. The currency has found its footing after hitting a series of record lows over the past month, helped largely by the RBI's measures to curb arbitrage and speculative activity in the domestic foreign exchange market.

The rupee lately came under pressure from the escalating conflict in West Asia. REUTERS

India to back vessel insurers amid war

India is planning sovereign guarantees to support insurers that provide cover for vessels travelling in the Persian Gulf, as the war in West Asia increases the risks to shipping, said government and industry sources familiar with the matter.

The plan includes a $1.5 billion sovereign guarantee fund to provide insurers with reinsurance support and liquidity should insurance costs remain high, said one government official.

A separate $300 million fund with contributions from the country's insurance industry is also being set up to help settle any large increase in insurance claims, the same official said. PTI

The move is part of a broader push to stabilize fuel supplies amid war-led disruptions. REUTERS

Govt doubles 5kg LPG cylinder quota

The government has doubled the daily quota of market-priced 5kg LPG cylinders for migrant workers as part of a broader push to stabilize fuel supplies amid disruptions linked to tensions around the Strait of Hormuz.

At a news briefing, Sujata Sharma, joint secretary in the ministry of petroleum and natural gas, said the government vide letter dated 6 April has conveyed that daily quantity of 5kg free trade LPG (FTL) cylinders in each state available for disbursal to migrant labourers is being doubled based on the average daily supply (number of such cylinders) during 2–3 March.

Unlike the subsidised 14.2kg cylinders that are used in household kitchens for cooking, the 5kg bottles are priced at market rates. A 5kg cylinder costs ₹549 in Delhi as against the ₹913 price for a 14.2kg domestic cylinder. PTI

EV retail sales up 25% in FY26: Fada

Total electric vehicle (EV) retail sales in India grew by 24.6% at 2.45 million units in FY26 compared with FY25, with every category delivering strong double-digit growth, Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations (Fada) said on Tuesday. While electric two-wheelers crossed 1.4 million units, electric passenger vehicle retail sales missed the 200,000 units by a whisker but surged 83.63% in FY26, Fada said in a statement. "FY26 has been a watershed year for India's electric mobility story. Total EV retail across two-wheelers, three-wheelers, passenger vehicles, and commercial vehicles stood at approximately 24.52 lakh units, growing nearly 24.6% y-o-y, with every category delivering strong double-digit growth," Fada president C. S. Vigneshwar said. In the electric PV category, total sales were at 199,923 units in FY26 compared with 108,873 units in FY25, a growth of 83.63%. PTI

(From left) Astronauts Jeremy Hansen, Christina Koch, Reid Wiseman and Victor Glover. AFP

Artemis II crew heads back to Earth

Nasa's four Artemis astronauts swung behind the moon and are headed home, in a journey that shattered space travel distance records and brought people the closest they've been to the lunar surface in more than 50 years.

At their nearest distance to the moon, the Artemis II's Orion capsule came within an estimated 4,067 miles of the lunar surface, according to calculations by Nasa. From the crew's point of view, the moon would have appeared roughly the size of a basketball in someone's outstretched hand. The spacecraft reached its maximum distance from Earth minutes later, reaching 252,756 miles, Nasa administrator Jared Isaacman said in a post on X.

The astronauts earlier broke the distance record for space travel. Shortly before 2pm New York time on Monday, they surpassed the distance the Apollo 13 crew travelled in 1970 of 248,655 miles (400,170km) from Earth, Nasa said. The close approach was the pinnacle moment of Nasa's Artemis II mission, which launched to space on Wednesday, 1 April, sending Nasa astronauts Reid Wiseman, Victor Glover, Christina Koch and Hansen en route to the moon. BLOOMBERG

No cash at toll plazas from 10 Apr

Cash payments at toll plazas will be discontinued for travellers on national highways from 10 April, the road transport and highways ministry has said.

In a gazette notification, the ministry has said that in cases where a vehicle enters a fee plaza without a valid FASTag, users can still pay via Unified Payment Interface (UPI), but at a higher charge of 1.25 times the applicable toll fee. A senior NHAI official said the move is aimed at reducing long queues at toll gates and at making highway travel smoother for commuters. The official said FASTag will remain the primary mode of toll collection from 10 April, while UPI will serve as the fallback payment option. "Provided that if the owner or driver of the vehicle does not opt to pay a fee in the manner specified under this rule [sub-rule (2) of rule 4], such vehicle shall be dealt in accordance with rule 14," the notification said. There are over 1,150 fee plazas on various national highways and expressways in the country. PTI

TRP reporting withheld for 4 weeks

The Centre's move aims to curb display of speculative content, sensationalism. MINT

The government has extended for four weeks its order to withhold the reporting of Television Rating Points (TRPs) for TV news channels with the aim of "curbing display of sensationalism and speculative content" amid the West Asia war. The ministry of information and broadcasting had on 6 March issued the first directive to the television rating agency Broadcast Audience Research Council (Barc) to immediately withhold reporting the TRPs for TV news channels for a period of four weeks or until further orders, whichever is earlier.

"The said direction was aimed towards curbing the display of unwarranted sensationalism and speculative content by some news genre channels amid the West Asia conflict, which may potentially create panic among the general public, especially those having friends and family in the affected areas or residing in affected areas," the fresh order from the Ministry said, adding the "conflict situation still largely prevails at the moment".

In the public interest, the ministry said, it directs M/s BARC to withhold reporting the TRPs for news TV channels for a further period of four weeks or until further directions, whichever is earlier. PTI

India moves closer to nuclear fuel self-reliance

India has moved closer to producing its own nuclear fuel after a domestic-designed reactor began a controlled nuclear reaction, an important step before it can start generating power. Energy-hungry India, the world's most populous country and third-largest emitter of greenhouse gases, has ambitious plans to expand nuclear power capacity from its current eight to 100 gigawatts by 2047. Prime Minister Narendra Modi said the Prototype Fast Breeder Reactor (PFBR) at Kalpakkam attained "criticality", the stage at which a self-sustaining nuclear chain reaction starts. Modi called it a "decisive step towards harnessing our vast thorium reserves", a potential fuel for nuclear reactors. The reactor does not yet generate electricity for the grid. That comes in the next stages, once the reactor moves to full power operation. The development also comes at a time of global energy uncertainty, including West Asia war, which has heightened concerns about fuel supply disruptions. India remains heavily dependent on coal, but has pledged to reach net-zero emissions by 2070. AFP

Prototype Fast Breeder Reactor at Kalpakkam attained 'criticality'. AP

Pvt banks beat PSBs in deposit growth

Private sector banks reported stronger deposit growth in the January-March quarter compared with their public sector peers, even as the broader banking system continued to face persistent challenges in mobilising deposits. Data compiled by *PTI* from banks' provisional numbers disclosures showed that private sector lenders recorded deposit growth in the range of 12–17% in Q4FY26, compared with 2–14% growth among PSU banks. Banks have increasingly relied on mobilizing funds through certificates of deposit (CDs) in recent quarters amid sustained pressure on low-cost deposits. Deposit mobilization has remained challenging, particularly on the current account and savings account (Casa) front, as relatively lower interest rates have made such deposits less attractive compared with other financial instruments. Among private lenders, IDFC First Bank reported the highest growth, with deposits rising 17.2% to ₹2.43 trillion in Q4FY26. PTI

ASSAM POLL: WELFARE AND INFRA HOG THE LIMELIGHT

The north-eastern state, which has a 126-member assembly, votes tomorrow. A ground report.

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BARPETA/NAGAON/MANGALDOI/DIBRUGARH

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma (left) addresses a public gathering in Nagaon, Assam, on 15 February; a file photo of the opposition Congress Party's Gaurav Gogoi. PTI

On a cool, rainy April day, a group of women sell vegetables on the roadside in Motha Dang village in Sivasagar, upper Assam. They are vocal about their choices and motivations in the upcoming election.

"We have received a lot of benefits from the government—cash transfers, free ration, rural houses, gas connections and more. Plus, it has made roads, highways and bridges," says Pranali Kalita Bora, noting that the government has done a lot for women and for the poor. Biju Saikia, Kalpana Saikia and Deepika Gogoi concur with that summation.

As with the last election, infrastructure and welfare delivery have again emerged as the biggest buzzwords in the run-up to this election. Despite chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma of the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) attempting to make a sharp detour from the state's ethnic identity politics to strike a communal tone, conversations on the ground revolve around 'unnayan' (development) and 'xubidha' (benefits).

Assam, which has a 126-member assembly, votes on Thursday, 9 April, with counting scheduled for 4 May along with other poll-bound states. In the 2021 election, the BJP won 60 seats with a 33.2% vote share, while the Congress won 29 seats and cornered a vote share of 29.2%.

There is much at stake both for the ruling BJP and the main opposition Congress, and for the two state leaders leading these respective camps: CM Sarma and Gaurav Gogoi.

REFERENDUM ON MAMA

With this election, the BJP will seek a third consecutive term in power. The stakes are even bigger for Sarma, who is seeking re-election as chief minister for the first time. In 2021, then chief minister Sarbananda Sonowal led the BJP to a second term, but Sarma, with his mass presence, organizational hold and the high command's blessings, took the coveted post.

Sarma is quite unequivocally the face of the BJP in this election, unlike earlier when Prime Minister Narendra Modi was the trump card and the go-to name for voters. If in 2021, those supporting the BJP cited Modi and his work as the main factor (and those opposed blamed him), in 2026, it is Sarma or "mama" that is synonymous with the BJP.

Nipen Rompi of Morigaon, says he will support "mama" because of all the development work done by him, the infrastructure boost and welfare schemes for the needy. On the other hand, Pranab Jyoti Bora of Hajo says he wants to see a change in regime because he does not quite appreciate the CM's public conduct and political language.

CONGRESS ON THE BACKFOOT

For the Congress, this is a battle for survival. The party, which had a strong footing in the state and ruled it for three consecutive terms under former chief minister Tarun Gogoi, Gaurav's father, has seen its fortunes decline since the BJP stormed to power.

The Congress seems to be struggling with a cohesive and powerful narrative to counter the BJP. Its biggest hope would be if voters yearn for change amid a two-term anti incumbency.

Much like Prime Minister Modi, Sarma has created a beneficiary base among Assam's women voters, who are now a vocal, independent and aware electorate

Besides the BJP's hold over the electorate today, what makes the election even more challenging for the Congress is the distortion in electoral math caused by the 2023 delimitation exercise. The redrawing of the boundaries of parliamentary and state legislature constituencies in Assam has meant a very significant dip in the number of seats where the Congress enjoyed a demographic advantage in terms of the minority vote.

For Gogoi, this is an uphill task given the party's recent free fall in the state, its very public internal divisions, and, of course, the Sarma regime's might and mass reach. The Congress leader, while well-liked in the state, is seen by many as a better fit to represent Assam in Delhi.

"We like Gaurav. He seems nice and upright. He is doing a great job of articulating Assam's concerns in Parliament. But we wonder if he is a good fit for the state, if he is connected to the grassroots," says Manab Bayan of Barpeta in lower Assam.

Gogoi has had quite a history of hostility with CM Sarma, a former Congressman, who was once his father's righthand man. The chief minister, on several occasions, has launched direct attacks against Gogoi and his family, making this a rather bitter battle.

What poses a bigger problem for the Congress is the strong beneficiary base created by Sarma and what is seen as the BJP government's push for visible infrastructure growth.

WELFARE AND INFRASTRUCTURE

Across Assam, the biggest conversation points in this election are around roads, highways and flyovers on the one hand, and cash transfers, free ration, rural housing and overall state aid on the other. Voters see these as the most crucial factors influencing their voting decisions.

"Sarma's government has made so many good roads and highways. Our village had no roads earlier. Plus, there has been a lot done for the poor," says Manoj Deori of Jorhat. "Not everyone has received benefits, but most have received one or the other and generally, the welfare outreach of this government is helping the state."

The BJP has unleashed a cocktail of welfarism in the state, from initiatives such as the Direct Benefits Transfer Scheme Orunodoi, under which nearly four million women received ₹9,000 each on 1 March, the Mahila Udyamita Abhiyan, which promises to empower women entrepreneurs, self-employment schemes Atmanirbhar Asom Abhijan and Assam Kalpataru Scheme, as well as the Modi government's existing programmes, including rural housing and Ujjwala.

The construction of roads, highways and flyovers across the state has bolstered the Sarma government's image of being development-oriented.

These factors seem to be most pertinent across geographies and age, with even young, first-time voters citing them as their priorities. Take, for instance, a classroom of mostly first-time but articulate and passionate voters in the prestigious Dibrugarh Hanumanbax Surajmall Kanoi College, who say infrastructure, outreach to the needy and quality education are their topmost concerns.

Says Bipasha Das, a fourth semester zoology honours student: "There is a lot being done for the poor and women. I come from a less privileged background, but government aid has facilitated my education and has helped improve our daily lives."

Her classmate Aishwarya Dutta nods in agreement. Jyotishman Gogoi, a sixth semester student, cites the importance of good infrastructure as an enabler for the youth to pursue education, employment and other opportunities for growth.

A direct consequence of a welfare platform is the creation of an important vote bank in women. Much like Prime Minister Modi, Sarma has created a beneficiary base among Assam's women voters, who are now a vocal, independent and aware electorate.

In Bhebarghat village, health workers Barnali Boniya and Tuli Kalita are in a rush to get to work. As they spare a moment to discuss the ongoing elections, they say they will support the BJP, pointing to benefits such as cash transfers, LPG cylinders, ration and BPL support. They claim that while some schemes haven't reached them directly, they know the benefits are reaching the most needy women across the state, and that gives them confidence in the government.

THE GAPS

However, not everyone has received those benefits equally, and those who haven't, are not happy. "The government may have announced many schemes, but local BJP leaders deny us many benefits. I am a victim myself and hence, I don't support this government," says Parul Deori of Raha, as she stocks up her week's supplies at a local grocery store.

Voters also cite rising prices as a worrying trend, urging the government to step in. In Bezpara village, Purobi Deka backs the BJP for development and welfare, but flags inflation. "Price rise hits the middle class the hardest and should be addressed, even if it means reducing some cash transfers," says Deka, taking a nuanced view of how women voters weigh welfare against everyday costs.

In the Diffloo Tea Estate in Bokakhat, upper Assam, workers are busy plucking leaves braving a drizzle. Without looking up from their plucking duties, many say benefits from government schemes have not reached them as expected, and raise demands around land titles, Scheduled Tribes status, wages, and better access to education.

"We have not received anything—not money under Orunodoi, not the ST status we demanded, not land titles or any facilities from the government. We need government support, but we don't receive anything," says Baby Bakti.

The tea tribes constitute about 17-20% of the state's population and are an influential electorate in around 30 seats, making them a coveted vote bank.

Another pain point for Bakti: no justice for Zubeen Garg. The extremely popular singer's sudden death in Singapore last year triggered a wave of sorrow, ire and protests in Assam, and continues to be an emotional conversation point. Some hold the government responsible for the delay while others express disappointment.

Ambarish Nath of Nagaon says while Sarma promised justice for Garg, he has been unable to deliver on it. "The government's work might otherwise be fine, but on this count, it has failed miserably and I may not want to support it because of this," he says.

NEW IDENTITY POLITICS

The big change in Assam under the BJP, and more specifically under Sarma, is an altered political language that revolves around a religion-based divide as against the state's old ethnicity and linguistic faultlines.

Sarma has pursued a particularly aggressive brand of Hindutva politics, introducing a sharp communal element to the state's identity schisms. The Assam Agitation and anti-outsider movement of the late 1970s, 1980s and 1990s were mainly targeted at people of Bangladeshi origin and Bengali roots, irrespective of religion. The 1990s saw violent attacks even on the Marwari and Punjabi communities, driving many out of the state.

The current regime, however, has attempted to focus attention on miyas, a term used to denote Muslim migrants of Bengali origin.

Among the voters of Assam, however, this isn't a cleavage that has gained as much traction as Sarma and company may have hoped for. Most, including those who are pro-BJP, express discomfort with this brazen "Hindu-Muslim" politics and say this isn't in Assam's DNA.

For instance, in Mangaldoi, which, in a sense, is at the heart of Assam's ethnicity struggle given how a by-election here in the late 1970s triggered the Assam Agitation, voters say it isn't religion that divides them.

Jayanta Sarma and Trailokya Deka say they reject "Hindu–Muslim politics" and emphasise that India is a secular country. They, however, insist that "outsiders" without citizenship—regardless of religion—should be sent back, reflecting enduring ethnic concerns.

Dhiren Barua of Kaliabor feels even more strongly about the issue. "CM Sarma's language and public conduct make me feel deeply uncomfortable. His words and behaviour do not reflect the dignity of his office. I have seen so many leaders over the years, but nobody has spoken the way he does."

Those supporting the BJP and Sarma seem to be doing so despite this communal rhetoric and not so much because of it, focussing on the delivery of benefits and on development work.

As Sarma continues to raise the pitch on communal politics, it is the minority community that is most on edge. As per the Census of 2011, Muslims constitute a little over 34% of the state's population. With the political rhetoric increasingly veering towards communal dog whistling, this population is increasingly feeling targeted.

Zia-Ul-Mohammad of Ghilakuri village in Darrang says he would prefer change and would like to see Gogoi as chief minister. His view is driven by deep discomfort with the chief minister's communal politics, which he feels is not in keeping with Assam's ethos, and claims he may even have supported Sarma had it not been for this aspect.

"The chief minister only does Hindu-Muslim politics. This is not what Assam is about. My neighbours from across the street are all Hindus and for decades we have sat together to enjoy meals, festivals and even everyday tea," says a visibly upset Rubul Hamid of Ghoga village in Nalbari. "The question is: who is an outsider, and not of Assamese origin. It has nothing to do with religion."

Clearly, while the ruling dispensation has been going to great lengths to change the political lexicon, what matters most to voters is quality of life, which will play a key part in determining the outcome of the election.

mint SHORT STORY

WHAT

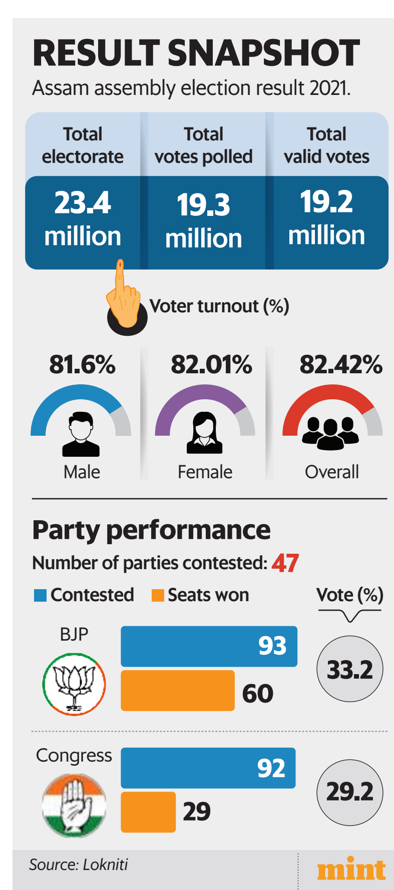
There is much at stake both for the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party and the main opposition Congress, and for the two state leaders leading these respective camps.

NOW

The BJP has unleashed a cocktail of welfarism in Assam. The construction of roads, highways and flyovers has also bolstered the image of the Sarma government.

BUT

The Congress party currently seems to be struggling with a cohesive and powerful narrative to counter the BJP. Its biggest hope now would be anti-incumbency.



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Tempted by defence and oil rallies? Experts urge caution

The war triggered sharp but short-lived rallies in defence and energy stocks. Tread carefully

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It's well-known that certain sectors respond strongly to geopolitical tensions. In 2003, the Iraq war sent defence and energy stocks soaring as investors anticipated increased military spending and volatile oil prices. Fast-forward to February 2026 and a similar pattern emerged, as pre-conflict optimism drove inflows into the defence and oil & gas sectors. While the dynamics aren't identical, the market's responsiveness to geopolitical developments remains unchanged.

The Nifty India Defence Index experienced sharp swings over the past six months, rallying towards 8,300 points in November 2025 before correcting to around 7,214 by 30 March, according to the National Stock Exchange website. Following the outbreak of war on 28 February, the index saw renewed investor interest, with episodic spikes of 2-3% in single session as defence stocks attracted focused buying amid expectations of higher sectoral spending.

In contrast, the Nifty Oil & Gas Index remained steadier, trading mostly between 10,000 and 11,500 and closing March around 10,788. Despite crude price volatility and geopolitical pressures, it delivered a modest one year return of around 2.2%, underscoring resilience without dramatic surges.

Market chatter on big bets has put these sectors in the spotlight, but it's crucial to understand how they have performed and how volatile they are.

Few spikes, instant corrections

Movements in the defence and energy sectors have been anything but linear. Prashant Mishra, founder and chief executive, Agnam Advisors, said, "Defence stocks saw an immediate sentiment-driven rally at the start of March as geopolitical tensions escalated, with another sharp spike around 6-7 March and a more pronounced move near 17 March, when the sector rose nearly 7%."

To put this into perspective, the Nifty India Defence Index returned 13.9% over the past year (1 April 2025 to 1 April 2026) excluding dividends, interests, and coupon payments.

However, this hasn't been a sustained trend. The pattern through the month has been one of intermittent spikes followed by corrections, highlighting volatility rather than strength. Importantly, the rally is not broad-based—only select stocks have participated. Much of the buying is driven by anticipation of higher defence spending, but there is no concrete data yet to support a structural or long-term uptrend.

Meanwhile, the Nifty Energy Index witnessed volatile, event-driven movements during the period. Rising West Asian tensions briefly pushed crude oil prices above $115 a barrel in early March. The index touched a peak of 37,181.8 on 26 February, but during March it traded in a relatively narrow range of about 34,800-36,800. It failed to sustain higher levels, reflecting broader market weakness and profit-booking after the late-February highs.

Rather than a sharp one-way rally, this index has also seen intermittent spikes and corrections. Despite geopolitical tailwinds, the one-year return remains in the low-to-mid teens, reflecting the sector's cyclical and volatile nature.

Avoid temptation

Rather than chasing sectoral opportunities via mutual funds, investors are better served by maintaining a diversified core portfolio. "The core portfolio must remain intact, with around 80% in diversified long-term allocations, while a small portion can be used to selectively participate in two to three opportunities," said Nehal Mota, co-founder and CEO, Finnovate, a Sebi-registered investment advisory firm.

Gaurav Santoshwar, a strategic debt advisor in Mumbai, follows a disciplined core-satellite strategy, keeping most investments in diversified mutual funds while allocating 5-10% tactically to defence or oil amid possible war-led rallies. He invests through flexible lump sums or SIPs in select funds, rotating allocations based on market conditions to capture short-term opportunities.

Perfect timing is rare

Sectoral funds typically see inflows after strong past performance, not before it. In other words, most investors jump in after the stocks have already rallied.

In the current environment, with increased news flow around defence spending and oil supply disruptions, there is a tendency for investors to chase recent winners. "This behaviour increases the probability of entering near peaks, especially since these sectors are sensitive to event reversals, such as easing tensions or corrections in crude prices," said Mishra.

"Sectoral investing requires precise entry and exit timing, which is inherently difficult even for experienced investors. For retail participants, such tactical calls often lead to suboptimal outcomes," said Priyanka Ketkar, a qualified personal finance professional and CEO of Purple Finch, a financial services firm.

Rather than chasing sectoral gains, investors are better served by maintaining a diversified core portfolio

While the early phase of the cycle often offers better entry points, missing it is not a concern if the core portfolio is well-positioned. Importantly, geopolitical events alone shouldn't drive decisions, and allocations should be guided by fundamentals like earnings visibility and balance sheet strength. "A more prudent approach is to remain aligned with long-term asset allocation and goal-based investing," said Ketkar.

Mayur Mandlekar, 48, director of commercial marketing and product management, at a multinational company, continues to stick to a diversified investment strategy despite recent war-driven volatility. "This strategy has worked well for me and has given me good returns. So I never felt the need to take tactical bets. Also, tactical bets mean you can win some and lose some."

Limit exposure, avoid hype

According to Mota of Finnovate, current data indicates that a significant portion of investor inflows followed the massive rally in defence stocks, occurring only after valuations had already stretched significantly through February 2026. NAV trends showed a significant portion of returns were delivered in the early phase, while March saw a decent reversal in valuations and NAVs. "Current levels still reflect higher-valuation entry points for these sectors. This increases the risk of compressed future returns and short-term volatility, especially for investors entering now."

For existing investors, experts recommended taking into account the cyclical nature of sectoral and thematic funds and avoiding over-concentration in a particular theme or sector.

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War rally or investment trap?

Retail investors should treat defence and energy funds as tactical bets with limited exposure. The core portfolio should remain invested in diversified mutual funds to better navigate market cycles.

Sectoral fund bets: why strategy matters more than hype

Strategy	Approach	Rationale
Tactical, not core	Treat sector funds as short-term tactical plays.	Driven by events, not steady long-term growth.
Protect the core	Keep most investments in diversified funds.	Limits the impact of sector volatility.
Core–satellite mix	Allocate only a small portion to sector bets.	Enables participation without excessive risk.
Avoid chasing momentum	Avoid entering after sharp rallies.	Risk of buying at peak valuations.
Disciplined entry and exit	Invest gradually and pre-plan exits.	Timing is difficult; reduces downside risk.
Rebalance periodically	Shift gains back into diversified assets.	Locks in profits and controls exposure.
Cap sector exposure	Avoid overexposure to one theme.	Reduces overall portfolio risk.
Ignore noise	Avoid reacting to headline-driven moves.	Prevents impulsive investment decisions.
Watch valuations	Be cautious in overheated sectors.	High valuations can cap future returns.
Stick to goals	Align investments with long-term asset allocation.	Ensures consistent and disciplined investing.

Geopolitical events can trigger sharp sector rallies, but they rarely create lasting investment trends.

"I maintain a strict core-satellite approach, keeping 90% in diversified funds while using small tactical allocations to capture short-term sector opportunities without risking portfolio stability."

GAURAV SANTOSHWAR (44)
Strategic debt adviser
Mumbai

"Consistency beats timing. I avoid the hype of sectoral shifts and focus on adding to a diversified portfolio during dips to ensure long-term disciplined growth."

MAYUR MANDLEKAR (44)
Director of commercial marketing and product management
Bengaluru

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GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

Why Indian expats in the UAE should plan cross-border Wills

Rohit Jain & Keshav Singhania

ISTOCKPHOTO

ASK MINT
ESTATE PLAN

I am a non-Muslim Indian living in Dubai. Given the geopolitical uncertainties, I wish to secure my estate through a will. What is the process of creating a will? And, are there any cross-border issues?

—Name withheld on request

The UAE has, in recent years, moved to bring much-needed clarity to how expatriate estates are handled. Federal Decree-Law No. 51 of 2024 and Personal Status Law No. 41 of 2024 have reshaped the succession landscape, particularly for non-Muslim residents. If a non-Muslim expatriate dies intestate but leaves behind family, the law now provides a straightforward default: the spouse receives 50% of the estate, with the balance divided equally among children, without gender distinction. In the absence of children, the estate passes to parents and then to siblings.

This is a clear departure from traditional Sharia-based ratios and reflects a more modern, globally aligned approach. Equally significant is how the law deals with heirless estates. Rather being tied up indefinitely, UAE assets, including real estate and business interests, may be transferred to regulated charitable endowment. For Indian expats in the UAE, a Will is less about formality and more about control.

The alternatives are well-established: DIFC, ADGM or onshore court such as Dubai Courts and Abu Dhabi Judicial Department. But the choice is not merely administrative.

DIFC and ADGM operate on common law principles and in English, making them accessible for expatriates and is better suited for structured estate plans. But, onshore courts are rooted in civil law processes and Arabic documentation—entirely workable, but more procedural in practice.

Registration costs also vary, with ADJD being cheaper than DIFC, which is the costliest at about AED 10,000-15,000.

Where this choice becomes critical is in cross-border estates. DIFC and ADGM Wills can, in certain cases, be structured to cover worldwide assets. Even then, jurisdictional boundaries remain unavoidable. While a UAE Will may clearly record testamentary intent, its enforceability outside the UAE will always be subject to local law.

On the other hand, an India-registered Will does not, by itself, secure assets situated in the UAE. Relying solely on an Indian Will may require probate in India followed by recognition proceedings before UAE courts—an approach that can be complex and uncertain under UAE civil law. Accordingly, maintaining separate, country specific Wills is advisable to avoid conflicts or delays.

Rohit Jain is managing partner, and Keshav Singhania is head, private client at Singhania & Co.

Do you have a personal finance query? Send in your queries at **mintmoney@livemint.com** and get them answered by industry experts.

Compare bank FD rates

Bank fixed deposits (FDs) continue to be popular investment products not just among senior citizens, who are looking for guaranteed income, but also among investors who can't stomach risk. But overexposure to FDs is not good, and you need to assess your asset allocation and goals to decide how much money you should park in them. For instance, saving for your child's higher education that's 15 years away through FDs may not be effective as the post-tax interest rate of an FD may not give you a real return (return that's above the rate of inflation). But if you plan to take a holiday in two years, an FD can help. Before choosing an FD, you should compare the interest rates on offer. Here is a list of banks that offer the highest FD rates for deposits up to ₹1 crore over various tenures.

Interest rates (%) for fixed deposits up to ₹1 crore

	6 months to < 1 year	1 to < 2 years	2 to < 3 years	3 to < 5 years	5 years and above
DCB Bank	6.00-6.50	**6.90-7.00**	6.90-7.15	**7.00-7.10**	7.00-7.15
YES Bank	4.75-6.50	**6.65-7.00**	6.90-7.00	**7.00**	6.75
RBL Bank	4.75-6.05	**7.00-7.20**	7.20	**7.00-7.20**	6.70
Jammu & Kashmir Bank	5.10-6.00	**6.70-6.75**	6.75-7.25	**6.65**	6.60
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	6.30-6.40	**6.60-7.10**	6.60	**6.60**	6.60
IndusInd Bank	5.00-6.25	**6.75-7.00**	6.90	**6.65-6.90**	6.50-6.65
Dhanlaxmi Bank	5.25	**6.25-6.95**	6.25-6.50	**6.50-7.00**	6.50-6.60
ICICI Bank	4.50-5.50	**6.25-6.30**	6.30-6.45	**6.45-6.50**	6.50
Axis Bank	5.50-5.75	**6.25-6.45**	6.45	**6.45**	6.45
Federal Bank	4.50-6.00	**6.25-6.70**	6.40	**6.40-6.75**	6.40
Karur Vysya Bank	6.00-6.65	**6.55-7.20**	6.55	**6.55**	6.25-6.55
Kotak Mahindra Bank	5.50-6.00	**6.50-6.70**	6.70	**6.40**	6.25
Canara Bank	5.25-5.50	**6.25-6.60**	6.25	**6.25**	6.25
City Union Bank	5.75-6.25	**6.50-7.00**	6.50	**6.25-6.50**	6.25
HDFC Bank	4.25-5.75	**6.25-6.45**	6.45	**6.40-6.50**	6.15-6.40
Indian Overseas Bank	4.75-5.50	**6.40-6.60**	6.40	**6.10**	6.10

Data taken from respective bank's website as on 6 April 2026; Only main entity of the merged banks are taken. Banks which merged with its main entity are removed from the table; The list of 16 banks is based on highest fixed deposit rates available for 5 years and above. Source: www.Bankbazaar.com

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HOW THE NEW CREDIT REPORTING CYCLE WILL REWIRE LOANS, EMIs AND APPROVALS

POWER POINT
ADITYA B.CHATTERJEE

We welcome your views and comments at **mintmoney@livemint.com**

When most people think about credit scores, they think of a credit card application. For years, the card has been the poster child of urban India's credit ecosystem. That framing is now outdated. A quiet shift is underway in the country's financial plumbing. Prodded by the Reserve Bank of India's push for higher-frequency reporting, lenders moved from monthly to fortnightly updates last year, and are set to shift to a weekly cycle from mid-year.

This is not just about faster approvals for premium cards. It is reshaping how home loans, auto loans, personal credit and even everyday EMIs are assessed, priced and approved.

The end of the "credit lag"

Until recently, India's lending system ran on a delay. Lenders reported to credit bureaus once a month, and financial behaviour—good or bad—took weeks to show up on a credit report. That lag has now been compressed. For borrowers, the implication is simple: the credit report is no longer a static snapshot but a near-live ledger. And the effects extend far beyond credit cards, touching every major credit decision in a consumer's life.

High-value loans

Consider a homebuyer trying to improve their debt-to-income ratio by prepaying a car loan. Earlier, it could take up to 45 days for that repayment to reflect in bureau data, resulting in lost property deals, delayed processing, or temporary rejections.

With high-frequency reporting, such changes show up in the next cycle. Borrowers can clean up their balance sheets and apply for large loans almost immediately. For lenders, it means they are underwriting based on the borrower's exact financial standing today, ensuring faster processing times, better interest rate negotiations, and smoother approvals for mortgages and auto loans.

Closing the door on loan stacking

At the other end of the market, the surge in unsecured lending, including personal loans and buy-now-pay-later products, has exposed a structural risk: loan stacking. In the old system, a borrower could take multiple loans from different lenders within days, exploiting reporting gaps. Lender B often had no visibility into a loan disbursed by Lender A just days earlier.

More frequent reporting narrows that window sharply, limiting over-leveraging across the system and, crucially, protecting vulnerable consumers from falling into compounding debt traps.

A new discipline for EMIs

For everyday borrowers, the shift demands tighter discipline. The cushion that once existed within a monthly reporting cycle has effectively disappeared. Previously, a borrower might delay an EMI by a week due to a temporary cash flow mismatch, hoping it wouldn't hit the monthly bureau reporting cycle.

Today, a missed payment will reflect on the next immediate incremental file. This swift reflection will directly impact their ability to access emergency credit, top-up loans, or consumer durables financing later that same month. Financial discipline must now be a continuous habit, not a monthly checkpoint.

Automating EMIs and maintaining adequate liquidity in auto-debit accounts is no longer best practice, it is essential.

Automating EMIs and maintaining adequate liquidity is now essential

What comes next

Weekly reporting is unlikely to be the end. India's digital financial infrastructure, from UPI to account aggregator framework, already operates in real time. The next step is likely to be daily, incremental updates rather than bulk submissions. Crucially, this future shift will be driven by incremental reporting rather than bulk data transfers. For example, if a borrower pays her EMI or clears a personal loan on a Tuesday, the lender will not need to resubmit its entire customer database on Wednesday.

Instead, banks will simply be pushing a daily incremental file—a "delta"—stating only the specific accounts that saw changes that day. This ensures the system remains fast and efficient without being overwhelmed by unnecessary data loads.

The bottom line

The shift to high-frequency reporting tightens discipline but also tilts the system in favour of borrowers who manage credit well. Good behaviour is recognized faster and risk is identified sooner. It also ensures that lenders can offer the right product, at the right price, at the exact moment of need. The future of lending in India is fast, precise, and highly personalized. As borrowers, it is time to look beyond the credit card and recognize that every financial decision—every loan, every EMI—is now shaping your financial identity in real time.

Aditya B Chatterjee is managing director at Equifax India

OUR VIEW

MINT

Kalpakkam: Get set for nuclear-fuel recycling

India's indigenous fast breeder reactor at this site has reached criticality. It marks a major milestone in our nuclear-power plan, signalling progress towards energy independence

India's prototype fast breeder reactor at Kalpakkam, Tamil Nadu, has gone 'critical,' heralding the second stage of a three-stage nuclear power generation programme envisaged by Homi J. Bhabha. When a reactor goes critical, it means that a single atomic fission event within it releases enough neutrons to produce exactly one other fission, on average. This is enough to sustain the process of breaking uranium into lighter elements, destroying some mass and creating energy at a rate defined by Einstein's famous equation, $E=mc^2$. If the fission is sub-critical, every fission of a uranium atom would not lead to another fission and the chain reaction would fizzle out. If the reactor goes super-critical, each fission would lead to multiple new fissions, sending the reactor into uncontrollable overdrive. The purpose of our fast breeder reactor is to use plutonium recovered from the spent fuel of first-stage fission reactors to 'breed' yet more plutonium. Once sufficient quantities of this stuff are produced, it can be used to interact with locally available thorium in the plan's third stage to produce uranium.

Consider the science of it. Thorium, uranium and plutonium all belong to a class of elements called 'actinides.' Bombarded under intense heat by neutrons in a nuclear reactor, uranium turns into plutonium. This plutonium exists in the spent fuel of a regular reactor; if it is not recovered, it renders this waste material highly radioactive and toxic, making disposal a challenge. However, once it is recovered, an oxidized version of it can be mixed with a uranium oxide to produce 'Mox' fuel for a fast breeder reactor. Fissile plutonium interacts with uranium and this mixture works like enriched uranium. In addition to energy, a fast breeder reactor produces a lot more of plutonium, which can be used to produce fresh batches of Mox and yet more plutonium. Once enough of it has been created, a uranium blanket over the reactor's core can be replaced with one of thorium; this can be turned into fissile uranium, which in turn would serve as fuel India's standard pressurized heavy water reactors (PHWRs). Think of it as fuel recycling.

Work on our fast breeder reactor began in the early 2000s, before the India-US nuclear deal of 2008 released us from the shackles of a tech-denial regime. So this fast breeder reactor's design and construction are indigenous. It has taken time, but India has gained notable expertise in this field to match its PHWR proficiency. Yet, a lobbying effort is underway that cites slow progress on our three-stage project to push for a technology under development in the US which would use a mix of high-assay low enriched uranium and thorium as fuel for PHWRs. Now that our prototype fast breeder reactor has attained criticality, we should ignore any attempt to kill this plan. Let's persist with the fast-breeder path we chose till its final stage. It will help minimize our need for uranium imports. In an uncertain world where vital supplies could be subject to geopolitical constraints and past understandings have been falling apart, it is crucial that we push for self-sufficiency to the extent possible. Recent reforms aimed at obtaining clean energy from nuclear plants have laid the ground for small modular reactors to be set up. These projects will be import-intensive but are welcome too. And if viable fusion reactors being developed in the US (and China) arrive in the meantime, that may be the only reason to abandon our homegrown nuclear energy programme.

THEIR VIEW

Philanthropic sapling planting can't fill in for carbon reduction

Industrial emissions must be slashed. This is not only an environmental but a business imperative

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Every year, some of India's largest industrial companies publish sustainability reports that are full of details on the number of trees planted, villages electrified and water bodies restored. And every year, the factories that made those reports possible continue to burn coal, run furnaces and emit carbon at rates that have barely changed in a decade. Both things are true. Neither cancels the other out. That is the uncomfortable part.

India's corporate sector has spent the decade since the enactment of the Companies Act of 2013 perfecting a particular kind of environmental sincerity. The law required large companies to spend 2% of their profits on initiatives for social good. The intention was sound. But for heavy industry like steel, cement, coal and chemicals, it created an unintended side-effect. It opened up a way to be seen as environmentally responsible without any change in how the business actually ran. Plant trees, fund solar panels in a village, restore a watershed, file the report and then move on. The factory that was a source of emissions stayed exactly as it was. This was a compliance exit from the harder question of what to do about carbon coming out of the chimney.

Only a small fraction of large listed companies have set any targets to reduce emissions from their core operations, while environmental corporate social responsibility (CSR) budgets have grown steadily. More troublingly, studies of corporate disclosure over the past decade suggest that heavier spending on environmental philanthropy has not translated to greater investment in an actual clean-up of industrial processes. In some analyses, the relationship ironically runs the other way. Therefore, philanthropy is not a complement to change. It is simply a pressure valve.

This pattern persists because the incentives made it rational. Afforestation is cheap, visible and easy to put in an annual report. Replacing a blast furnace process or retrofitting a cement kiln costs millions, carries technology risk and squeezes profits in the short term. As long as the rules reward the first and say nothing about the second, most companies will choose the first. This is not a moral failing. It is a predictable business response. Charity is not a first step. It's a detour.

Three things are now changing that calculation faster than most companies realize. The European Union's carbon tax, known as the Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM), has come into force this year. A few major goods exported to Europe are being charged for the carbon produced in making them. Indian steel and aluminium exporters, who have long competed partly by not paying for their emissions, are facing a direct price penalty. As much as 20% of India's steel exports could be materially affected. It is a straightforward commercial problem, with no reputational cushion.

At home, India's carbon credit trading scheme is setting up a carbon market. Once carbon carries a price in rupees, the financial case for investing in cleaner processes will improve on its own, without any need for persuasion based on principle. Moreover, the Securities and Exchange Commission's Business Responsibility and Sustainability Reporting requirement asks India's top 1,000 listed companies to disclose actual operational emissions alongside their CSR spending in the same document. For the first time, analysts and investors can put both numbers on the same page.

Estimates of unpriced carbon risk sitting on the balance sheets of India's largest industrial emitters run into trillions. The tardy efforts of Indian industry to decarbonize require no new rules, but three fixes.

One, redirect about a quarter of all environmental CSR budgets towards cutting emissions within a company's own supply chain—cleaner suppliers, less carbon-heavy logistics and energy efficiency in ancillary units. The money has already been set aside. It just needs to go elsewhere.

Two, apply an internal carbon price to every investment decision. Firms that apply a shadow carbon price of, say, $40-80 per tonne to investment decisions choose cleaner technologies more often when given the choice. A number in a spreadsheet changes the conversation in ways that a sustainability strategy document rarely does.

Three, tie executive pay to emission reduction targets. Companies that linked a meaningful share of senior pay to emission-reduction targets are found to have cut their operational carbon intensity much faster than those that did not. Incentives work—in finance, sales or decarbonization.

India's industrial base is large enough for the handling of this transition to matter beyond the country's borders. The companies that move early will find cheaper capital, open export markets and hold a stronger competitive position. Those that keep filing sustainability reports full of proclamations on saplings while leaving their furnaces untouched will eventually face a reckoning with irate regulators, investors or trade partners. These businesses should choose to act while they still can. That window will not stay open indefinitely.

10 YEARS AGO


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LANDMARK LEGISLATION

Rajasthan first to pass 'titling' law

The Rajasthan Urban Land (Certification Of Titles) Bill, 2016, was passed through a voice vote on Monday

Raje wins the 'title' on reforms

EIGHT INDIANS IN ASIA'S MOST POWERFUL BUSINESSWOMEN LIST

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SC directs Vijay Mallya to disclose all assets

QUICK EDIT
Transfers racket

Facebook goes hyperlocal in India with services site

TACKLING COMPETITION
Micromax shifts focus from phones to services

Aptel gives some relief to power firms

JUST A THOUGHT

> This advanced reactor [at Kalpakkam], capable of producing more fuel than it consumes, reflects the depth of our scientific capability and the strength of our engineering enterprise.
>
> NARENDRA MODI

THEIR VIEW

No work, all play: Musk's prophecy may not come true

ATANU BISWAS

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Elon Musk has predicted that in 10 to 20 years, work will become optional. He has done this umpteen times—in response to a *New York Times* article about Amazon, at a US-Saudi investment forum, in a conversation with Zerodha's Nikhil Kamath, at Viva Technology 2024 in Paris and the 2023 AI Safety Summit in Bletchley Park. "It'll be like playing sports or a video game or something like that," Musk said. He also likened having a job to the more time-consuming task of farming a vegetable garden instead of going grocery shopping.

Musk believes that robots and artificial intelligence (AI) will deliver any goods and services you desire. In his view, humanoid robots like Tesla's Optimus may grow to be the biggest industry. According to Musk, AI and robotics could usher in an era in which all people are "far wealthier than the richest person on Earth." Additionally, Musk has stated, "We probably won't have money, and probably we will just have energy [and] power generation as *de facto* currency." Musk, however, admitted that we must ensure that AI has a strong concern for truth and beauty.

The English economist John Maynard Keynes made some daring and fascinating predictions in his 1930 article, 'Economic Possibilities for Our Grandchildren'. Keynes foresaw a huge increase in earnings over the course of the following century as well as an unparalleled period of leisure brought about by improved standards of living during which people would "do more things for ourselves... only too glad to have small duties and tasks and routines."

"Three hours a day is quite enough to satisfy the old Adam in most of us!" Keynes remarked. But Musk now predicts a workless old Adam!

A future without jobs would be more dystopian than utopian; as one might imagine, civilization would strive to survive.

From the invention of wheels to the introduction of machines in Nottingham's textile industry, and from steam engines to electricity, the history of human civilization shows that technological revolutions not only increase productivity but also transfer some human labour to machines that humans have created, thereby reducing human workloads. Isn't AI just another technology that will reduce the need for human labour in some ways? Also, in 2019, Chinese billionaire Jack Ma predicted that people may work as little as three days a week and four hours a day in the next 10-20 years, thanks to technological advancements and changes in educational systems.

There has undoubtedly been a significant shift in work hours since the Industrial Revolution, when workers put in 10-16 hours a day. A century ago, in 1926, Henry Ford converted the typical six-day workweek to a five-day one. Will AI's magic wand finally cause the seismic transformation in workplace culture that Keynes foresaw in his famous essay? Or would it fundamentally change to the degree that Musk has been forecasting?

> **Keynes' forecast of far greater income, living standards and leisure time looks a lot more realistic**

Scottish author Iain M. Banks' 'Culture' series of sci-fi novels, published between 1987 and 2012, serve as inspiration for Musk's automated, job-voluntary future, with money not being an issue. The self-described socialist author imagined a post-scarcity society where human labour is voluntary, AI ensures abundance and humanoid aliens as well as superintelligent AI bots are dispersed throughout the Milky Way galaxy. Elon Musk may well have been inspired by Banks' concept since he was a student. In essence, Musk may believe that AI will lead to a Banksian 'space socialism'.

"In those books, money doesn't exist," Musk once observed. "It's kind of interesting."

Well, Culture's universe is appealing and emotionally plausible, even though the anticipated AI advancements might take centuries or millennia to materialize rather than decades.

According to Musk, since everyone will have access to this magic genie, AI will act as a kind of leveller. But didn't he tell Twitter employees in November 2022 to be ready for 80-hour workweeks amid a tumultuous start to his leadership at the company? More recently, Tesla announced Musk's $1 trillion pay package (though payable only if some targets are met). And how challenging will it be to develop an AI that's "maximally truth-seeking?"

Robots so far have proven expensive, making them difficult to scale, even as the cost of AI is declining, according to a new working paper by the University of Pennsylvania's Konrad Kording and Ioana Marinescu, who presented a novel framework for assessing AI and the future of work. "AI transformation will be significant yet bounded, not infinite," they contend.

There are many experts who do not agree with Musk's prediction that AI will ransform the workplace beyond recognition. After Musk's remarks in Bletchley Park, Mustafa Suleyman, a British AI researcher and co-founder of DeepMind, said in 2023, "I think that certainly over a 50-year period, we should be concerned."

While Musk's vision of full-scale automation may partly be the future, AI adoption in the workplace is still not happening as quickly as anticipated, despite recent rounds of tech-related layoffs.

Thus, rather than confirming the Muskian prognosis, an AI-driven global labour market may lend credence to a Keynesian scenario. The future that Keynes had in mind was around 2030, right?

MY VIEW | CAFE ECONOMICS

Why a crude oil crisis could play out differently this time around

India's economy, like the world's, is structurally less vulnerable than in the 70s but policymakers must still pay close attention

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BLOOMBERG

The ongoing war in West Asia has cast a pall of uncertainty over the global economy. The disruptions in energy supplies have begun to ripple through supply chains across the world. In its latest monthly review of the Indian economy, the finance ministry has noted: "Recent shocks are being transmitted through higher input costs, supply constraints and pressures across sectors, with early indications of some moderation in economic activity."

For economic policymakers, managing a disruption in supply is far more complicated than responding to a sudden shift in demand. The reason is simple. In the case of a demand shock, both output and prices move in the same direction. For example, a sudden drop in demand in an economy will lead to slower growth as well as lower inflation. The textbook solution of stimulating the economy through lower interest rates as well as higher government spending usually works well.

Supply shocks are very different. Output and prices move in different directions. For example, a shortage of supplies means that economic activity slows down while inflation moves up. The textbook solutions lose their bite in these extraordinary situations, creating tricky choices between either supporting growth or taming price increases.

A lot will depend on how long the war will last. The best strategy right now would be for the government to absorb some of the initial price increases through either tax cuts or higher subsidies, while the Reserve Bank of India waits along the sidelines. It will be less neat in case the supply shock lasts through the year.

Policymakers, companies, investors and economists will obviously be keeping a close eye on how economic growth and inflation behave in the months ahead. The general expectation is that economic activity will lose some momentum while price pressures will increase. The final effect on both fronts will be tough to assess since war disruptions are still playing out and the impact could be non-linear in case there are physical shortages of key inputs, both for industry as well as agriculture.

Does economic history offer any clues? The first major oil shock that hit the global economy was in October 1973. Oil prices quadrupled in a short span of time after West Asian petroleum exporters imposed a severe embargo on shipments after the Yom Kippur war of some Arab states with Israel.

The Indian economy went through a harrowing time. Consumer price inflation averaged 23% a year over the next two years. Economic growth was a modest 4.6% in 1973-74. It then went into negative territory the next year. Growth in nominal gross domestic product (GDP) was 22.6% that year and 17.7% in 1974-75. What this means is that the sharp rise in nominal GDP was because of higher prices rather than an increase in output. Stagflation, in other words.

The next oil shock came in 1979 after the Islamic revolution in Iran and start of the Iran-Iraq war. Nominal GDP expanded by a modest 9.1% in 1979-80 and then a sharp 19.5% the next year. India had double-digit inflation in both these years. The economy contracted by 5.2% in real terms in 1979-80. It bounced back the following year, with a real growth rate of 7.2%.

However, harsh lessons from those two oil shocks have to be tempered with one other fact. India was unlucky to face energy shortages even as droughts hit agricultural production in these two periods. So high inflation as well as muted economic growth was the result of a twin battering that the governments of the day had no direct control over. Agriculture is now a much smaller part of the Indian economy compared to 1973 and 1979, and food stocks are far more comfortable. This is important given early warnings of an El Niño year, which signals dry conditions. However, on the other side, India uses far more fossil fuel energy than it did back then.

The other lesson comes a year closer to our times. Soaring international crude oil prices were one reason why India's nominal growth was 18.7% in 2010-11. Consumer price inflation averaged 12.2% that year. Unlike 1973 or 1979, global oil prices were pushed up by red-hot economic growth in countries such as China and India as well speculative buying fuelled by a wave of cheap money unleashed by central banks in the aftermath of the North Atlantic Financial Crisis in 2008. The main lesson here is that inflation was not the result of restrictions on energy supplies but also of loose macroeconomic policies.

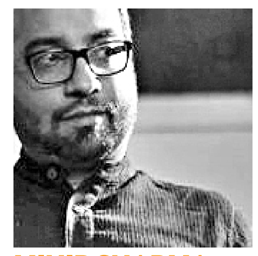
A look at the data since 1970 shows that there is a negligible relationship between global oil prices on one hand and nominal economic growth on the other. Data points scatter, with no clear pattern. The line of best fit has a slope so gentle that it is barely meaningful. India has grown rapidly with oil at $15 a barrel and equally rapidly with oil at $110.

However, this overall benign story hides what happened during severe energy shocks—in 1973-74, 1980-81, 1990-91 and 2021-22. A lot will depend on the details. Is the world facing a supply shock or a demand shock? Are there any other exogenous blows, such as a hit to food production? How dependent are economies on oil? And how will economic policy respond to these dislocations?

MINT CURATOR

Trump is making China look like a better bet for the world

Pax Americana has been unreliable but Chinese wares have helped



MIHIR SHARMA
is a Bloomberg Opinion columnist.

Relying upon Beijing may not turn out to be any safer eventually. ISTOCKPHOTO

For at least a decade, developing countries across Asia and Africa have worried about growing dependent on the People's Republic of China. They're concerned about debt traps, coercive policies and hidden costs that might push their economies toward crisis.

Crisis has come, and that logic has been turned on its head. After six weeks of the US and Israel's war on Iran and its ensuing counter-attacks, it is the countries that bet on Chinese supply chains that are faring better than the ones that had trusted Pax Americana.

Consider Pakistan. By now it should have been in the middle of yet another economic and social implosion. It has always been vulnerable to energy price shocks, given that it imports almost all of its energy, much of it through the Strait of Hormuz. The country has $130 billion in external debt and a persistent current account deficit and so the slightest nudge should have tipped it over into a familiar spiral: emergency requests to the International Monetary Fund, 18-hour power blackouts, unrest on the streets.

None of that is visible. There are signs of stress, certainly. Islamabad has hiked fuel prices and is reportedly planning to shut off electricity for two to three hours each day. A sustained shortage of liquid natural gas will make it hard to keep power plants running. But, compared to the situation just a few years ago—when, after the Russian invasion of Ukraine, the economy had a full-scale meltdown—it's showing remarkable resilience.

What's the difference? Chinese-made solar panels. Pakistanis have gleefully transitioned to solar power, importing about 17 gigawatts a year of photovoltaics since 2024. A quarter of households have installed solar panels for their own use.

Islamabad didn't even have to spend too much money subsidizing the renewables rollout. It just had to ride Chinese overcapacity and make it work for Pakistani citizens by keeping tariffs low. The price of imported solar panels dropped by almost 60% in 2024-25; Beijing's subsidies kept Chinese factories humming but also financed the electrification of millions of households across Pakistan.

Many other countries made the opposite choice in order to insulate domestic production or minimize political risk. Those that tried to keep cheap Chinese photovoltaic cells out have seen much slower rates of uptake—and are, in consequence, far more exposed to chaos in the Gulf.

Nor are solar panels the only way in which cheap Chinese goods are turning out to be sources of resilience rather than disruption. Nepal has a higher proportion of electric vehicles (EVs) than any other country in the world, barring Norway. Its huge imported fleet of cheap EVs mean that it is far less worried about petrol prices than most of its Asian neighbours. And they run on clean electricity, emerging from a hydropower infrastructure that is financed in part by Beijing.

It's not hard to imagine policymakers from across the developing world looking at examples like these and concluding that betting on Beijing isn't actually the riskier option. Some may already have taken that chance; imports of Chinese solar panels have shot up in the past couple of years across sub-Saharan Africa in particular. If the only options are dependence on predictably mercantilist Beijing and on an erratic, self-centred and disruptive US, the choice is obvious.

That may turn out to be the wrong call. It is not wise to imagine that relying upon Beijing's goodwill is any safer. In just the past year, China has shown its willingness to weaponize control over supply chains, such as the production of magnets and rare earths.

But right now, the contrast is glaring. Countries that believed that the world's open trading order, underpinned by American hegemony, would protect them from shocks are struggling; those who chose to run the risk of dependence upon Chinese imports and infrastructure are showing unexpected resilience.

This will only get worse if the US withdraws from the Gulf without making an effort to reopen the Strait of Hormuz. Then the lesson the world learns is even harsher: America will make decisions about your energy supply, take no responsibility for the consequences, and then leave. China will sell you the technology that allows you to stop caring about what the US does.

This is a far greater geopolitical setback to the US than a loss of face in the Iran war might be. The US president may have thought that he would be remembered as the one who restored American greatness by solving long-running problems—Venezuela, Iran, perhaps Cuba. Instead, it looks like he'll be remembered as the president who lost Asia to China.

MY VIEW | EX MACHINA

Rethink the changes proposed for India's internet rules

RAHUL MATTHAN

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On 30 March, the ministry of electronics and information technology (MeitY) published draft amendments to the Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines) Rules, 2021, which, if passed, will have far-reaching consequences for internet users in India. While each of the three primary amendment proposals does something different, together they will transform the internet from a rules-based regime into one governed by discretion. Though they may seem benign, their bite could be worse than their bark.

The new Rule 14(2) would expand the powers of the Inter-Departmental Committee (IDC) from hearing just "complaints and grievances" to "any matter" referred directly by the ministry. Rule 8 takes things further by not just expanding adjudicatory power, but who is subject to it—from 'publishers' to anyone who posts about news online. But both these pale in relation to Rule 3(4), which reshapes the source of legal authority.

Let's go through each provision to better understand how they will all affect us.

Let us start with Rule 14. Through a set of innocuous adjustments, sub-rule (2) will significantly expand the powers of the IDC. From being an apex appellate body in a three-tier complaint-resolution mechanism for violations of the Code of Ethics, it could become a super-regulator with the power to hear just about "any matter" that the ministry refers to it.

There are two problems with this. First, since the IDC would have the power to rule on anything the ministry sends it, the recommendations it issues could well exceed the statutory authority under which it was created. But what's far worse is that by accepting references directly from the ministry, parties could be denied the two levels of appeal they are currently entitled to, thus collapsing the current three-tier mechanism into a single executive-controlled process. With this one amendment alone, the government could end up violating principles of both administrative law and natural justice.

It is worth noting that in August 2021, the Bombay High Court stayed the Code of Ethics framework as *prima facie* violative of Article 19(1)(a) of the Constitution of India—a prohibition subsequently extended by the Madras High Court. In this backdrop, for the inter-departmental panel to operate within this now tenuous structure would expand its powers even as the constitutionality of the framework itself remains under litigation and is questionable.

This brings us to Rule 8(1). As originally drafted, this provision applied only to "publishers of news and current affairs content" and "publishers of online curated content." In other words, regular news outlets, as well as their online equivalents. The proposed amendment will extend the applicability of certain provisions to ordinary users who share news or current affairs content. Since sharing posts about news is something we all do, this means that a provision earlier designed for news organisations will now apply to you and me. In effect, the Code of Ethics, a standard of accuracy, fairness and impartiality with which news organizations must comply, could get extended to ordinary internet users who have neither the resources nor the inclination to vet everything they post at this level of rigour.

They will give the executive discretionary power and make life harder for regular users of online platforms

But it is the proposed addition of a new sub-Rule (4) to Rule 3 that in many ways is the most disappointing. This new provision seeks to legally elevate clarifications, advisories, orders, directions, standard operating procedures, codes of practice and guidelines to the level of rules and regulations (the only forms of subordinate legislation that the executive branch is constitutionally permitted to enact). If brought into force, it will allow the executive to make a new law without calling it a law, and, in doing so, arrogate upon itself the power and authority that ought to vest with the legislature. Or at the very least be subject to Parliamentary supervision.

The power of the executive branch to make rules and regulations is always subject to an obligation to place them before Parliament as soon after they have been made as possible. By elevating various informal executive instruments of this kind to the level of enforceable law—none of which need to be laid before the legislative branch—the government seems to be trying to evade a necessary constitutional check on its power.

What makes these regressive proposals particularly disappointing is that they were released for public consultation just three days after the Jan Vishwas Bill was introduced in the Lok Sabha. The latter, as many have noted, is the single largest horizontal decriminalization effort anywhere in the world, significantly improving the ease of doing business across sectors. Central to this deregulation effort is the principle of regulatory certainty it embodies—that the state should not impose compliance obligations on citizens through instruments that do not carry the weight of the law. For the government to just a few days later introduce amendments that do just that shows how little the left hand appears to know of what the right is doing.

I am the first to admit how hard it is to govern modern online spaces and these proposed amendments are an attempt to walk a well-known tightrope between allowing free expression online and preventing the harms that can result. But if we cannot find a more effective way to strike that balance, we will replace a system governed by rules with one ruled by executive discretion.

When a smartphone becomes a collectible

As rumours of an iPhone Fold get stronger, Apple may have already given us a preview with the Air. Is the thinnest iPhone now a future collectible?

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Around 2016, India's smartphone market started taking a leaf out of an earlier era when Nokia, Sony Ericsson, Motorola, and BlackBerry ruled the industry. They started trying to innovate on designs, albeit within the confines of smartphone factories trying to eke out every penny of efficiency out of industrial standardization.

That craze to create outlandish designs in smartphones died quickly, and what followed were years of a race to cram the most amount of silicon power and high-resolution displays into everyday devices. Something, however, changed in 2025, when both Apple and Samsung, which account for two of every five phones sold worldwide, launched ultra-thin flagships.

These 5mm phones, somehow, didn't result in an instant craze. Samsung's Galaxy S25 Edge went almost under the radar, as Samsung swiftly moved its ultra-thin form factor to its foldables.

The iPhone Air by Apple, however, is a different story.

FOLDING RUMOURS

For years, industry insiders have shared rumours about Apple testing internal engineering sketches of a foldable smartphone. This, to be sure, has not materialized yet, but such rumours are not without precedent.

For instance, in September 2016, Apple launched for the first time a smartphone with two cameras on it—the iPhone 7 Plus. Back then, the smartphone market was rife with speculation around how Apple was behind the curve—almost every phone-maker had released phones with multiple cameras already.

Yet, when Apple finally brought in the two-camera iPhone 7 Plus, it standardized the now-ubiquitous 'portrait mode' photography across the industry. Most Apple watchers agreed at the time that the company does not rush into introducing new features, but when it does so, Apple often produces a better product better than its competitors.

The iPhone Air, however, is not quite the same. It isn't trying to bring slim phones back in vogue, and users carrying it as their everyday driver agree that Apple seems fully self-aware of the constraints of a single-camera smartphone photography system in the modern world.

What it is instead, is a smartphone that comes as a stopgap measure before Apple steps into the foldable smartphone world. On Monday, a report from supply chain analysts in China circulated widely. It stated that Apple's much-awaited iPhone Fold has moved into the final production stage, ahead of a potential launch in September this year.

"There is a strong chance that the iPhone Air is not a new product line by itself, but a proof of what Apple is capable of, before the company releases its iPhone Fold later this year," said Navkendar Singh, associate vice-president at market research and consultancy firm, International Data Corporation.

Others have noted this too. Between October and February, Japan's Mizhuo Securities and Nikkei both reported in brokerage notes to investors that the iPhone Air's production targets have been slashed. The reports also claimed that a second run for the lineup, for now, looks delayed at least.

What, therefore, could the iPhone Air really stand for, given that it might not enjoy a long run into the future?

THE JOYS OF A LIMITED-RUN DEVICE

It is this very factor of limited volumes that could make the iPhone Air the underrated collector's edition device with which Apple may have unintentionally marked its 50th anniversary.

Over time, Apple's product philosophy has been largely driven by the seamlessness of design. Notable products that evolved into collectibles include the click-wheel on iPod Classic, and the first iPhone that standardized the touchscreen. In both cases, each product gave birth to entire industries.

The Air may become a classic like the OG iPhone, the iPod and the iPhone 7 Plus.

The iPhone Air has the hallmarks of such a device. It measures a hair over 5mm in thickness, and packs in pretty much every feature of any other flagship iPhone, but comes with the added edge of its limited supplies and sales.

In the long run, if the iPhone Air is shown the door after a one-year run, it will almost certainly be marked as a 50th anniversary special: A device that showcased Apple's design prowess, didn't fight the specifications war, had unique quirks and flaws that collectibles are often dotted with, and in future, could emerge as a device that will be cool to be spotted with.

To begin with, the iPhone Air's real-world battery life shortcomings means that one has to also invest in an external power bank. Then there are the constraints with the iPhone Air's portrait mode; and the telephoto zoom—even with Apple's algorithm-driven software—is not among the best.

Yet, the iPhone Air doesn't try to be the best in terms of specifications. Instead, it provides a glimpse of what modern smartphones can be, and the extent of miniaturization and precision engineering that the world's smartphone supply chain is capable of pulling off. Multiple durability tests hailed how the iPhone Air has perhaps the strongest chassis of the entire 2025 iPhone lineup by Apple. The internal motherboard assembly, as teardown and dissection reports have shown, leaned into ease of repairability.

What Apple therefore showcased with the iPhone Air is how it is readying itself for a world where foldable smartphones could be durable, and pack in every feature without making a compromise.

THE LONG-TERM PICTURE

Even seven months since its release, spotting an iPhone Air out in the open prompts a second glance. It still sparks curiosity, although understandably, buying an iPhone 17 makes for sound consumer preference. In such a market, those who own the iPhone Air could well end up owning a device that, in the long run, becomes a rarity.

As smartphones move to large screens, bulky cameras and folding designs, the iPhone Air could well mark the last of an era before mixed reality and holographs also merge with modern-day smartphone design. At the same time, the Air will have done so not by being a relic, but as a clear and evident bridge between the past and future of smartphone design.

For the past, the iPhone Air harks back to a rear glass panel and a single camera that was expected to do everything for on-the-go quick snaps. For the future, the 5mm body of the iPhone Air provides proof of concept that engineering has evolved enough to pack AI-ready computing power into a tin body.

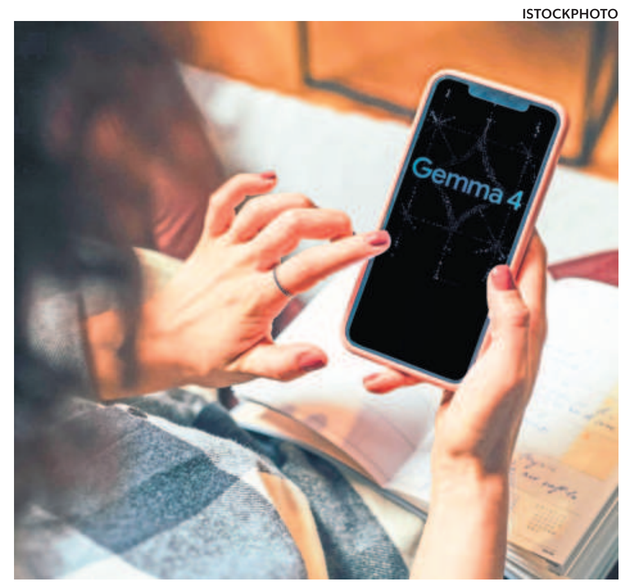
If things indeed go the way brokerage firms highlight, the iPhone Air will become a 50th-year collectible, an engineering feat that proved what smartphones were meant to be: simple.

AI TRACKER

Google, OpenAI and Anthropic make big moves

New open AI models, a media business and biotech investments in focus

ISTOCKPHOTO



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GOOGLE RELEASES NEW 'OPEN AI' MODELS

Once upon a time, it was hoped that all AI models would be free—they'd be focused more on the public good than on making profits. That utopian idea has died a quiet death, but the dream of open source AI tools hasn't gone away. A few days ago Google unveiled Gemma 4, that can be downloaded and shaped by developers using an Apache 2.0 license. Gemma 4's models can handle coding, complex reasoning and real-world tasks. They are also supposed to be light enough to be run on laptops and phones. There are four sizes to the models, and analysts believe that being open, these models can run directly on devices, and perhaps even without requiring an internet connection.

AFP

OPENAI BUYS A TECH TALKSHOW

OpenAI, meanwhile, has bought the popular tech talk show *TBPN*, marking its entry into the media business. The financial terms of the deal have not been disclosed, but OpenAI sees the acquisition as a means to shape a positive narrative about ChatGPT and CEO Sam Altman. The talk show, hosted by John Coogan and Jordi Hays, is known for its industry interviews, and is closely followed by Silicon Valley insiders. Altman is known to be a fan of the show, and his association with Coogan is an old one, including when Coogan was at Y Combinator, a startup incubator where Altman was president. OpenAI insists that *TBPN* will operate with full editorial freedom, but the company's chief of strategy, Fidji Simo also said the acquisition will help the company engage better with the public about AGI.

ANTHROPIC ENTERS HEALTHCARE

OpenAI's great rival Anthropic, in turn, has entered the healthcare space, by buying AI biotech startup Coefficient Bio for $400 billion, according to media reports. This is in line with Anthropic's stated intent to build industry-specific AI tools, especially when it comes to medicine and life-sciences in general. Coefficient Bio works with a specialized agenda, looking to manage biotech workflows such as drug research and discovery, as well as developing regulatory strategies.

REVIEW | NOTHING PHONE (4A) PRO

The design disruptor takes a step towards the mainstream

The Nothing Phone (4a) Pro is a capable device that is as convenient for daily use as it is unique in its looks

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For a few years now, Nothing has mastered the art of standing out in a sea of boring glass slabs with the transparent design, the Glyph lights, the avant-garde software aesthetic. To use a Nothing Phone still feels like a design studio has wandered into the smartphone market.

Yet, identifying as the refreshing, playful and occasionally quirky alternative to the norm can only get you so far, and with the Nothing Phone (4a) Pro (₹39,999 onwards), Nothing has quietly shifted. The brand is now signalling an interest in making an actual better phone, not just one that's interesting.

The Phone (4a) Pro feels barely related to the budget 4a that it was launched alongside, or previous Nothing phones for that matter. Trading the "look inside me" party trick for a more grounded aluminium unibody design, the (4a) Pro looks and feels premium, particularly in the fetching silver colourway that gives off strong retro tool vibes (you get black and pink options as well). And it works—it's a classy, yet far more normal look that I'd wager many folks would like, opening Nothing up to a wider market. In hand, the slim 7.9mm profile and matte finished edges make the otherwise large phone easy to grip, and there's a small dimple on the bottom-left corner to help you fish the phone out of the pocket more easily. Gorilla Glass 7i screen protection and IP65 rating take care of accidental drops and splashes.

Nothing's signature see-through styling makes an appearance on the device-spanning camera bump. You're likely to notice the massive Glyph Matrix LED array, which is over 50% larger and twice as bright than the one on the pricier Phone (3). You get fewer mini-LEDs, and there's no glyph button on the back, but it is plenty enough for scrolling text, custom notification symbols and status/progress indicators, plus some community-provided Glyph Toys.

With so much going on the back panel, it's good to see Nothing has lavished some attention to the 6.83in, 1260 X 2800-pixel flexible-AMOLED display. Not only does the screen have skinnier bezels than most

of its mid-range peers, but it also does one better compared with the flagship Phone (3)—it's bigger, offers a higher adaptive refresh rate (up to 144Hz) and with a higher peak brightness while playing back HDR content. Coupled with the stereo speaker setup, the (4a) is a solid content consumption device, although some may prefer to dial down the colours to "Standard" if the "Alive" preset is a bit too punchy and vibrant for their taste.

On the performance front, the (4a) Pro is expectedly more of a mid-ranger, with the Snapdragon 7 Gen 4 chipset only a small step up from the Phone (4a) and about the same as its segment peers. What this translates to is the ability to handle games such as *Call of Duty: Mobile* at high settings, and heavier titles as *Genshin Impact* at medium settings if you're the sort for extended gaming sessions; the larger vapour chamber cooling system can only do so much.

Elsewhere, the (4a) Pro is a smooth everyday device, and it is able to reliably handle moderate-to-heavy workloads. Nothing OS 4.1 is clean and free of preloaded apps—just Facebook and Instagram—and what it misses out on heavy customization, it more than makes up via extensive widget support.

During my daily use, the 5,400mAh lithium-ion battery lasted well past the five-hour mark, which is good enough for casual gaming, browsing, streaming and social media. There's no charger in the box for the 50W fast charging, and no wireless charging due to the all-metal body.

When it comes to cameras, the (4a) Pro sports a 50MP primary camera, a 50MP periscope 3.5x telephoto and an 8MP ultrawide, plus a 32MP punch-hole selfie camera up front. The 3.5x optical zoom gives Nothing a solid edge over rivals that opt for sensor cropping to zoom in on the image, and the ability to punch in to near-lossless 7x zoom makes this a rather versatile camera setup. Shots from the telephoto do a good job capturing sharp images in daylight, and they're no pushovers even in low light (the images come out a little over-sharpened though).

Lining up along the primary shooter—which manages good detail and excellent dynamic range in daylight and social media-ready shots in low light—you get a capable one-two combo, and Nothing's showing big strides in getting image processing right. The ultrawide and the selfie cameras are just about passable. The community-made camera presets are a must-try.

VERDICT

The Nothing Phone (4a) Pro is very much still a Nothing device, even as the design and personality matures to cater to a wider audience, making it more practical, accessible and usable for everyday users. At ₹39,999 the (4a) Pro model justifies the added outlay over the 4a with bumped up performance, better cameras, a premium metal chassis and a useful Glyph Matrix display. Notably, the cameras have gotten better, the software experience is still top-notch, and the performance is good enough for the average user. For long, Nothing has known how to make you look twice, and the Phone (4a) Pro might finally be one that will make you stay.

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